

Prayer in the Dark

Talking to God When You Are Not Sure Anyone Is Listening

JAMES BELL

Prayer in the Dark

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The Spirit helps us in our weakness. We do not know what to pray for as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words.

PAUL, ROMANS 8

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INTRODUCTION

The Prayers That Hit the Ceiling

I HAVE PRAYED PRAYERS that went nowhere. I need you to know that before we go any further, because most books on prayer are written by people who seem to have never had the experience, or who have decided not to mention it. They begin at the destination. They describe a room I have stood outside of, cold, with my hand on a door that would not open. If that is where you are, I am not going to pretend I have never been there. I have prayed in the dark. I am writing this from inside it, not from the far side.

There is a particular sound a prayer makes when it stops at the ceiling. You will know it if you have heard it. It is not a sound, really. It is the absence of one. You say the words, out loud or under your breath, and they rise about as far as the light fixture and then they are just words in a room, and the room is quiet, and you are aware, suddenly and completely, of how quiet it is. You wonder if anyone is there. You wonder if you have been talking to yourself this whole time, the way a man in an empty house talks to a dog that died last spring out

of a habit his mouth has not yet unlearned. I have had that thought at two in the morning. I have had it standing over a hospital bed. I have had it, God help me, in the pulpit, mid-sentence, while leading three hundred people in a prayer I was no longer sure I believed anyone was receiving.

I came to God late and from the outside. I was an atheist, a real one, not the polite agnostic who keeps a pew warm out of nostalgia. I believed there was no one there, and I had good company, and I was not unhappy about it. So when I say I know the suspicion that prayer is a man talking to the ceiling, I am not performing a doubt I overcame long ago as a rhetorical warm-up. I lived years inside that suspicion. And here is the thing I did not expect, the thing no one warned me about when I crossed over. Coming to faith did not end the suspicion. It relocated it. Before, I was sure no one was listening and it did not trouble me. After, I hoped someone was listening, and the silence, when it came, troubled me to the bone. Faith did not remove the possibility that I was talking to no one. It raised the stakes of the possibility.

I was also raised without a father. I mention this not to invite you into my griefs but because it is load-bearing for what follows. A boy who grows up calling out and getting no answer learns something in his body about calling out. He learns to expect the silence before he opens his mouth. When Jesus taught his followers to begin their praying with the word Father, he was not, for me, handing me a comfortable image. He was reaching straight into the wound. Some of you will find that the tenderest word in the language. Some of you will find it the hardest. I have found it both, on different days, and I no longer trust anyone who has found it only easy.

So let me say what this book is not, because you have been

burned before and I want to spare you the slow disappointment of discovering it three chapters in. This is not a book that will teach you to pray so that it works. It is not a technique. It is not a set of steps that, correctly performed, produce the result you are after. There are books like that, whole shelves of them, and some of them are written by sincere people, and I think, on the whole, they do more harm than good, because they leave the reader who prays correctly and gets nothing convinced that the failure is his. He did the steps. The steps did not work. Therefore he is the broken part. That is a cruelty dressed as encouragement, and I will not do it to you.

What this book is, is honest. It takes aim at the hard parts and does not flinch. Unanswered prayer, the real kind, the prayer you prayed for a decade that heaven never granted. The silence of God, not explained away with a tidy reason but sat with, the way you sit with a friend in a hospital corridor when there is nothing left to say. Prayer when you are numb, when you feel nothing, when the words are dust in your mouth. Prayer when you are angry at God, actually angry, angry enough to stop, and the strange grace that this too is prayer. I am going to walk you into these rooms because you are already in them and it does you no good to be told they do not exist.

And I am going to try to recover something for you that I think has been stolen, quietly, by a whole culture of religion that should have known better. Prayer is not a vending machine. It is not the mechanism by which you insert the correct devotion and receive the desired outcome. When the Psalmists prayed, and they prayed more honestly than anyone before or since, they did not pray like that. They complained. They accused. They spread their rage out in

front of God like a man emptying his pockets onto a table, and God, astonishingly, kept those prayers, canonized them, handed them down to us as Scripture, so that three thousand years later a raging, doubting man in Michigan could open the book and find his own worst thoughts already there, already prayed, already received. That is what I want to give back to you. Not a method. A conversation. One you are allowed to stay in even when you cannot see the face of the one you are talking to.

Eugene Peterson, who died in 2018 after a lifetime of teaching the church to pray the Psalms, wrote that we do not learn to pray by getting good at it. We learn to pray by praying, badly, honestly, in the dark, using the words God already gave us for exactly this. I believe that. I have staked a ministry on it. This book is my attempt to say it to you slowly, over many pages, in the hope that somewhere in here you find permission to open your mouth again. Not because it will work. Because staying in the conversation, even the silent one, even the furious one, even the one you are not sure anyone hears, is itself the thing. It is not the means to the life with God. It is the life with God. And it can be had in the dark. That is the whole book. The rest is just me trying to convince you it is true.

CHAPTER ONE

When You Are Not Sure Anyone Is There

The worst thing that can happen to a man who prays is not that God says no. It is that a man decides, without ever quite deciding, that there was never anyone to say it.

LET ME TELL YOU about the first prayer I ever prayed as a believer, because it did not go the way the testimonies go. In the testimonies, the new convert falls to his knees and is flooded with peace, and the room fills with a warmth he has no words for, and he rises a changed man. That is a real experience. I have met people who had it. I did not have it. I prayed my first prayer sitting on the edge of a bed in a rented room, and what I felt was mostly embarrassment, the specific

embarrassment of a grown man doing something he has spent his whole adult life mocking. I felt like a fraud. I felt like I was talking to the furniture. And underneath both of those I felt a third thing, small and stubborn, which was the reason I kept going. I felt that if there was anyone there, I wanted to be found by him more than I wanted to protect my dignity. So I kept talking to the furniture, on the outside chance the furniture was God.

I want to sit with the not-being-sure, because it is where most of you live and almost no one will name it from a stage. The stage version of prayer assumes the connection. It assumes you know, in your bones, that God is present and attentive, the way you know your spouse is in the next room. From that assumption, prayer is easy to describe. You simply talk to the person you know is there. But that is not the situation of the honest praying person. The honest praying person is often not sure. Not intellectually unsure, necessarily, though that too. Unsure in the gut. He affirms in the creed that God hears, and he means it, and then he goes into his room and shuts the door and the room is just a room, and the affirmation and the experience do not match, and he does not know what to do with the gap.

Here is the first thing I want you to hear, and I want you to hear it before I have earned it, because you may not make it to the chapter where I earn it. The gap is not evidence against your faith. The gap is not a sign that you are doing it wrong. The gap is the ordinary condition of prayer for most of the people who have ever prayed seriously, and the tradition knew this, and named it, and did not panic about it. The mystics called it the absence. The Psalmists called it the hiding of God's face. Teresa of Avila, writing in Spain in the

1500s, spent whole books on the aridity of prayer, the dryness, the sense of drawing water from a dry well. She did not treat this as a problem to be solved by better technique. She treated it as a stage of the life with God, and in some cases the deepest stage. You are not below the tradition. You are inside it.

But I do not want to spiritualize the doubt too quickly, because that is its own kind of dodge. Sometimes the not-being-sure is not the dark night of the soul. Sometimes it is just the plain, cold possibility that there is no one there. I refuse to write a book about prayer that does not admit this out loud. When you pray and hear nothing, one available explanation is that nothing is what there is to hear. I held that explanation for years. I do not hold it now, but I hold my not holding it with a certain humility, because I know how reasonable it seemed from the inside, and I will not insult the version of me who believed it, and I will not insult you if you believe it now. If you are reading this and you are not sure God exists at all, you are welcome here. This book is not going to threaten you or shame you into certainty. It is going to invite you to keep the conversation open a little longer than your logic says you should, and to see what happens.

Because something did happen to me, and I can only report it, not prove it. What happened was not that I got an answer that settled the question. What happened was that the talking itself began to change me, over years, in a direction I had not chosen and would not have chosen. I became less afraid. I became, slowly, more honest, first with God and then with everyone else. I found that the parts of me I had kept hidden even from myself came up out of the dark when I prayed, and I had to look at them, and looking at them in what I hoped was the presence of God turned out to be different

from looking at them alone. I am not saying this proves God was there. I am saying that the man who prayed to the furniture on the outside chance became, over time, a man who could not honestly account for himself without reference to someone on the other end. The evidence was not a voice. The evidence was a life bent by a conversation.

I think of the father in Mark's Gospel who brings his sick son to Jesus and says the truest sentence in the New Testament. I believe. Help my unbelief. He does not resolve the contradiction. He prays it. He holds both halves of himself out to Jesus at once, the faith and the doubt, and Jesus does not send him away to sort himself out first. That is the posture I am asking you to consider. Not certainty. Not the pretense of certainty. The honest holding out of both halves. Lord, I am not sure you are there. I am talking to you anyway. If that is the most faith you can muster, it is enough to begin, because it was enough for that father, and his son was healed, and the man went home carrying a faith with a hole in it, which is the only kind most of us ever carry.

So here is what I would ask of you as we begin. Do not wait until you are sure to pray. You will wait forever, and the waiting is itself a decision, a slow closing of the door that you will not even notice you have made until one day you realize you have not spoken to God in a year and you do not miss it, and that not missing it is the most dangerous thing of all. The worst outcome is not the anguished prayer into apparent silence. The anguished prayer is alive. The worst outcome is the quiet settling into a life without prayer, the drift, the gradual conviction that there was never anyone to talk to, arrived at not by argument but by neglect. Stay in the conversation. Talk to the furniture on the outside chance it is God. I did, and I am telling you, from inside a life I did not

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expect to have, that the outside chance was worth everything
I have.

CHAPTER TWO

Why Most Books on Prayer Did Not Help Me

*A book that promises you a working prayer is selling you a working prayer.
What you need is a God, and God is not for sale.*

I HAVE A SHELF of them. Books on prayer. I bought them the way a sick man buys remedies, hopefully, one after another, each one promising in its subtitle to be the one that finally works. And I want to tell you honestly why most of them did not help me, not to be cruel to their authors, many of whom were serious people, but because naming the failure is the first step toward something better. Most books on prayer are written for people whose prayer already works. They assume the engine turns over. They are manuals for tuning an engine that is already running, and I came to them with an engine

that would not start, and page after page of advice about fuel mixture and timing was no use to a man whose problem was that he turned the key and heard nothing.

The most common failure is the failure of the formula. The book identifies a method, and the method is presented, whether the author intends it or not, as a mechanism. Pray this way and you will experience this result. Pray with these words, in this posture, at this hour, with this attitude, and the connection will be made. Now, I do not doubt that method has its place, and later in this book I am going to defend fixed prayers and bodily posture and the daily hours with real conviction, so hear me carefully. The problem is not method. The problem is method presented as guarantee. Because the moment prayer is a mechanism that produces a result, the person for whom it produces no result has been handed a verdict on himself. He followed the method. He got nothing. The method works. Therefore he is broken. I cannot count the people I have pastored who arrived at exactly this conclusion, quietly, and stopped praying not because they stopped believing in God but because they stopped believing in themselves as people God would answer.

The second failure is subtler and, I think, worse. It is the failure of the survivorship story. These books are full of answered prayers, and the answered prayers are moving, and they are almost certainly true. A woman prayed for her wayward son for twenty years and he came home. A man prayed over an impossible diagnosis and the tumor was gone. I believe these accounts. I have witnessed things I cannot explain. But a book built entirely of answered prayers is telling you a lie by omission, and the lie is that this is what prayer is like, that this is the pattern, that if you pray the son

comes home and the tumor disappears. It does not tell you about the ten thousand mothers who prayed with equal faith for twenty years and buried their sons. Those mothers do not get chapters. Their prayers do not make the anthology. And so the reader, holding the anthology, comes to believe that answered prayer is the rule and his own unanswered prayer is the exception, when the honest truth, the truth the Psalms are not afraid of, is that unanswered prayer is at least as common as the answered kind, and any book that hides this is not comforting you. It is setting you up.

The third failure is the failure of tone. So much writing about prayer is relentlessly, exhaustingly upbeat. It bounces. It exclaims. It treats prayer as an adventure of unbroken intimacy, a running conversation with a God who is basically always chatty. And I want to say, gently, that this tone is a wall to the suffering. When you are in the dark, when your prayers are hitting the ceiling, the bright and bouncing book does not meet you. It shames you by contrast. You read its joy and you feel your own dryness as a personal failure, a deficiency of gratitude or faith or effort. The Psalms do not have this tone. Fully a third of the Psalter is lament, complaint, protest, the raw material of grief handed up to God without a bow on it. The book of prayer that God himself gave us is far darker than the books we write about it, and that fact should stop us cold. We have made prayer sunnier than Scripture did. That is not piety. That is editing God.

I remember the night I gave up on the books. I had one open on my knees, a good one, well-reviewed, and it was walking me through a method for hearing God's voice, and I did the method, faithfully, in the quiet, and I heard nothing, and I closed the book and I thought, with a bitterness that surprised me, this man hears God and I do not, and either he

is lying or I am cursed. And then, sitting there in the dark with the useless book, I did the only honest thing I had done all night. I stopped following the method and I just told God the truth. I said, I do not hear you. I have never heard you the way these people say they hear you. If you are there, this is what I have, and it is not much, and I am tired of pretending it is more. And I want to tell you that nothing dramatic happened. No voice. No warmth. But something in me unclenched, and I realized that the unclenching was the closest thing to prayer I had felt all night, and it had come the moment I stopped performing and started telling the truth.

That is when I began to suspect that the books had it backwards. They were teaching me to get good at prayer. But the honesty I stumbled into that night was not me getting good at prayer. It was me getting bad at it, in the sense that mattered. It was me giving up the performance and showing up as the wreck I actually was. And that, I have come to believe, is nearer to the heart of the thing than any method. Ole Hallesby, the Norwegian who wrote his little book on prayer in 1931 while the shadows were gathering over Europe, said that helplessness is the real secret of prayer, that the person who has no strength left and no words left and no confidence left is precisely the person prayer is for. Not the accomplished pray-er. The helpless one. God is drawn, Hallesby said, not to our fervor but to our need. That was the opposite of every method book on my shelf, and it was the first thing anyone had said about prayer that fit the shape of my actual experience.

So I am not going to hand you a better method. I want to be clear about that, up front, so you can put this book down now if a method is what you came for and save us both the disappointment. What I am going to try to do is worse and

better than a method. I am going to try to give you permission. Permission to pray badly. Permission to pray angry, and dry, and doubting, and empty. Permission to bring the wreck instead of the performance. Permission to stay in a conversation you cannot hear the other side of. The books did not help me because they were trying to fix my prayer. What I needed was not a fixed prayer. What I needed was a God who could be spoken to by a man whose prayer was broken, and it turns out that is exactly the God the Bible describes, and I had to burn through a shelf of better books to find him.

CHAPTER THREE

Prayer Is Not a Vending Machine

We came to God with our coins and our selections. He kept giving us himself instead, and we called it a malfunction.

THERE IS A MACHINE down the hall from my study at the church. It takes your dollar, you press B4, and a bag of pretzels drops into the tray. The transaction is clean. You put in the correct input, you receive the specified output, and if you put in your dollar and press B4 and nothing drops, the machine is broken and you are entitled to be angry and to shake it. I have watched grown men shake that machine. And I have come to believe that most of us, when we were taught to pray, were taught to treat God like that machine, and that this single error is responsible for more abandoned faith than

all the arguments of all the atheists combined.

The vending-machine model of prayer is rarely stated so baldly. No one teaches it in those words. But it is smuggled in everywhere, in the language of prayer as a tool, prayer as a key, prayer that unlocks and releases and activates. It is there in the way we speak of the power of prayer, as if prayer were a force we wield rather than a conversation we enter. It is there most of all in the unspoken logic of our disappointment, because you can tell what a man really believed about prayer by what makes him angry when it fails. If you prayed for your marriage and it ended and your reaction was that the machine took your dollar and gave you nothing, then whatever your theology said, your gut believed in the vending machine. I know this because it was my gut, and I shook the machine, and I am not proud of it, but I understand it, and I will not condemn you for it.

Let me be careful here, because the correction can go too far and become its own cruelty. I am not saying God does not answer prayer. I am not saying you should not ask him for things, plainly, specifically, urgently. Jesus told us to ask. He said ask and it will be given, and he meant it, and I am going to spend a whole chapter later refusing to explain away the promises. Asking is not the error. Asking is commanded. The error is in what we believe the asking is for, and what we believe the relationship is, and what we conclude about God and ourselves when the thing we asked for does not come. The vending-machine believer asks in order to receive, and the receiving is the point, and God is the mechanism in between. But that gets the whole thing backwards. In real prayer, the asking is not the mechanism and the receiving is not the point. The asking is a way of turning toward God with

your actual desire, and the point, the deep point that takes a lifetime to learn, is God himself.

Consider how strange the alternative is when you say it out loud. If prayer were a vending machine, then the ideal relationship with God would be one in which you never had to talk to him at all except to place your orders. The perfect life of prayer would be an efficient one, minimal contact, maximum yield. But no one who has actually loved anyone believes that intimacy works like that. You do not love your child in order to extract outcomes from her. When my sons were small and one of them climbed into my lap, he was not there to submit a request. Sometimes there was a request, a scraped knee, a broken toy, and I met it. But the climbing into the lap was not instrumental. It was the thing itself. And on the days I understood my own children I understood, dimly, that I had been praying wrong my whole life, treating the lap as a means to the toy, when the lap was the whole inheritance and the toy was nothing.

C.S. Lewis, in the letters he wrote near the end of his life and published as *Letters to Malcolm* in 1964, wrestled with exactly this, and he refused the easy answer. He would not say that prayer always changes things in the world, and he would not say that it never does. What he insisted on was that prayer is not primarily a technique for altering events but a form of personal relation to God, and that the man who prays chiefly to get results has mistaken the whole nature of the encounter. Lewis, who had come to faith from atheism as I did, knew the temptation to want God for his gifts. He knew how natural it is, how nearly universal. And he named the alternative not as a higher spirituality for advanced saints but as the plain meaning of the word Father. You do not audit your father. You are known by him.

I have watched the vending-machine faith destroy people, and I want to describe the destruction precisely so you can see if it is happening to you. It goes like this. A person believes, sincerely, that faithful prayer produces results. They pray faithfully for something good, a healing, a rescue, a restoration, something no one could call selfish. The result does not come. And now they are caught in a trap with only three exits, and every one of them is a wound. Exit one, God is real but did not answer, therefore God does not love me. Exit two, God is real and loving but I prayed wrong, therefore I am the failure. Exit three, God is not real, and I have been shaking an empty machine. Faithful people take all three exits, every day, and the church watches them go and wonders why, and the answer, at least part of the answer, is that we handed them a false picture of prayer and then let them break their hearts against the falseness of it.

There is a fourth exit, and it is the reason for this book, and it is not available to the vending-machine believer because it requires giving up the machine entirely. The fourth exit is this. God is real, and God is loving, and prayer is not a mechanism for producing outcomes but a relationship in which I am gradually made into a person who can bear both the outcomes I wanted and the ones I did not. On the fourth exit, the unanswered prayer is not proof of God's absence or my failure. It is the hard terrain across which the relationship actually deepens, the way a friendship is proven not in the season of easy favors but in the long night when one friend keeps sitting with another and neither of them can fix a thing. I did not find the fourth exit by getting better at prayer. I found it by having every other exit close in my face, one grief at a time, until the only door left was the door marked stay, and I walked through it because there was nowhere else to go,

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and it turned out to be the only door that led anywhere at all.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Honest God Can Take

*We spent our whole lives being polite to
God, and then we opened the Psalms
and found out he had never asked us to
be.*

THE FIRST TIME I read Psalm 88 all the way to the end, I thought there had been a printing error. I kept turning the page, looking for the verse where it turns, the verse where the psalmist remembers God's faithfulness and the clouds part and the prayer resolves into hope. Almost every lament in the Psalter does this. It descends into the pit and then, near the end, it pivots, and the pivot is signaled by a small word, but, and after the but comes the light. I had come to rely on the but. But Psalm 88 has no but. It ends in the dark. The last line, in the translation I was reading, is simply, the darkness is my

closest friend. And then it stops. There is no resolution. There is no turn. The psalmist goes down into the pit and the psalm goes down with him and God, who preserved this prayer and included it in the book of prayers he gave his people, let it end there, in the dark, unresolved, forever.

I cannot tell you what that did to me. I had been a believer for a few years by then, and I had absorbed, without anyone teaching it to me directly, the idea that a good prayer ends well. That the mark of faith is the turn toward hope. That to end in the dark is to fail, to give in, to let the doubt win. And here was a prayer, canonized, holy, prayed by the people of God for three thousand years, that ended in the dark and called it good enough. I remember sitting there and feeling something in my chest come loose, some clenched and frightened thing I had been holding tight for years, the belief that God could only bear my hope and not my despair. Psalm 88 told me the truth. God can bear the despair. He put it in the book.

This is the great scandalous mercy of the Psalter, and I do not think the church has ever fully recovered from its refusal to reckon with it. A third of the Psalms are laments, and the laments are not polite. They accuse God of sleeping. They accuse him of forgetting. They ask, out loud, how long, and why, and where are you, and they do not always get an answer inside the psalm, and the absence of the answer is not edited out. Walter Brueggemann, the Old Testament scholar who spent his life on these texts and died in 2025, called the laments the great counter-testimony of Israel, the voice that refuses to let the official story of God's goodness silence the actual experience of God's people. He argued that the church, by quietly dropping the laments from its worship, had

produced a faith of relentless positivity that could not survive contact with real suffering. He was right. Go and count how many of the songs your church sings are laments. In most churches the number is zero. And then wonder why the grieving feel they have no language in the house of God.

Because here is what happens when you take the laments away. You do not make the pain disappear. You make it homeless. The person in agony still feels the agony, but now they believe they cannot bring it to God, because everything they have been taught tells them that prayer is supposed to be grateful and hopeful and trusting, and their prayer is none of those things, their prayer is a howl, and so they conclude that their howl is not welcome and they swallow it and they pray something polite and dead instead, or they stop praying altogether. I have watched this happen to some of the most faithful people I know. Their child dies, or their body fails, or their marriage collapses, and they come to me and they say, in a whisper, as if confessing a sin, I am so angry at God, and I cannot say that to him, and I say to them, the Psalms say it to him, on nearly every page, and they look at me like I have handed them a key to a door they did not know was there.

Let me show you how far the honesty goes, because I do not want you to think the laments are merely sad. They are worse than sad, and their worseness is their gift. Psalm 137, one of the most beautiful in the whole book in its opening, the exiles weeping by the rivers of Babylon, hanging their harps on the willows, unable to sing the Lord's song in a strange land, ends with a line so brutal that most churches will not read it aloud. It ends with the exiles praying for the death of the enemy's infants, dashed against the rocks. That is in the Bible. That is a prayer God kept. Now, I am not telling you that prayer is right. The prayer is not being commended. But it is

being received. The rage of a conquered and traumatized people, the most terrible rage there is, the rage of the powerless who have watched their own children die and now wish the same on the children of their enemies, is brought into the presence of God rather than acted out in the world. And that, I have come to believe, is the deep function of the ugly psalm. It is the place you take the rage so you do not take it to your neighbor.

I want to say something now that I have never said from the pulpit because I have not been brave enough, and a book is a braver place than a pulpit. There have been times in my life when the truest thing I could have prayed was an accusation against God, and I did not pray it, because I was too pious, and I think the piety was a sin. When my prayers were hitting the ceiling and I was sure no one was listening, the honest prayer, the psalm-shaped prayer, would have been to say to God, you are not answering me and it is destroying me and I do not understand how you can call this love. That is Psalm 88. That is Psalm 13. That is the language God himself provided. And instead I said polite things, hopeful things, things I did not mean, because I had absorbed the lie that God could only take the polished version of me. I lied to God to protect his feelings. Read that sentence again. I lied to God to protect his feelings, as if the maker of heaven and earth needed to be shielded from the truth of my heart, as if he did not already know it, as if the whole point of prayer were not to bring the truth of my heart into the light where he already was.

So here is what I am asking of you, and it is harder than it sounds. Tell God the truth. Not the truth you think you should feel. The truth you actually feel, in all its ugliness, in all its accusation, in all its doubt and rage and despair. If you are

angry, pray angry. If you are numb, pray numb. If you think he has abandoned you, tell him you think he has abandoned you. The Psalms are your permission and your vocabulary. They are God's own gift of the words for the feelings we were told we could not have. Peterson called the Psalms the anti-flattery in the life of prayer, the great cure for the religious dishonesty that tells God what it thinks he wants to hear. The God of the Bible does not want to hear what you think he wants to hear. He wants to hear you. And the astonishing thing, the thing I stake my life on, is that he can take it. He can take all of it. He proved he could take it by writing the ugliest human feelings into his own holy book and calling them prayer.

CHAPTER FIVE

Teaching Us to Pray

He did not answer the question we asked. We asked how to get what we wanted. He told us how to want what we lacked.

THERE IS ONE MOMENT in the Gospels where the disciples ask Jesus to teach them something, and it is worth noticing what they asked to be taught. They did not ask him to teach them to preach, though they had heard him preach and it must have been extraordinary. They did not ask him to teach them to heal, though they had watched him heal and surely wanted the power. They asked him to teach them to pray. And I think they asked this because they had watched him pray, watched him go out alone before dawn, watched him disappear into the hills for whole nights, and they had seen that whatever he had, it came from there. The praying was the source. They wanted the source. And so they said, Lord,

teach us to pray, and he gave them the prayer we have said so many times we no longer hear it.

I want us to hear it again, slowly, because I think most of us have said the Lord's Prayer so often it has gone smooth in our mouths like a stone in a river, worn featureless by repetition. We rattle it off. And in the rattling we miss that Jesus, asked to teach prayer, did not teach a technique. He taught an order. He taught a shape. And the shape is a rebuke to almost everything the vending-machine faith believes about what prayer is for. Because look at where the prayer begins. It does not begin with us. It does not begin with our needs, our requests, our list of the things we want the machine to dispense. It begins with him. Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name. The first movement of the prayer Jesus taught is not asking for anything. It is the hallowing of the name of God. It is worship. Before a single request, the pray-er is oriented away from the self and toward God, and this ordering is not an accident. It is the whole teaching.

Consider the word Father, and consider that Jesus put it first and made it the address. For a man raised without a father, as I was, this word is not neutral. It carries freight. And I have come to think that Jesus, in teaching us to begin here, is doing something to us before we ask for anything at all. He is establishing the relationship inside which the asking will happen. You are not approaching a machine, or a magistrate, or a distant power to be flattered into compliance. You are approaching a Father, which means you are approaching someone to whom you already belong, someone whose disposition toward you is settled before you open your mouth. The asking that comes later comes from inside a relationship

of belonging, not from outside it, as a beggar at a gate. This changes everything about what the asking is. The child who asks his father for bread is not trying to earn the bread. He is expressing a trust that already exists.

Then come the petitions, and notice their order too, because the order keeps teaching. Your kingdom come, your will be done. Before we pray for our own daily bread, we pray for God's kingdom and God's will, and this is not pious throat-clearing. It is a reordering of desire. It is Jesus teaching us to want the right things in the right order, God's reign first, our own needs after. And I want to be honest that this order is not natural to me. When I come to prayer in distress, my needs are not second. They are first, they are loud, they are the whole reason I came. The Lord's Prayer does not condemn my needs. It sees them, it will get to them, our daily bread is right there in the middle of the prayer, plain and physical and real. But it puts them in their place. It teaches me, over years of repetition, to hold my own urgent needs inside a larger frame in which God's purposes are the true horizon and my bread is real but not ultimate. That reordering is slow. It happens through repetition, not insight. You do not learn it by understanding it. You learn it by praying it ten thousand times until the order sinks below thought and becomes the shape of your wanting.

And then, having taught us to ask for bread, Jesus teaches us to ask for forgiveness, and he attaches to it the one clause in the whole prayer that comes with a condition. Forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. As. That little word is a hook set in our flesh. It ties the mercy we receive to the mercy we extend, and it will not let us pray the prayer without confronting the person we have not forgiven. I have prayed the Lord's Prayer through gritted teeth, arriving at that clause

and stumbling, because there was someone I had not forgiven, and the prayer would not let me past without naming it. This too is the teaching. Jesus did not give us a prayer that leaves us as we are. He gave us a prayer that works on us as we say it, that forms us, that keeps setting the same hooks in the same soft places until we either deal with them or admit we are refusing to.

I want to sit with the physical honesty of the bread, because I think it saves the prayer from becoming too spiritual. Give us this day our daily bread. Not our spiritual nourishment, though certainly that. Bread. The plainest thing, the thing a body needs to not die, the thing a poor man in first-century Palestine was genuinely unsure of when he woke each morning. Jesus put the body's real hunger right in the center of the prayer he taught, between the kingdom of God and the forgiveness of sins, and by doing so he refused the false spirituality that treats prayer as too holy for the stomach. You are allowed to ask God for bread. For the mortgage. For the biopsy result. For the child to come home. The daily-bread clause is Jesus telling you that the God of the kingdom is also the God of your grocery bill, and that bringing him your smallest physical need is not beneath the dignity of prayer but native to it.

So when you do not know how to pray, and there will be many days you do not, pray this. Do not improvise. Do not wait for the eloquence or the feeling to come. Say the words Jesus gave, slowly, one clause at a time, and let them do to you what they were built to do. Hallow the name before you ask for anything. Want the kingdom before you want your bread. Ask for the bread without shame. Confront the person you have not forgiven. Ask to be kept from the evil that is always nearer than you think. This is not a magic formula and it will

not make your prayers work in the vending-machine sense, but it will slowly rebuild you into a person shaped like the prayer, and that reshaping is what Jesus was after when the disciples asked him for a technique and he gave them, instead, a way of becoming. Teresa of Avila spent the longest section of her masterwork on prayer, written in the 1560s, walking her sisters through the Lord's Prayer line by line, and she said a soul could be carried all the way to union with God on these words alone, if it would only pray them slowly enough to mean them. I believe her. I have not gotten there. But I have felt the words begin the work, and beginning is not nothing.

CHAPTER SIX

Lament Is Prayer, Not the Failure of It

*We thought our grief was the
interruption of prayer. It turned out to
be prayer arriving.*

I NEED TO CORRECT something the church taught me, and it taught you too, though probably no one ever said it in words. The church taught me that lament is what prayer becomes when prayer breaks down. That the crying out, the how long, the where are you, the raw complaint, is the sound of a faith that has faltered and needs to recover itself. That the goal, always, is to get back to praise, and the lament is the sad detour on the way there, the thing you pass through and hope to leave behind. I believed this for years, and it made my grief feel like a spiritual failure, an embarrassment, a lapse to be confessed. And it is wrong. It is exactly wrong. Lament is not

the failure of prayer. Lament is one of the highest forms prayer takes, and a church that cannot lament has not risen above grief. It has lost the language for half of what it means to be alive before God.

Let me show you the structure of a lament, because the Psalms have a form and the form is instructive. A typical lament begins with an address, a turning toward God, often abrupt, often almost rude. O God. My God. And then, without preamble, it launches into the complaint. It tells God what is wrong. It describes the suffering in specific and often exaggerated terms, the bones wasting away, the tears that are the psalmist's food day and night, the enemies encircling, the pit, the miry clay. It does not minimize. It does not add the reflexive qualifier we always add, I know others have it worse. The lament claims its full pain and lays it out. And then, crucially, it turns to accusation, or something very near it. It asks God why. It asks how long. It reminds God of his promises and, by implication, of his apparent failure to keep them. Wake up, O Lord, why do you sleep. That is a real line in a real psalm. The people of God accusing God of sleeping through their suffering, and preserving the accusation as Scripture.

Now, I said most laments turn, near the end, toward trust or praise, and they do, and I do not want to hide that. But I want you to see the turn correctly, because if you see it wrong you will weaponize it against your own grief. The turn is not the lament recovering from its failure and getting back to the real business of praise. The turn, when it comes, comes through the lament, not despite it. It is not that the psalmist stops complaining and starts trusting. It is that the complaining is itself an act of trust, because you do not pour

out your rage and your accusation to someone you have given up on. You only lament to a God you still, somewhere beneath the rage, believe is there and believe is listening and believe, against all the evidence, might yet act. The lament is faith in its most stripped-down form. It is faith that has lost everything except its grip on the God it is angry with. And that grip, that refusal to let go even in fury, is the very thing the turn grows out of.

I learned this at a graveside, or rather I began to learn it there, because these things are not learned all at once. I was a young pastor, and I was burying a child, and the family was destroyed, and I had my funeral liturgy with its careful hopeful words, and I stood there and I could not say them, or rather I said them and they were ash in my mouth, because the situation would not bear them. And the mother, at the graveside, began to keen. It is the only word for it. A sound came out of her that was not words, a sound of pure protest against the wrongness of the thing, and part of me, the trained pastoral part, wanted to comfort her, to quiet the sound, to move us back toward the hopeful words. And another part of me, older and truer, recognized that the sound she was making was the most honest prayer at that graveside, more honest than my liturgy, and that God was nearer to that keening than to all my careful theology. She was not failing to pray. She was praying, in the oldest language there is, the language that has no words, the language Paul says the Spirit himself uses, groanings too deep for words.

Brueggemann argued that the loss of lament from the church's life is not a small liturgical matter but a distortion of the whole faith, because a community that can only praise has, in effect, decided that the way things are is the way they should be. Praise, unbroken and unqualified, can become a

form of denial, a refusal to name the wrongness of a world in which children die and the wicked prosper and prayers go unanswered for decades. Lament is the refusal of that denial. It is the insistence, before God, that this is not right, that this was not the deal, that the world is broken and God has some explaining to do. And far from being irreverent, this insistence is the engine of hope, because you only protest a wrong you believe should and could be made right. The one who has truly given up does not lament. He goes quiet. Lament is the noise faith makes on its way through the dark, and the noise is a sign of life.

So I want to give you back your grief as prayer. If you are in the pit, you do not have to climb out of it before you are allowed to pray. The pit is a place from which the Psalms are prayed, out of the depths I cry to you, O Lord, and the crying out of the depths is not a lesser prayer that you offer while you wait to be able to offer a better one. It is the prayer. It is possibly the truest prayer you will ever pray, because it is the one where you have stopped performing and stopped managing and stopped protecting God from your pain, and you are simply there, in the depths, crying out, which is exactly where the Psalmist was and exactly where God met him. The lament does not need to resolve. Psalm 88 does not resolve. Your grief may not resolve, not in this life, and you are still permitted, still commanded, still welcomed, to bring it, unresolved, into the presence of God and to leave it there, and to call that leaving prayer.

Here is the verdict I want you to carry out of this chapter. The opposite of faith is not lament. The opposite of faith is indifference, the settled decision that there is no one to cry out to and nothing to cry out about. Lament is the sound of a faith still fighting. When you lament, you are not falling away

PRAYER IN THE DARK

from God. You are holding onto him with the only grip you have left, which is the grip of your grief, and that grip, I promise you, is strong enough, because it is not finally your grip on him that holds. It is his grip on you. And his grip does not loosen when you rage. It held David through the darkest psalms. It held the mother at the graveside. It held me at the altar when I had no words left. It will hold you in the pit. Cry out. The crying out is prayer.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Silence of God

We kept asking why he was silent. It never occurred to us that a father sometimes sits with a child in the dark and says nothing, because there is nothing to say, and saying nothing is the love.

I HAVE TO BE careful in this chapter, more careful than in any other, because the silence of God is the place where books like this one usually cheat. They set up the silence, they let you feel its weight, and then, in the final third, they explain it away. They tell you the silence is not really silence. They tell you God was speaking all along and you just were not listening in the right way. They tell you the silence is a test, or a lesson, or a season, something with a purpose and a shape and, above all, an end. And every one of these moves,

however well-intended, is a small betrayal, because it takes the actual thing you are suffering, the actual silence, and replaces it with a manageable version that has a bow on it. I am not going to do that. I am going to sit in the silence with you, and I am going to refuse to explain it away, and I am going to tell you that even so, even unexplained, it is not the end of the conversation.

First, let me insist that the silence is real. When Scripture speaks of the hiding of God's face, it is not using a figure of speech for something that is secretly not happening. The Psalmists experienced the felt absence of God as a fact, and they said so, and God preserved their saying so. How long will you hide your face from me. Why do you stand far off, O Lord. Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble. These are not the words of people who understood, on reflection, that God was present all along and they had simply misperceived. They are the words of people who experienced absence, who cried into what felt like an empty sky and got nothing back, and who were not corrected for this experience but validated in it, given words for it, handed a whole vocabulary of divine hiddenness. If the giants of the faith experienced the silence of God as silence, I am not going to tell you that yours is a misunderstanding. Yours is real. I believe you.

And it goes higher than the Psalmists. It goes to the cross. Because the loudest cry of divine abandonment in all of Scripture comes not from a doubting sinner but from the Son of God himself, hanging on the cross, crying out the opening words of Psalm 22, my God, my God, why have you forsaken me. Let the weight of that land on you. Jesus, in his deepest agony, prayed a lament of abandonment. He did not pray a serene prayer of trust. He prayed the psalm of the forsaken,

out loud, from the cross, and heaven did not answer, and he died into the silence. Whatever the silence of God is, it is not something that only happens to the faithless or the immature. It happened to Christ. And that means, and I want you to hold this, that when you cry into the silence and hear nothing, you are not outside the experience of Jesus. You are inside it. You are standing exactly where he stood, praying exactly what he prayed, into exactly the silence he faced, and if there was ever a place where a Christian is most conformed to his Lord, it may be here, in the unanswered cry, more than in any triumph.

Now I have to say something about the silence that will sound cold at first and I ask you to stay with me until it turns warm. The silence of God is not, in every case, the withdrawal of God. These are different things, and confusing them causes enormous suffering. When my sons were young and one of them was frightened in the night, there were times I went and sat on the edge of his bed and did not speak. I did not deliver a lecture on why he should not be afraid. I did not narrate my presence. I just sat, in the dark, silent, and let him know by the weight of me on the mattress that he was not alone. If you had recorded that room, you would have heard nothing, and you might have concluded the father was absent or unresponsive. You would have been wrong. The silence was not absence. The silence was a form the presence took, because sometimes love has nothing to say and says nothing, and the nothing is the love. I am not telling you this is always what God's silence is. I am telling you it is sometimes what it is, and you cannot tell from inside the silence which kind you are in, and that not-knowing is the hardest part, and I will not pretend it away.

Lewis, in *A Grief Observed*, written in 1961 after his wife

died, described the silence of God in the extremity of loss with a bitterness that shocked his readers, because it came from the great Christian apologist, the man who had explained suffering in a famous book years before. But now he was inside it, and he wrote that when you go to God in desperate need, when every other help has failed, you find, or seem to find, a door slammed in your face, and the sound of bolting and double bolting on the inside, and after that, silence. He did not soften it. And then, slowly, over the course of the book, he came to suspect that the slammed door was not what it seemed, that his own frantic need had been part of what made him unable to receive, that the door might not have been bolted from God's side at all. He did not resolve it neatly. He offered no formula. But he came, at the end, to a kind of quiet, not because the silence was explained but because he stopped demanding that it be explained and simply stayed near the God who was silent.

That is the move I want to commend to you, and it is not a solution, it is a posture. Stay near the silent God. Do not require the silence to break before you will keep company with him. This is enormously hard, because everything in us wants to make the staying conditional on the answering. We say, in effect, break your silence and I will keep praying, prove you are there and I will keep talking, and when the silence continues we take our staying away as a punishment, we withdraw, we go quiet in return, we make our silence answer his. And I understand that impulse, I have lived it, but I want to name what it costs. It ends the conversation. And the one thing worse than praying into the silence of God is not praying at all, because the prayer into silence keeps the door open from your side, and the not-praying closes it, and a closed door, held closed long enough, becomes a habit, and

the habit becomes a life, and the life becomes a settled forgetting that there was ever anyone to talk to.

So here is what I do, and I offer it not as a technique but as a testimony from one who has spent long seasons in the dark. When God is silent, I keep talking. I do not wait for the answer to resume the conversation. I say, out loud sometimes, you are silent, and it is hard, and I do not understand it, and I am staying. I tell him the silence is difficult. I tell him I am tempted to leave. I tell him I am not leaving, not because I feel his presence, I often do not, but because I have decided that his silence is not going to have the last word, that I will keep my end of the conversation open even when his end gives me nothing, that I will be, as it were, faithful to a God who seems, in this hour, to be doing nothing for me at all. And I want to tell you, honestly, that this staying has not usually produced a breaking of the silence. What it has produced, over years, is a strange and durable peace that does not depend on the silence breaking, a peace that lives underneath the silence rather than on the far side of it. I did not find God at the end of the silence. I found him in it. That is not the answer I wanted. It is the answer I got, and it has been enough.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Unanswered Prayer, and the Three Answers That Are Not No

*We asked for one thing and were
refused, and only years later did we see
that the refusal had a face, and the face
was kind, and it had been holding
something better that we could not yet
carry.*

I PROMISED YOU EARLIER that I would not explain unanswered prayer away, and I am going to keep that promise, but I am also going to complicate it, because the honest truth about unanswered prayer is more complicated than either the vending-machine faith or the bitter unbelief

allows. The vending-machine faith says unanswered prayer means you prayed wrong. The bitter unbelief says unanswered prayer means no one is there. And I have come, over a long time, to a third position that is harder to hold than either, because it requires living inside a genuine mystery instead of resolving it. The third position is this. Some prayers are unanswered, really unanswered, in the plain sense that the thing was asked for and did not come. And even so, God was neither absent nor punishing, and the unanswered prayer was not proof against him. Holding both halves of that at once is the discipline of the mature pray-er, and I want to help you hold it.

Let me start with the answers that are not no, because there are more of them than we usually admit, and mistaking them for no has caused needless despair. The first answer that is not no is not yet. We are creatures of time and God is not, and the thing we asked for may be coming on a timeline that makes our whole life look, from inside it, like refusal. Abraham was promised a son and waited twenty-five years, and for most of those years the promise looked exactly like an unanswered prayer, and it was not, it was a delayed one, and the delay had its own work to do, its own forming of a man who would be ready to receive what he had asked for. I have prayed prayers that were answered ten years late, and in the tenth year I saw that had they been answered in the first, they would have wrecked me, because I was not yet the person who could hold the answer. Not yet is real. But I want to be careful, because not yet can become a cruelty when it is used to string the suffering along indefinitely, to tell a person their answer is always just over the horizon. Some prayers get not yet all the way to the grave. I am not going to pretend otherwise. But some genuine answers wear the mask of no for

years, and it is worth knowing that the mask exists.

The second answer that is not no is not this, but something better, and this one is harder to receive, because it requires trusting that God knows a good you cannot yet see. When one of my sons was young he asked me, with great seriousness, for something that would have harmed him, and I said no, and to him my no was incomprehensible and cruel, because he could not see what I could see, and I could not explain it in terms his mind could hold. I just had to be, to him, a father who refused a thing he desperately wanted, and to bear his conviction that I did not love him. And I think, I cannot prove, but I think, that some of my unanswered prayers are of this kind. I asked for a good, a real good, and God, seeing further, gave a different good, or withheld my good to protect a greater one, and I stood there like my son, convinced of the refusal, unable to see the love in it. Lewis said that if God had granted all the silly prayers he had prayed over the years, where would he be now, and I feel the force of that. Some of my most anguished unanswered prayers, granted, would have been disasters, and I know it now, and I did not know it then, and the not-knowing was agony, and the agony was not evidence against the love.

The third answer that is not no is the strangest and the deepest, and I almost hesitate to name it because it can sound like a dodge, but it is not a dodge, it is the pattern of Scripture. The third answer is I will not give you the thing, but I will give you myself, and myself is what you were really after even when you thought you wanted the thing. Paul prayed three times for the removal of his thorn, whatever it was, some affliction that tormented him, and God said no, plainly, a real no, the thorn stayed. But the no came with something. My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in

weakness. God refused the request and granted, instead, himself, his sufficient grace, his power in Paul's weakness, and Paul came to regard this refusal as one of the great gifts of his life, came to boast in the very weakness he had begged to be relieved of, because the weakness became the place where he knew God most intimately. That is not the vending machine dispensing an alternate product. That is a relationship deepening through a refusal, which is a thing that can only happen between persons, and never between a man and a machine.

But now I have to keep my promise, because I have just given you three answers that are not no, and if I stop here I have cheated you, I have explained the silence away after all. So let me say the hard thing plainly. Sometimes the answer is no, and it is not not yet, and it is not something better, and there is no discernible greater good, and you will go to your grave not understanding it. Some parents bury their children having prayed with more faith than I have ever mustered, and there is no lesson in it, no hidden gift, nothing that makes it make sense, and anyone who tells them otherwise is lying to make themselves comfortable. I will not do it. Job's friends did it, they explained his suffering, they found the hidden reason, and at the end of the book God is angry with them, not with Job, because Job spoke to God honestly out of his pain and they spoke about God dishonestly to defend him. The honest lament is nearer to God than the dishonest explanation. Remember that the next time someone tries to explain your grief.

So how do we pray at all, knowing that some of our prayers will get this final no, the one with no explanation? I think we pray the way Jesus prayed in Gethsemane, and I think that prayer is the model for every honest prayer we will ever pray.

He asked, plainly, for the thing he wanted. Let this cup pass from me. He did not pretend he wanted to suffer. He asked to be spared, with sweat like blood, with everything in him recoiling from what was coming. That is the first movement, and it is permitted, it is right, we are to ask for what we want without pretense. And then came the second movement, and it is the hardest sentence a human being has ever prayed. Yet not my will, but yours be done. Not as resignation, not as the defeated shrug of a man giving up, but as trust, the deliberate placing of his desperate request into the hands of a Father he trusted even in the dark of that garden, even knowing the cup would not pass, even facing the cross. He asked, and he yielded, and the asking was real and the yielding was real, and both together are what prayer looks like at its summit.

That is the shape I am asking you to hold. Ask for the thing. Ask plainly, urgently, without the false piety that pretends you do not want what you want. And then, having asked, entrust the asking to a Father whose refusals you cannot always understand but whose character you have decided to trust, and say, and mean it as much as you are able, not my will but yours. This is not a formula that gets you the thing. Jesus prayed it and did not get the thing, he got the cross. It is the posture that keeps you in the conversation and in the relationship even when the answer is the one you feared, the posture that refuses to let the no become a wall between you and God. The unanswered prayer, prayed in the Gethsemane posture, does not end the relationship. It deepens it, because it is the moment you love God for himself and not for his gifts, which is the thing all of prayer was quietly training you toward the whole time.

CHAPTER NINE

Praying When You Are Numb

We waited to feel something before we prayed, and the feeling never came, and so we never prayed, and the not-praying deepened the numbness, and we called the whole thing proof that God was gone.

THERE IS A CONDITION that the books on prayer rarely address, and it is more common than any of the dramatic ones, and it is, in some ways, harder to bear than anger or doubt, because it has no energy in it at all. It is numbness. It is the state in which you do not feel angry at God and you do not feel abandoned by God and you do not feel anything about God, in which the whole subject of prayer produces in you not

agony but a flat grey nothing, in which you know you should pray and you cannot make yourself care that you are not praying, in which even the guilt about not praying has gone dull. I have been here. I have been here for stretches longer than I want to admit from a pulpit. And I want to talk about it plainly, because if you are here, the books that assume you arrive at prayer full of longing are no use to you at all.

The first thing to say about numbness is that it is not, primarily, a spiritual failure, though the church will often treat it as one. Numbness is frequently the mind's response to too much pain, a protective shutting-down, the emotional equivalent of a limb going to sleep because the blood has been cut off. It comes after grief, after prolonged stress, after depression, after burnout, after the kind of sustained disappointment that a soul can only take so much of before it stops feeling in self-defense. When you are numb toward God, it is often because you are numb toward everything, and the numbness toward God is a symptom of a deeper exhaustion, not a verdict on your faith. I have watched people flog themselves for their spiritual coldness when what they actually needed was sleep, and food, and the lifting of a burden, and sometimes a doctor. I want to say this clearly and I am not a physician and this is not medical advice, but if your numbness is total and lasting and comes with the inability to feel pleasure or hope in anything, that may be depression, and depression is a real illness with real help available, and seeking that help is not a failure of faith but an act of stewardship over the body God gave you.

But let us say the numbness is not clinical, or not only clinical, and you are simply in one of those grey seasons where prayer feels like talking into a dead phone. What then?

Here is the counsel I have found, and it runs directly against the grain of the feelings-first spirituality most of us absorbed. Pray without the feeling. Do not wait for the feeling to return before you pray. The feeling may not return for a long time, and if you make prayer conditional on feeling, you will not pray during precisely the season when prayer is doing its deepest and least visible work. Pray numb. Say the words even though the words are dust. Show up to the appointed time even though nothing happens at the appointed time. The prayer prayed in numbness, without any felt sense of God, without any warmth or assurance or sense of being heard, is not a lesser prayer. In some ways it is a purer one, because it is stripped of everything except the bare will to keep the conversation open, and that bare will, that decision to pray when there is no reward in the praying, is faith in a form more refined than any ecstasy.

This is exactly where the fixed forms of prayer become a lifeline, and I will say more about them in their own chapter, but I have to mention them here because they are the specific medicine for numbness. When you cannot generate a single word of your own, you can pray the words of another. You can pray a Psalm you do not feel. You can pray the Lord's Prayer with a heart of stone. You can pray the written prayers of the church, the collects, the prayers of the daily office, the prayers that thousands of numb and grieving Christians before you prayed when they too had nothing of their own to bring. The great gift of fixed prayer is that it does not require you to feel anything to say it. It carries you when you cannot carry yourself. It is the wheelchair of the spiritual life, and there is no shame in a wheelchair when your legs have stopped working, and the person who refuses the wheelchair out of pride simply does not move. Pray the given words. Let

them pray you when you cannot pray.

I want to tell you about a season of numbness in my own life, because I think the confession may help you more than the counsel. There was a period of about a year, some years into my ministry, when I felt nothing in prayer at all. I was preaching every Sunday about a God I could not feel. I was leading others in prayers that, privately, hit my own ceiling and stopped. And the numbness produced in me a terrible temptation, which was to quit praying entirely, because it seemed dishonest to keep doing a thing I felt nothing in, and it seemed pointless besides. And the thing that held me, the only thing, was a decision I had made earlier, in a warmer season, that I would pray whether or not I felt like it, that I would treat prayer not as an expression of my feelings but as an appointment I kept regardless. So I kept the appointment. Every morning, numb, I sat down and prayed the Psalms and said the Lord's Prayer and sat in silence and felt nothing, and got up, and did it again the next day, for a year, feeling nothing.

And here is what I learned, and it is not what I expected. The numbness did not lift because I finally prayed hard enough or right enough. It lifted the way a fog lifts, slowly, on its own schedule, for reasons I could not trace, and one day I noticed I could feel again, and the feeling had crept back while I was not looking. But what I want you to see is what the year of numb praying accomplished, which was not the return of feeling, that came on its own, but something else, something I only saw looking back. It kept me in the relationship. When the feeling returned, God and I were not strangers who had to be reintroduced, because I had never left the room. I had sat there, numb, every morning, keeping the appointment, and so when the warmth came back it came

back into a relationship that had been continuously tended rather than one that had to be rebuilt from ruins. The numb prayers, which felt like nothing, which felt like failures, had in fact been the thing that held the whole relationship together across a year when feeling could not.

So do not despise your numb prayers. They may be the most important prayers you ever pray, precisely because there is nothing in them for you, no warmth, no reward, no felt sense of God, only the bare bones of fidelity. Hallesby said that prayer is essentially not our activity but God's, not our reaching up but his reaching down, and that the numb and helpless pray-er, who has nothing to offer and knows it, is in some ways closer to the truth of prayer than the one whose prayers are full of fervor and self-generated feeling. The numb pray-er cannot mistake his prayer for a performance, because there is no performance in him. He can only show up, empty, and wait. And that showing up, empty, day after day, into the grey, is not the absence of faith. It is faith at its most naked. Keep the appointment. Pray the given words. The feeling is not the prayer. The staying is the prayer.

CHAPTER TEN

Praying When You Are Angry at God

*We were told good Christians do not get
angry at God, so the angry ones went
silent, and their silence was mistaken
for peace, and underneath it their
faith quietly starved.*

I WANT TO GIVE you permission for something the church has spent centuries trying to take away, and I want to give it to you on the authority of Scripture and not merely my own opinion, because you will need the authority to believe it. You are allowed to be angry at God. Not in the sense that anger is a stage to pass through quickly on the way to acceptance. In the sense that anger, brought to God, expressed to God, prayed to God, is a legitimate and even holy form of prayer,

attested throughout the Bible, modeled by the saints, and infinitely preferable to the polite deadness that most of us substitute for it. The church taught me that anger at God was blasphemy, a sin to be repented of, and so when I was angry at God, and I have been furiously, bitterly angry at God, I hid it, I suppressed it, I prayed around it, and the suppression did not make the anger holy. It made it fester. It turned into distance, and the distance turned into doubt, and the doubt nearly turned into leaving, and all of it could have been avoided if someone had told me the truth, which is that I could have just told God I was angry.

Look at how the people of God in Scripture actually spoke to him when they were angry, because it will shock you if you have never noticed it. Jeremiah, the weeping prophet, accused God of deceiving him, said God had enticed him and overpowered him and made him a laughingstock, used language a modern believer would be terrified to use. Job, in his suffering, demanded that God answer for himself, said he would maintain his own case to God's face, refused to accept the pious explanations of his friends and insisted on taking his complaint directly to the Almighty. Moses, exhausted by the people, essentially told God to kill him rather than make him carry the burden any longer. Habakkuk stood on his watchtower and demanded that God explain how he could allow the wicked to swallow the righteous. These are not marginal figures. These are the heroes of the faith, and they spoke to God with a directness, a boldness, a raw anger, that would get a person quietly counseled out of most churches today. And God did not strike them down. God answered them. In Job's case God showed up in a whirlwind and had a conversation with him, the very conversation Job had demanded, and at the end commended Job for speaking

rightly, and condemned the friends who had defended God with lies.

Here is what I have come to understand about anger at God, and it took me years and a good deal of suffering to see it. Anger at God is only possible where there is relationship. You do not get angry at a stranger, or a machine, or a force of nature. You get angry at someone you are in relationship with, someone you had expectations of, someone you believed owed you something because of who they had promised to be. When I am angry at God, my anger is itself a testimony that I believe he is there, that I believe he is a person and not a force, that I believe he made promises and entered into a covenant and is therefore accountable to it in some way I can appeal to. The anger presupposes the relationship. And this means that anger at God, far from being the opposite of faith, is often a form of faith, a faith that takes God seriously enough to be disappointed in him, a faith that refuses the easy out of deciding he was never there. The atheist does not rage at God. I know, I was one. The atheist shrugs. The rage belongs to the believer, and it belongs to him precisely because he believes.

But I need to be careful, because there is a way of talking about anger at God that turns it into a license for a kind of permanent, self-justifying bitterness, and that is not what I am commending. There is a difference between bringing your anger to God and using your anger to withdraw from God. The first is prayer. The second is the beginning of divorce. When Job was angry, he took his anger to God, he brought it into the relationship, he demanded an audience, he stayed in the conversation even while raging. He did not go silent. He did not turn away. He turned toward, with his fists up, but he turned toward, and that turning toward, even in

fury, kept the relationship alive. The danger is not the anger. The danger is anger that curdles into avoidance, anger you nurse in private instead of pray in the open, anger that becomes the reason you stop talking to God rather than the content of what you say to him. Bring the anger. Do not let the anger take you away.

Let me tell you what my own anger at God sounded like, because I think the confession is more useful than the theory. There was a season when I was angry at God for the silence I have been describing throughout this book, angry that I had left everything to follow him, angry that I had staked my whole life and reputation on him, and that in my hour of deepest need he had given me nothing, no word, no comfort, no sense of his presence, just the ceiling and the quiet. And for a long time I could not pray this anger, because I thought it was wrong, so I prayed politely and died a little more each week. And then one night, alone, I stopped being polite. I said to God, out loud, I am angry at you. I have given you everything and you have given me silence. I do not understand you and right now I do not much like you, and I am telling you this because I have nowhere else to take it and because if you are who you say you are, you can take it, and if you cannot take it, then you are not who you say you are and I need to know that too. And I want to tell you that saying it, finally, out loud, to God, was the most alive my faith had felt in a year.

Nothing was resolved that night. The silence did not break. But something shifted, and the shift was this. I had stopped protecting God from my anger, and in stopping, I had let the anger into the relationship instead of letting it fester outside it, and the relationship, which had been slowly dying under the weight of all my polite suppression, began, faintly, to

breathe again. Because the thing that was killing my faith was never the anger. It was the hiding of the anger. It was the belief that there were parts of me God could not handle, rooms of my heart he was not allowed into, and that belief made the relationship a performance, and performances cannot survive real suffering. When I let God into the room where the anger lived, I let him into the truest room in my heart, and a relationship in which God is welcome even in the room of your rage is a relationship that can survive almost anything. So bring him your anger. Say the furious thing. He kept Job's fury in the Book and commended the man who spoke it. He can keep yours. And keeping it, he keeps you.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Prayer of the Body

*We had been trying to pray with a
mind that would not settle, and forgot
we had knees, and hands, and breath,
and that God made all of them, and
can be reached through all of them.*

WE HAVE INHERITED, MOST of us, a picture of prayer as an entirely mental activity, something that happens inside the head, a matter of thoughts directed toward God, of concentration, of the right ideas held in the right way. And this picture is not wrong so much as it is thin, and its thinness is a problem, because it locates the whole of prayer in the one faculty that is least reliable when we are suffering, the mind, which races, and wanders, and doubts, and cannot be commanded to settle just because we want it to. If prayer is only mental, then prayer is at the mercy of a mind that, in the

dark seasons, will not cooperate. But you are not only a mind. You are a body. God made you a body, gave you knees and hands and lungs and a voice, and it turns out these are not obstacles to prayer but instruments of it, and in the seasons when the mind will not pray, the body sometimes can.

Consider posture, which the modern church has largely abandoned and the ancient church took with great seriousness. The Bible is full of bodies at prayer, and the bodies are not incidental. People fall on their faces. They kneel. They lift up their hands. They bow their heads. They stand. They lie prostrate on the ground. David danced. Solomon knelt with his hands spread toward heaven. Daniel got down on his knees three times a day. Jesus knelt in Gethsemane and, Luke tells us, fell to the ground. These postures are not arbitrary, and they are not mere cultural decoration to be stripped away in favor of a purely inward prayer. The body preaches to the soul. When I kneel, my body is saying something my racing mind cannot manage to say, it is confessing that I am small and God is great, it is enacting a humility my thoughts refuse to hold, and the enactment shapes the thoughts, slowly, from the outside in. I have knelt on hard floors when my mind was a storm, and the kneeling did what my thinking could not, it gathered me, it said with my knees what my head could not say, here I am, low, before God.

This is not superstition and it is not works-righteousness, and I want to guard it from both misreadings. Kneeling does not make your prayer more effective in the vending-machine sense, and God is not more impressed by the man on his knees than the man in his chair. But we are embodied creatures, and our bodies and souls are not two separate

compartments but one integrated person, and what we do with the body affects what happens in the soul, always, whether we attend to it or not. The posture of the body during prayer is not decoration. It is participation. The whole self prays, or something less than the whole self prays, and in the dark seasons, when the mind has gone numb or wild, the body can lead, and the mind can follow the body into a prayer it could not have reached on its own. Kneel, and let your knees pray while your head catches up.

And then there is breath, which is the most ancient and most overlooked instrument of prayer. The very word for spirit in Hebrew, *ruach*, and in Greek, *pneuma*, is also the word for breath and for wind, so that in the languages God chose for his revelation, the Spirit and the breath are named by the same word, and this is not an accident of vocabulary but a window into something deep. You are breathing right now. You have been breathing since before you could think, and you will breathe until you die, and every breath is a small receiving of life you did not manufacture. The Christian tradition has long known that the breath itself can become prayer, that the simple act of drawing air in and letting it out can be joined to the name of God, so that a person with no words left, whose mind cannot form a sentence, can still pray with the body's oldest rhythm. The tradition of the Jesus Prayer, prayed by the Eastern churches for many centuries, does exactly this, joining a short phrase, *Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me*, to the rhythm of the breath, so that prayer becomes as continuous and as unforced as breathing itself.

I want to commend this to the numb and the exhausted especially, because it asks so little and gives so much. When you cannot pray, you can still breathe, and you can pray your breathing. Breathe in, slowly, and as you do, receive. You did

not make this breath. It is given. Breathe out, slowly, and as you do, release, hand back, let go. There is a prayer in this that requires no eloquence, no concentration you cannot muster, no feeling you do not have. It requires only that you notice the breath God is already giving you and turn it, gently, into an acknowledgment of him. In the hospital, sitting with the dying, I have prayed this way when there were no words that would not have been lies. Just the breath. Just the receiving and the releasing. And it was prayer, real prayer, the prayer of a body that could still turn toward God when the mind had run out of anything to say.

The ordinary movements of the day can become prayer too, and this is the deepest reach of the prayer of the body, though I will say more about it in the chapter on praying without ceasing. The washing of dishes, the walking to work, the holding of a child, the labor of the hands, all of it can be offered, all of it can be turned, quietly, into a form of prayer that does not require you to stop and close your eyes and generate a mental state. Brother Lawrence, the seventeenth-century monk who worked in a monastery kitchen and left behind a small book his friends assembled after his death in 1691, said that he had learned to feel as close to God among the pots and pans as he did at the sacrament, that the clatter of the kitchen did not disturb his sense of God's presence, that he had made his ordinary work into a continual conversation with God by simply doing it in God's company. This is the prayer of the body at its fullest, the whole embodied life, the hands and the feet and the daily labor, all of it turned Godward, so that prayer is no longer a thing you stop your life to do but a way of doing your life.

So if your mind will not pray, do not conclude that you cannot pray. Come at it from the body. Kneel when your

thoughts are a storm and let your knees confess what your head cannot. Lift your hands when your heart is closed and let the openness of your palms teach your closed heart what openness feels like. Breathe the name of God when you have no other words, and let the oldest rhythm in you carry the prayer your mind has abandoned. Walk, work, hold, wash, and offer all of it. You are not a ghost trapped in a machine, trying to pray past the interference of your flesh. You are a body, made by God, loved by God, and destined, the Scripture says, for the resurrection of that very body, and the body you have been given is not an obstacle to prayer. It is one of the ways home. When the dark is too thick for the mind to find its way, the body sometimes knows the way, and the way is knees, and hands, and breath, and the ordinary labor of ordinary hands, all of it turned, quietly, toward the God who made it.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Fixed Prayers When You Have No Words

*We were told that written prayers were
less sincere than spontaneous ones,
and so, when our own words dried up,
we had nothing, and the people who
had memorized the old prayers had a
well to draw from in the desert.*

I WAS TAUGHT, EARLY in my Christian life, to be suspicious of written prayers. The people who taught me faith held that spontaneous prayer, prayer in your own words from your own heart, was the sincere kind, and that reciting prayers written by someone else was, at best, a crutch, and at worst a dead formalism, the empty repetition Jesus warned against. And so for years I prayed only spontaneously, only in my own

words, and I thought this made my prayers more real. And then I hit the seasons this whole book has been describing, the numbness, the silence, the anger, the dark, and I discovered the terrible weakness of a prayer life built entirely on spontaneity. When my own words dried up, I had nothing. The well I had been drawing from was my own heart, and my own heart had gone dry, and there was no other well, because I had been taught to distrust every well but my own. Meanwhile there were Christians who, when their own words failed, could reach for two thousand years of prayers written by people who had walked through the same dark, and they were not left mute. They had a well that did not depend on the state of their own heart. I wanted that well. I had been taught to despise it, and I had been taught wrong.

Let me correct the misunderstanding at the root, because it is a serious one. The idea that spontaneous prayer is more sincere than written prayer assumes that sincerity lives in the origin of the words, that a prayer is real only if you generated it yourself in the moment. But this is not how sincerity works anywhere else in life. When I stood at the front of a church and said to my wife the vows the church had written, I did not compose them on the spot, and no one thought them insincere for being borrowed. The vows were written by others, said by millions before us, and they were more true for it, not less, because they said what needed saying better than I could have said it in the rush of the moment, and I meant every borrowed word. The sincerity was not in the origin of the words. It was in the meaning I brought to them. And it is exactly the same with prayer. When I pray a prayer written by a saint four hundred years ago, the words are not less mine because I did not compose them. They become mine in the praying, and often they say what I could not have

said, they give shape to a longing I could feel but not articulate, they pray me better than I could pray myself.

Consider that Jesus himself, in his hour of greatest agony, prayed a written prayer. On the cross, he did not compose a spontaneous cry. He prayed Psalm 22, my God, my God, why have you forsaken me, a prayer written by David a thousand years before, a prayer Jesus had memorized as a Jewish boy and carried in his body until the moment he needed it most, when his own words might have failed him but the given words were there. And Stephen, dying, prayed the words of Jesus. And Christians for two thousand years, at the hour of their death, have prayed the Psalms and the Lord's Prayer and the prayers of the church, because in the extremity of dying, when the mind cannot compose, the memorized prayer is there, worn smooth by a lifetime of use, ready to carry the soul across when the soul can no longer walk on its own. The fixed prayer is not the crutch of the weak-faithed. It is the provision of a wise God for the hour when we have no words, and that hour comes for all of us.

The Psalter is the first and greatest of these wells, and I want to press it on you specifically, because it is the prayer book God himself gave. The Psalms are not merely poems about prayer or examples of prayer. They are prayers, given to the people of God to be prayed, and the church prayed them, all of them, in order, for most of its history, until we recently decided we preferred our own words and our own favorite verses and left the hard Psalms unprayed. Peterson spent his life urging the church back to praying the whole Psalter, and he made an argument I have never been able to shake. He said that when we pray only our own prayers, we pray only about the things that are already on our minds, and so our prayers become a mirror of our own small concerns, but

when we pray the Psalms, all of them, in order, we are drawn into a range of human experience far larger than our own, we are made to pray words of rage we would not have chosen, words of praise we did not feel like praising, words of penitence we were avoiding, and in this way the Psalms enlarge us, they teach us to feel and to pray things our own hearts were too narrow to reach on their own.

There is a whole architecture built for this, and I want to at least name it, because it may be the thing that saves your prayer life. The daily office, the fixed hours of prayer, the practice of stopping at appointed times through the day to pray set prayers and set Psalms, is one of the oldest disciplines of the church, older than the printed Bible, older than most of the theology we argue about. Monks structured their whole lives around it, seven times a day and once in the night, praying through the entire Psalter every week or every month, so that the words of God's own prayer book soaked into them until the Psalms became the involuntary language of their hearts. You do not have to be a monk to draw on this. There are prayer books, the Book of Common Prayer chief among them, that will hand you a structure, morning and evening, a Psalm, a reading, a set of prayers, so that when you sit down to pray and have nothing, you are not left staring at the ceiling trying to manufacture words. You open the book. The words are there. You pray them. And on the days you feel nothing, the book prays for you, and on the days you feel everything, the book keeps you from drowning in it.

Let me speak directly to the fear that this is empty ritual, the vain repetition Jesus condemned, because it is a real fear and it deserves a real answer. When Jesus warned against vain repetition, he was warning against the pagan idea that prayers work like incantations, that piling up words and

repeating them many times will compel the gods to act, that the mechanism is in the repetition itself. That is the vending machine again, and Jesus rightly condemned it. But the repetition of a good prayer prayed with attention and meaning is not that. The problem was never repetition. Jesus prayed the same prayer three times in Gethsemane, in the same words. The problem was the belief that the words themselves, mechanically repeated, compel God. A written prayer prayed as a genuine address to a God you are actually turning toward is not vain repetition. It is the same thing as any other prayer, honest speech directed to God, and the fact that you did not compose the words changes nothing about the honesty, and may in fact deepen it, because the words of the saints are often more honest than the words we would have chosen to protect ourselves.

So build yourself a well before the drought comes. This is the practical counsel I most want you to take from this chapter. Do not wait until your own words have dried up to go looking for other words, because in the drought you will not have the strength to look. Now, while you can, memorize some Psalms. Learn the Lord's Prayer so deeply it comes to you without thought. Find a prayer book and let it teach you a rhythm. Store up the words of the church against the day when your own heart has nothing to say, so that when that day comes, and it will come, you are not left mute in the dark, but can reach, half-conscious, exhausted, numb, for the words that a thousand years of the faithful have prayed in exactly your condition, and pray them, and be carried by them, until your own voice returns. The person who despises fixed prayer is fine until the drought. The person who has hidden the given words in his heart has a well in the desert. Dig the well now.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Praying for Others When You Cannot Pray for Yourself

When our own prayers had turned to ash, we could sometimes still lift up a name that was not our own, and in the lifting we found we had not stopped praying after all.

THERE IS A STRANGE mercy in intercession, in the praying for others, and I discovered it by accident in a season when I could not pray for myself at all. My own life had gone dark, my own prayers had hit the ceiling for so long I had nearly given up making them, and I found that when I sat down to pray, everything to do with my own needs and griefs came out flat

and dead, because I no longer believed, in my gut, that praying about them would do anything. But I was a pastor, and people had asked me to pray for them, and one morning, out of duty more than faith, I began to pray for them by name, and I noticed something. Praying for them did not feel dead. Lifting up a name that was not my own, carrying to God a burden that was not my own, I found a small warmth I could not find when I prayed for myself, and I realized that when the self has gone too dark to pray for, the others can still be prayed for, and in praying for them, you have not stopped praying after all.

I think this works for reasons worth understanding. When I pray for myself in a dark season, my prayer is tangled up with all my despair, all my doubt about whether God hears me, all my accumulated disappointment, and the tangle can become so thick that the prayer cannot get through. But when I pray for someone else, I am, for a moment, freed from the tangle. My despair about my own life does not attach to my prayer for my neighbor's dying mother. I can believe, on her behalf, in a God I cannot quite believe in on my own, because my hope for her is not contaminated by my grief for myself. Intercession lets you borrow, as it were, a cleaner belief, a belief you can hold for another that you cannot hold for yourself, and in holding it for another, you keep hold of it at all. The name you lift is a rope, and the rope, thrown for someone else, turns out to keep you from falling too.

This is one of the deepest reasons the church prays together, and it is a reason we have largely forgotten in our individualism. We were never meant to pray alone. The Lord's Prayer is plural from the first word, our Father, not my Father, give us this day, forgive us, lead us, as though Jesus knew that

prayer is fundamentally a corporate act, the family speaking together to the Father, and that no one prays only for himself. And the great gift of this is that on the days you cannot pray, the church prays for you. When your faith has gone dark, someone else's has not, and they are praying, and their praying holds you up when you cannot hold yourself up, the way the friends in the Gospel carried the paralyzed man to Jesus and lowered him through the roof, and Jesus, Mark tells us, saw their faith, the faith of the friends, and healed the man who could not get to Jesus on his own. Sometimes you are the paralyzed man, and you cannot get yourself to God, and you need friends whose faith will carry you. And sometimes you are the friend, carrying someone who cannot walk, and your prayer for them is the roof they are lowered through.

I want to say something to the person who feels they have no right to intercede, who feels that their own faith is too weak, their own life too much of a mess, to presume to pray for anyone else. I felt this. Who was I, whose own prayers hit the ceiling, to pray for the healing of another, as though I had some access to God that worked? But this gets intercession exactly backwards. Intercession is not a service performed by the spiritually strong on behalf of the weak. It is not that you must first attain a working prayer life and then, from your position of spiritual health, dispense prayers to the needy. Intercession is the weak praying for the weak, the beggar telling another beggar where he found bread, and it works, when it works, not because of the quality of the one praying but because of the character of the God prayed to. Your weak, doubting, half-believing prayer for your neighbor is heard on the same terms as the strongest saint's, because it was never your strength that made prayer work. Moses interceded for a

people who did not deserve it, standing in the gap, and Moses was a murderer with a stutter who had argued with God about his own inadequacy, and God heard him, not because Moses was worthy but because God is merciful.

There is a particular form of this that I want to press on you, which is praying for the people you cannot stand, praying for your enemies, because Jesus commanded it and because it does something to the one who prays it that nothing else can do. Pray for those who persecute you, he said, and I used to think this was purely for the benefit of the persecutor, a way of doing them good. But I have come to see that it is at least as much for the one who prays. It is nearly impossible to keep hating someone you are genuinely praying for. When you lift up before God the name of the person who wounded you, and ask God to bless them, actually bless them, the prayer works on your own heart like water on a stone, slowly, over years, wearing away the hatred you were nursing, until one day you find you can think of them without the old fire, and you did not decide to forgive them by an act of will, the praying did it to you while you were not looking. I have prayed for people I despised, through gritted teeth, meaning it barely, and the praying changed me long before it changed anything else. Intercession for the enemy is the slowest and surest cure for the poison of resentment there is.

But I do not want to leave the impression that intercession always works in the sense the vending machine means, because this book has been honest about that from the start and I will not stop now. You will pray for people, by name, faithfully, for years, and some of them will not be healed, will not come home, will not be saved from the thing you begged God to save them from. I have prayed for people at their

bedsides who died anyway. I have interceded for prodigals who never returned. The mystery of unanswered prayer is not suspended just because the prayer is for someone else, and it can be even more agonizing to watch a prayer for another go unanswered than to bear the unanswering of a prayer for yourself. I have no formula for this. I have only the same counsel as before, that the intercession, even unanswered, is not wasted, because it is love, and love offered to God on behalf of another is never wasted, even when it does not get the outcome, because it joins you to the God who loves that person more than you do, and it joins you to the person you are praying for, and both of those joinings are real goods that survive the unanswering.

So when you cannot pray for yourself, pray for someone else. When your own well is dry, carry water to your neighbor, and you may find the well was not as dry as you thought. Make a list of names. Say them before God, one by one, the ones you love and the ones you cannot stand, the ones who are dying and the ones who have wounded you, and lift each one up, and in the lifting, discover that you are still in the conversation, that the God you could not talk to about your own dark can still be talked to about someone else's, and that in talking to him about them, you have kept the line open, you have stayed in the relationship, you have prayed after all. The prayer for another is a rope thrown across the dark, and it lands on the far shore where God is, and it turns out to be tied, at your end, to you, and it holds you fast while you throw it. Intercession does not require a working faith. It requires only a name, and a willingness to lift it, and the willingness to lift a name is nearly always still there, even when everything else has gone.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Simply Being With God

We had turned prayer into a transaction with an agenda, a list to get through, and forgot that the deepest prayer might be to sit with someone we love and say nothing at all.

THERE IS A KIND of prayer that has almost no words in it, and I avoided it for years because I did not understand it and because it frightened me, and I want to tell you about it now, gently, because it may be the very thing your exhausted, overworded, agenda-driven prayer life is starving for. We are so used to prayer as speech, prayer as the presentation of requests, prayer as a monologue we deliver to God with our list of concerns, that the idea of prayer as simply being with God, without words, without an agenda, without accomplishing anything, strikes us as either lazy or mystical,

a thing for people with more time and less to do than us. But it is neither lazy nor exotic. It is the oldest and simplest thing there is, and every person who has ever loved another person already knows how to do it, even if they have never done it with God.

Think about what happens between two people who love each other and have known each other a long time. In the early days, they talk constantly, they fill every silence, they have so much to say and so much to establish. But as the love deepens and the years accumulate, something changes. They become able to be together without talking. They sit on the porch in the evening and say nothing for an hour, and the silence is not empty, it is full, it is a different and deeper form of communion than all their earlier talking, because now they are simply present to each other, resting in a togetherness that no longer needs to be constantly rebuilt with words. My wife and I can sit in a room together, each doing our own thing, saying nothing, and it is one of the truest forms of our love, this comfortable wordless presence, and it took decades to arrive at. If this is how it works with the people we love, why would we assume prayer must always be words? Why would the deepest communion with God be the most verbal one?

The tradition has a name for this wordless prayer, and it calls it contemplation, and I have to rescue that word from the fog that surrounds it, because it has been made to sound like an advanced spiritual technique available only to mystics, and it is nothing of the kind. Contemplation is simply resting in the presence of God without the constant activity of thinking about him or talking to him. It is turning the whole self toward God and then being quiet, and staying

quiet, and letting God be God without requiring anything of the encounter, without an agenda, without a list, without even the demand that you feel something. It is the prayer of simply being there. Teresa of Avila and John of the Cross wrote about it at length in the 1500s, and they insisted, against the spiritual snobbery of their own day, that it was not reserved for the elite, that God offers this quiet resting to ordinary souls, that it is not something you achieve by technique but something you receive by making yourself available and still.

I resisted this for a long time because I am, by temperament and by profession, a man of words. I make my living with words. I preach, I write, I counsel, all words, and I brought this into my prayer life, so that prayer for me was always speech, always the marshaling of the right words to say to God, always an activity I performed. And the idea of simply being quiet before God felt like doing nothing, felt like a failure to pray, because I equated praying with speaking and if I was not speaking I was not praying. And it was only when my words ran out, in one of the dark seasons this book keeps returning to, that I stumbled into wordless prayer, because I had no words left, and instead of concluding that I therefore could not pray, I sat down anyway and was simply, wordlessly, present, turned toward God with nothing to say, and I found, to my astonishment, that this was prayer, maybe the realest prayer I had prayed in months, precisely because there was no performance in it, no words to hide behind, just me, and God, and the silence between us that was not empty.

I have to be honest that this kind of prayer is hard for us in a way it was not hard for our ancestors, and the difficulty is worth naming. We are the most distracted people who have ever lived. Our minds have been trained, by a thousand devices and demands, to flinch away from silence, to reach

for stimulation the instant a quiet moment opens, to be unable to sit still without a screen. And so when we try to be quiet before God, we discover that we have nearly lost the capacity for it, that our minds will not settle, that the silence is unbearable and we reach for our phones like a reflex. This is a genuine spiritual wound of our particular moment, and I will not pretend the practice is easy. It is not easy. It is a discipline, and like all disciplines it goes badly at first, and your mind will wander a hundred times in five minutes, and you will feel you are failing. You are not failing. The gentle returning of your wandering mind to God, a hundred times, is itself the prayer. The wandering is not the failure. The returning is the practice. Each return is a small act of love, a turning again toward the one you keep drifting away from, and a prayer made of a hundred gentle returnings is a beautiful prayer, however scattered it felt from inside.

Let me tell you how to begin, not as a technique that produces results, but as a way of making yourself available. Sit somewhere quiet. Put down the phone, actually away, in another room. Close your eyes or lower them. And then simply turn your attention toward God, and rest there, without trying to say anything, without trying to feel anything, without trying to accomplish anything. When your mind wanders, and it will, gently bring it back, perhaps with a single word, a name, Jesus, Father, or a short phrase you return to, not as a chant to empty the mind but as a way to keep turning the mind toward God. And then just be there, for a few minutes at first, longer as you are able, in the presence of the God who is already present whether you feel him or not. You are not doing this to get anything. That is the whole point and the hardest part. You are doing it for the same reason you sit on the porch with someone you love and say

nothing. You are doing it to be with him.

And here is why this matters so much for the person praying in the dark, the person this whole book is for. The wordless prayer, the simple being-with, does not depend on the silence of God breaking. When I sit in wordless prayer, I am not waiting for God to speak, and so his not speaking does not defeat the prayer. I am simply being present to a God who is present, and his presence does not require his speech, any more than my wife's presence on the porch requires her to say anything. This is prayer that can survive the silence of God, because it was never built on God's words in the first place. It was built on his presence, which the Scripture promises never departs, though we cannot always feel it. So on the days when God says nothing, when every worded prayer hits the ceiling, you can still sit with him in the silence, not demanding words, not requiring an answer, simply keeping company with the God who is there, and in that keeping company you may find the peace you could never argue or feel your way to, the peace of two who love each other, sitting together in the dark, saying nothing, and needing to say nothing, because the being together is the whole of it, and it is enough.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Dark Night, and Why the Silence Can Be Intimacy

*We had been reading the darkness as
abandonment, and a Spanish friar
told us we had it backwards, that this
particular darkness was the shadow of
a light too great to see by, and that God
was nearer in it than in all the
consolations we grieved to lose.*

I HAVE TO INTRODUCE you to a man now, because he understood something about the dark that I have found nowhere else stated so precisely, and it changed how I read

my own long seasons of silence. His name was John of the Cross, a Spanish friar and reformer who lived in the 1500s, who was imprisoned by his own religious brothers for nine months in a cell so small he could barely stand, in the dark and the cold, and who came out of that imprisonment having written some of the most luminous poetry about God in any language. He gave us a phrase we use loosely and wrongly, the dark night of the soul, and I want to recover what he actually meant by it, because the recovery is medicine for exactly the condition this book keeps circling.

We use the phrase to mean any hard time, any depression, any season of suffering. But John meant something far more specific and far stranger. He meant a particular kind of darkness that comes not despite the soul's progress toward God but because of it, a darkness that is not the withdrawal of God but the effect of God's nearness on a soul not yet able to bear it. His argument, and I want to state it carefully because it is easy to misunderstand, is that there are two kinds of spiritual darkness, and they must not be confused. There is the darkness that comes from sin, from turning away from God, and this darkness is bad and must be repented of and fled. But there is another darkness, and this one comes from God himself, and it feels almost identical from inside, which is why it is so easy to mistake, and yet it is the opposite thing. It is the darkness a soul enters when God is weaning it off its dependence on spiritual feelings, off the consolations and warmth and felt sweetness that God gave it in the beginning, so that it can learn to love God for himself rather than for the good feelings he provides.

Think about what this means, because it is a reversal of everything the vending-machine faith assumes. In the early

stages of the life with God, John says, God often gives the soul great felt consolations, warmth in prayer, sweetness, a strong sense of his presence, the way a mother gives a nursing infant milk. And the soul, being a soul, comes to love the consolations, comes to depend on them, comes, without realizing it, to seek the feelings more than it seeks God, to pray for the warmth rather than for God himself. And so God, in mercy, takes the consolations away. He withdraws the felt sweetness, not because he has withdrawn himself, but precisely because he is drawing the soul deeper, weaning it, teaching it to walk instead of nurse, and the withdrawal of the felt presence feels, from inside, exactly like abandonment. The soul cries out that God has left it. But God has not left it. God has come so close, and is doing such deep work in it, that the work happens below the level of feeling, in the dark, where the soul cannot perceive it, and the very darkness the soul grieves is the shadow cast by a nearness too great to be felt as light.

I do not want to claim more for this than I know, and I want to guard it from a cruel misuse. It would be a terrible thing to tell every suffering person that their darkness is the secret intimacy of God, because some darkness is just darkness, some is depression that needs treatment, some is the plain silence I refused to explain away in an earlier chapter, and I am not taking that back. John himself insisted on careful discernment, on not mistaking every dryness for the dark night of contemplation. So I offer this not as an explanation for all your darkness but as a possibility for some of it, a possibility the church has largely forgotten, that there is a kind of felt absence of God that is not his absence at all but a deeper mode of his presence, one that will make no sense to you while you are in it, one you may only recognize looking

back, years later, when you see that in the very season you felt most abandoned, something was being done in you that could not have been done in the light.

Let me tell you what this reframing did for me, because it did not remove my darkness but it changed my reading of it, and the changed reading changed everything about how I bore it. For years I had read my seasons of silence as failures, as evidence that God was displeased with me or absent from me or perhaps not there at all, and this reading added to the darkness a second darkness, the despair of thinking the darkness meant I was lost. And then I encountered John of the Cross, and I entertained the possibility, only the possibility, that at least some of my darkness might be the other kind, might be God weaning me off my dependence on feeling him so that I could learn to love him without the reward of feeling, might be intimacy disguised as absence. And I cannot tell you this made the darkness pleasant. It did not. But it removed the second darkness, the despair, because now I could hold the silence not as a verdict against me but as a possible sign of God working too deep to be felt, and I could stay in it, and even, on my better days, trust it, the way a patient trusts a surgeon he cannot see working while he is under.

The deepest thing John gives us is this, and it is the thing I most want you to carry. The goal of the life with God is not to feel God. The goal is to love God and to be united with God, and feeling is only a means to that end, a scaffolding God erects around a soul in the early days and then, in mercy, removes, because scaffolding left up forever prevents the building from being seen. When God takes away your felt sense of him, he may be taking away the scaffolding because the building is far enough along to stand without it. And the

proof of this, the thing that distinguishes the holy darkness from the darkness of sin, is what the soul does in the dark. The soul in the darkness of sin drifts away from God, loses interest, goes cold. But the soul in the dark night, John says, finds its love for God actually deepening even as its feeling of God disappears, finds itself more devoted, more longing, more faithful in the absence of all reward, because the love has been purified of its dependence on payoff and has become love of God for God's own sake. If you find that in your darkness you love God more even though you feel him less, that you keep turning toward him with no reward for the turning, that your faithfulness has grown while your feelings have vanished, then take heart, because that is not the mark of a soul God has abandoned. That is the mark of a soul God is drawing into the deepest intimacy there is, the intimacy that no longer needs to be felt to be real, the love that survives the removal of everything except itself.

So I will say the thing that sounds impossible and mean it. The silence of God, which I have refused throughout this book to explain away, may in some seasons be not the failure of intimacy but its deepening. Not always. Not necessarily. I hold this loosely and offer it humbly. But it is at least possible that the very darkness you are grieving, the very silence you are enduring, the very absence of all the warmth you used to feel, is the sign that God has drawn nearer than the warmth ever let you come, that he is doing in the dark a work the light would only have interrupted, that he has taken the consolations away because you were loving them instead of him and he loves you too much to let you settle for the gifts when he is offering himself. In the dark, unable to feel him, keep loving him. Keep turning toward him with nothing coming back. That faithfulness in the dark, that love without

PRAYER IN THE DARK

reward, is not the death of your prayer life. According to a man who learned it in a freezing cell and came out singing, it is the deepest prayer of all.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Praying Without Ceasing in an Ordinary Life

*We heard the command to pray
without ceasing and despaired,
because we had jobs, and children,
and only twenty minutes we could give
to God, until we understood that he
had not asked for our twenty minutes.
He had asked for our life.*

PAUL TOLD THE THESSALONIANS to pray without ceasing, three words that have tormented ordinary Christians for two thousand years, because they seem to describe an

impossibility. Pray without ceasing? I have a job that requires my whole attention. I have children who need me every waking hour. I have a body that demands sleep. How can any person with an actual life pray without ceasing, when I can barely find fifteen minutes of quiet in a day, and half of those I spend fighting to stay awake? For years this command produced in me only guilt, a sense that real prayer belonged to monks and retirees, people with empty hours to fill, and that my own frantic, interrupted, exhausted life could never rise to it. I was reading it wrong, and reading it wrong was keeping me from the very thing it was offering.

The mistake was thinking that pray without ceasing meant do the activity of formal prayer continuously, without stopping, as though Paul were commanding me to keep up a nonstop verbal monologue to God through every meeting and diaper change and grocery run, which is manifestly impossible and which Paul, who worked with his hands making tents, would have known to be impossible. That is not what he meant. To pray without ceasing is not to perform the activity of prayer without interruption. It is to live the whole of life in a continual God-ward orientation, to develop a habitual turning of the heart toward God that runs underneath all your activity the way a river runs underneath the traffic on a bridge, present and constant even when you are not attending to it, surfacing into explicit words whenever there is a gap, and coloring everything even when there are no words at all. It is not an added activity crammed into an already full day. It is a way of doing the full day.

Brother Lawrence, the kitchen monk I mentioned before, understood this better than any theologian, and he called it the practice of the presence of God, and it is the most

practical wisdom about ordinary prayer I have ever found. He said that he had given up the elaborate methods of prayer that had frustrated him and had settled on one simple thing, to keep himself always in the presence of God, to do everything, however small, for the love of God and in the awareness of God, so that the peeling of a potato became a prayer, and the washing of a dish became a prayer, not because he stopped to say words over the potato but because he did the peeling in God's company, aware of God, offering the small labor to God. His prayer was not an interruption of his work. It was the manner of his work. And he claimed, and those who knew him confirmed, that he lived in a nearly constant quiet joy, not because his life was easy, kitchen work in a monastery is hard and dull, but because he had learned to be with God in the middle of it.

This is available to you, in your ordinary and interrupted life, and I want to make it concrete, because abstractions about God-ward orientation are useless if you do not know how to begin on a Tuesday. Begin by turning the transitions of your day into small prayers. The moment you wake, before your feet hit the floor, a breath of turning toward God, a word, here I am, or thank you, or help. The commute, so much of it dead time we fill with noise, becomes a place of prayer, not formal, just a continuing quiet conversation, the day's worries handed over one by one, the people you will see lifted up, the traffic itself borne with God rather than alone. The small frustrations, the spilled coffee, the difficult coworker, the child's tantrum, each one a place to turn, briefly, toward God, not with eloquence, just a turning, help, mercy, here, again. The meal, blessed not out of ritual duty but as a real acknowledgment that this too is from God. And the ordinary labor of your hands, whatever it is, done as Brother Lawrence

peeled his potatoes, in God's company, offered to God, so that the work itself becomes the prayer.

What this does, over time, is dissolve the false wall between the sacred and the ordinary that has crippled so much of our prayer. We have been taught, most of us, that prayer is a special activity that happens in a special mode at a special time in a special posture, and that the rest of life is secular, un-prayed, ordinary in the bad sense. And so we cram our whole relationship with God into a few minutes of formal prayer and then live twenty-three hours and forty-five minutes as functional atheists, as though God were confined to the fifteen minutes and absent from the rest. Praying without ceasing tears down that wall. It insists that God is as present in the kitchen as in the sanctuary, as available in the meeting as in the prayer closet, as near in the middle of the chaos of small children as in the silence of the retreat, and that the whole of your ordinary life can be lived toward him, turned toward him, offered to him, so that there is no longer a sacred fifteen minutes and a secular rest, but one whole life, lived in his presence, which is prayer without ceasing.

I want to say a word to the parents especially, and to anyone whose life is so full of the care of others that they have no quiet hours, because you are the ones this command most torments and most liberates. When my sons were small, there were years I could not have a quiet time. There was no quiet. There was no time. I was outnumbered and exhausted and the idea of a peaceful hour with God and an open Bible was a cruel fantasy. And I felt, in those years, that I had lost my prayer life, that fatherhood had cost me God. It had not. What it had cost me was a particular form of prayer, the quiet formal hour, and I grieved that form and I should have grieved it. But it had not cost me prayer, because prayer

without ceasing was still available, and in fact those years taught me it better than any peaceful season could have. I learned to pray in fragments, in the two minutes before the baby woke, in the whispered plea over a feverish child at three in the morning, in the exhausted gratitude at the end of an impossible day. I learned to pray my children themselves, to hold each one before God as I held him in my arms, to make the very labor of fathering into an offering. The frantic, interrupted, sleep-deprived prayer of a parent is not a lesser prayer than the monk's serene hour. It may be a greater one, because it is prayed with no leisure, no reward, no felt peace, just the bare turning of an exhausted heart toward God in the two-minute gaps of a life given away to others.

So do not despair at the command to pray without ceasing, and do not conclude that a busy and ordinary life has locked you out of the deep places of prayer. It has not. It has only locked you out of one form of prayer, the leisured form, and offered you, in exchange, the form Paul actually commanded, which is the whole life turned toward God, the transitions prayed, the labor offered, the frustrations turned into a hundred small returnings, the children and the coworkers and the traffic and the dishes all borne in the company of God. This is not less than the monk's prayer. It is the same prayer, worn into the fabric of an ordinary day, and it is the prayer most of us are actually called to, the sanctifying of the ordinary, the discovery that God was never confined to the prayer closet but was in the kitchen the whole time, waiting to be noticed, offering himself in the middle of the dishes, asking not for our twenty minutes but for our life.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The God Who Prays in Us

*We had been straining to reach up to a
God far off, and Paul told us the truth,
that the reaching itself was already
God, that the Spirit was praying in us
the whole time we thought we were
praying alone.*

WE COME NOW TO the verse this book takes its epigraph from, and I have saved it for near the end because it is, I think, the deepest thing the New Testament says about prayer, and it undoes, quietly and completely, the whole anxious picture of prayer most of us have been laboring under. Paul writes to the Romans that the Spirit helps us in our weakness, that we do not know what to pray for as we

ought, but that the Spirit himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words. Sit with what that claims. It claims that when you do not know how to pray, which is most of the time, and when your prayers are too broken and confused and wordless to amount to anything, which is often, the Spirit of God himself is praying in you, taking your inarticulate groaning and making it into intercession before the Father, so that your worst and most broken prayer is not, in fact, yours alone, but is caught up into a prayer that God is praying inside you.

I need you to feel how completely this reverses the picture we started with. Through this whole book I have described prayer as a man talking into the ceiling, uncertain anyone is there, straining to reach up to a distant God, and I have refused to pretend that straining is not real, because it is real, and it is the honest experience of prayer in the dark. But Paul is telling us something that runs underneath that experience, something we cannot feel and can only believe. He is telling us that even in the moment we feel most alone in our praying, most uncertain, most convinced our words are hitting the ceiling and dropping dead, God the Spirit is present within us, praying. The straining upward that feels so lonely is not the whole story. Underneath it, or within it, God is already at work, praying in us what we cannot pray ourselves, so that prayer turns out not to be primarily our activity at all, our achievement, our reaching, but God's, God reaching into us and praying from the inside out.

This is what Hallesby was pointing at when he said that prayer is essentially not the work of the strong but the helplessness of the weak turned toward God, that the fervor and the eloquence and the accomplishment we associate with

good prayer are beside the point, that God is drawn to our need and not our performance. If the Spirit prays in us, then the quality of our prayer does not finally depend on our skill or our feeling or our faith, but on the Spirit who is doing the praying, and the Spirit does not need our eloquence, does not require our warmth, is not defeated by our numbness or our doubt or our rage. The Spirit takes the raw material we bring, however broken, the groaning too deep for words, the wordless ache, the numb showing-up, the angry outburst, the confused half-belief, and makes it into prayer, real prayer, prayer that reaches the Father, because the Spirit is God and God can make a prayer out of anything, even out of our inability to pray.

Consider what this means for the person who has come to the end of themselves in prayer, the person this whole book is for. You have told me you do not know how to pray. Paul says, neither did anyone, we do not know what to pray for as we ought, and that not-knowing is not the disqualification you feared, it is the very condition Paul addresses, the very weakness the Spirit was sent to help. You have told me your prayers are wordless, that you groan more than you speak, that there are depths in you that have no language. Paul says the Spirit intercedes with groanings too deep for words, that the very wordlessness you took as the failure of your prayer is the exact form the Spirit's prayer takes in you. You have told me you are weak, that your faith is thin, that you can barely believe anyone is listening. Paul says the Spirit helps us in our weakness, present tense, ongoing, now, in the weakness itself, not after you have overcome it. The Spirit does not wait for you to become strong before he prays in you. He prays in you precisely because you are weak, and the weakness is where he works.

I have to tell you what this did to me when I finally understood it, because I had read this passage many times as a preacher and expounded it and never let it touch me, and then one night in the dark it touched me. I was praying badly, as I so often was, hitting the ceiling, sure I was talking to no one, and I remembered this verse, and I thought, if this is true, then even this, even this broken dead prayer I am praying right now into what feels like an empty sky, even this is being prayed by the Spirit in me, and my not being able to feel it changes nothing about whether it is happening, because it was never dependent on my feeling in the first place. And something in me let go of a burden I had carried my whole Christian life, the burden of thinking that the success of my prayer depended on me, on my getting it right, on my mustering the feeling or the faith or the words. It did not depend on me. It never had. The Spirit was praying in me the whole time, in every broken prayer, in every numb showing-up, in every furious outburst, in every wordless groan, taking all of it, all my failed attempts at prayer, and making them into something that reached the Father, because that is what the Spirit does, and it is not my job to accomplish it, only to show up and let it happen.

Now I want to guard this from a misuse, because a truth this liberating can be twisted into an excuse. To say the Spirit prays in us is not to say we need not pray, that we can leave it all to the Spirit and not bother turning up. It is the opposite. It is precisely because the Spirit prays in us that we must keep turning up, keep opening our mouths, keep bringing our broken words and our wordless groans, because the Spirit prays in us as we pray, not instead of us. The showing up matters. The turning toward matters. The bringing of the broken prayer matters, not because the broken prayer

accomplishes anything by itself, but because it is the occasion, the opening, the raw material the Spirit takes up and makes into real intercession. So we do not stop praying because the Spirit prays in us. We pray with a new freedom, because we know that our part is only to show up and be honest, and the Spirit's part is to do what we cannot, and the Spirit's part is the part that actually reaches God.

This is the deepest answer to the question the whole book has been asking, the question of whether anyone is listening. Because Paul is telling us that the answer is even better than yes. The answer is not merely that God is listening on the far end of our prayer, receiving our transmission across the distance. The answer is that God is on both ends, and in the middle, that God the Father hears, and God the Spirit prays in us, and God the Son, Paul says a few verses later, is at the right hand of the Father also interceding for us, so that our poor prayer is surrounded by God on every side, prompted by the Spirit within, carried by the Son above, received by the Father, so that the whole thing, from beginning to end, is held inside the life of God. When you pray in the dark, uncertain anyone is there, the truth is that the God you are straining to reach is nearer than your own breath, praying in you the prayer you cannot pray, and your uncertainty about whether anyone is listening is answered not by a voice from the ceiling but by the quiet fact that the listening God is also the praying God, and he is praying, right now, in you.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

When You Want to Quit

We came so close, so many times, to closing our mouths for good, and the mercy was not that God gave us a reason to stay. The mercy was that he held on to us while we were deciding whether to leave.

I WANT TO TALK to the person who is nearly done, the person who has read everything in this book and part of them is nodding and part of them is thinking, it is too late for me, I have prayed too long into too much silence and I am nearly finished, I am close to closing my mouth for good and never opening it again. I know this person because I have been this person, more than once, and I do not want to end this book without walking straight into the temptation to quit prayer entirely, because it is the most honest place many of us live,

and the bright books skip right over it, and I will not.

The temptation to quit prayer rarely comes as a dramatic loss of faith. It is not usually that you decide, in a moment, that God does not exist and therefore prayer is pointless. It is quieter and more corrosive than that. It comes as a slow attrition, a gradual wearing down, a series of small surrenders. You prayed for the thing and it did not come, and you prayed for the next thing and it did not come, and the disappointments accumulated, each one small enough to survive but the sum of them heavy, and somewhere along the way you stopped expecting anything, and once you stopped expecting anything, prayer began to feel like a formality, and once it felt like a formality it began to feel like a lie, and once it felt like a lie you began, without quite deciding to, to do it less, and then rarely, and then you noticed one day that you had not really prayed, not honestly, in months, and the noticing did not even alarm you, and that lack of alarm was the most dangerous thing of all. This is how prayer dies in most people. Not with a decision. With a drift.

And I want to say to you, if you are in the drift, that the drift can be interrupted, and that interrupting it does not require you to first recover the faith or the feeling or the hope you have lost. It requires only that you open your mouth again, badly, honestly, and say the true thing, which is probably something like this, God, I am nearly done. I have almost stopped talking to you. I do not know if you are there and I am tired of not knowing and I am close to giving up. That is a prayer. It may be the most important prayer you could pray right now, because it is the truth, and the truth spoken to God, however despairing, keeps the line open, and the line staying open is everything, because a line that stays

open, even barely, even by a thread, is a relationship, and a relationship can be revived, but a line gone completely dead is a much harder thing to bring back, though not, I want to say clearly, impossible, because with God nothing is impossible, and people come back from complete deadness all the time.

Let me tell you why I did not quit, in the season I came closest, because I think the reason matters and it is not the reason you might expect. I did not stay because I found an argument that settled my doubts, or because God broke his silence and gave me the sign I had been demanding, or because I mustered up some heroic faith. None of that happened. I stayed for a much smaller and stranger reason. I stayed because I could not quite bring myself to say the final no. Every time I came to the edge of quitting, of closing my mouth for good, of declaring the whole thing dead, I found that I could not take the last step, that some small stubborn thing in me refused, that I would rather keep praying into a silence I could not explain than declare the silence empty and walk away. And I have come to believe that the small stubborn thing that would not let me quit was itself a work of grace, that the very inability to make the final no was God holding on to me from his side while I could not hold on from mine, that when Paul says nothing can separate us from the love of God, he means that even our own drift toward quitting is met by a God who does not drift, who holds the line open from his end when we have nearly let go of ours.

Because that is the thing I most want you to hear if you are near the end. The relationship does not depend, finally, on your grip. It depends on his. All through this book I have talked about staying in the conversation, keeping the line open, showing up in the dark, and I have meant every word,

and your part is real and matters. But underneath your part is his part, and his part is the one that actually holds. When Jesus told Peter that Satan had asked to sift him like wheat, he did not say, so pull yourself together and hold on tight. He said, I have prayed for you, that your faith may not fail. The holding was Jesus's holding. Peter did fail, spectacularly, denied him three times, and yet came back, because the thing that held Peter was not Peter's grip on Jesus, which failed, but Jesus's grip on Peter, which did not. And if you are near the end, near quitting, near closing your mouth for good, I want you to know that your grip is not the thing holding you, and its weakening is not the end of the story, because there is another grip, from the other side, that does not weaken, and that grip has held people who let go entirely and brought them back, and it can hold you.

So do not quit today. That is all I am asking. Not that you recover your faith, not that you feel God, not that you resolve your doubts, not that you become the kind of person for whom prayer works. Just that you do not close your mouth for good today. Say the one true prayer, the prayer of the person who is nearly done, God, I am nearly done, and I am still here, barely, and if you are there, hold on to me because I cannot hold on to you. That prayer, prayed by a person on the edge of quitting, is worth more than all the confident prayers of all the people for whom prayer has always been easy, because it is the prayer of someone who has stayed in the conversation at the very point where every reason to stay has failed, who has kept the line open by a thread when the thread was all that was left, and a thread is enough, because it is not finally the thread that holds. It is the one who holds the thread, and he does not let go, even when we have nearly let go of everything, even in the dark, even in the silence, even when

we are nearly done. Especially then.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Prayers We Are Afraid to Pray

We kept the dangerous prayers behind a locked door, and told ourselves it was reverence. It was fear. And the God we would not risk asking was the God we would not let ourselves be changed by.

THERE ARE PRAYERS WE do not pray because we are afraid of them, and I do not mean the angry prayers or the doubting prayers, which I have already tried to give you permission for. I mean a different and subtler category, the prayers we avoid because we are afraid God might answer them, or afraid of what they would cost us to mean, or afraid of the person we would become if we prayed them honestly. These are the prayers we edit out before they reach our lips, the requests

we will not make, the surrenders we will not offer, the questions we will not ask, and I want to walk into this locked room with you because I think some of the most important prayers of your life are behind this door, unprayed, and the not praying of them is quietly costing you the very depth you say you long for.

Consider the prayer of total surrender, the prayer that says, God, do whatever you want with me, take whatever you need to take, make me whatever you need to make me, even if it hurts, even if it costs me the things I am clutching. Most of us will not pray this prayer, and we tell ourselves it is because we are being careful, or realistic, or because such a prayer is presumptuous. But if we are honest, we will not pray it because we are afraid God will take us at our word, that he will actually do whatever he wants with us, and what he wants might not be what we want, and we would rather keep control of our own lives than hand them over to a God whose plans we cannot see. I have avoided this prayer for exactly this reason. I have wanted God enough to follow him but not enough to let him have me entirely, and the reservation, the small withheld portion, the part of my life I would not put on the table, has been the very thing keeping me shallow, because you cannot go deep with God while holding back the part of you that you most need him to touch.

There is a prayer even more frightening than surrender, and it is the prayer to be shown yourself, the prayer of Psalm 139, search me, O God, and know my heart, try me and know my anxious thoughts, and see if there is any grievous way in me. We do not pray this, most of us, because we do not want to be searched, we do not want to know what a searching God would find, we have arranged our whole inner lives around

not looking too closely at certain rooms, and we are not about to invite God to turn the lights on in them. But the unsearched heart does not get better. It gets worse in the dark. The rooms we will not let God into are the rooms where the rot spreads, and the prayer to be searched, terrifying as it is, is the beginning of the only healing there is, because you cannot be healed of what you will not let yourself see, and you will not let yourself see it until you invite the searching God to show it to you, gently, in the light of a love that has already forgiven whatever it finds.

I have prayed the prayer to be searched, and I want to tell you what it is like, because it is not what the fear imagines. The fear imagines that God, invited into your hidden rooms, will be appalled, will recoil, will confirm your worst suspicion that you are unlovable at the core. That is not what happens. What happens is that God, invited in, shows you the thing you were hiding, and it is bad, it is often worse than you thought, and at the very same moment he shows you that he has known it all along, that it did not surprise him, that he loved you with full knowledge of it before you ever prayed the prayer, and that the love was never conditional on the room being clean. The searching prayer does not lead to condemnation. It leads to the discovery that you are known, all the way down, into the rooms you were most ashamed of, and loved there, and that being known and loved in the same place is the thing your soul has been starving for your whole life while you kept the door locked to protect a love you already had.

There is another prayer we are afraid to pray, and it is the smallest and the hardest, and it is the prayer that admits a specific need to a God we are not sure will meet it. We are afraid to ask God plainly for the thing we most want, because

if we ask and do not receive, the disappointment will be sharper than if we never asked at all. So we protect ourselves by not asking, by keeping our deepest desires vague, by praying generally so that no specific no can wound us. Your will be done, we say, and we mean it as surrender, but sometimes it is not surrender at all, it is self-protection, it is a way of not risking the specific ask, not risking the vulnerability of telling God exactly what we want and letting him say no to it. And I understand this, I have done it, but I want to say that it costs us intimacy, because you cannot be close to someone you will not tell your real desires to, and a prayer life of only vague and self-protective requests is a prayer life that keeps God at arm's length precisely to avoid the risk of being disappointed by him.

The remedy is not to stop saying your will be done. Jesus said it, and I have spent a whole chapter on it, and it is the summit of prayer. The remedy is to say it only after you have made the specific ask, the way Jesus did in Gethsemane, where the your will be done came only after the plain and desperate let this cup pass from me. Jesus did not protect himself from disappointment by refusing to ask. He asked, plainly, for exactly what he wanted, exposed his real desire, risked the no, and then, having asked, entrusted the outcome to the Father. That is the shape. Ask for the specific thing, the thing you most want, the thing you are afraid to name because you cannot bear for God to refuse it. Name it. Risk it. And then, having risked it, place it in his hands. The self-protective vagueness that never asks is not more spiritual than the naked specific request. It is less. It is fear dressed as surrender, and the God who wants your whole heart wants the specific desires in it too, wants you to bring them, wants the intimacy of being told what you actually long for, even

when the answer must be no.

So I want to send you toward the locked door, gently, and suggest that you try, one at a time, to pray the prayers you have been afraid to pray. The prayer of surrender, that lets God have the part of you that you have been clutching. The prayer to be searched, that turns the lights on in the rooms you have kept dark. The prayer of the specific, naked, risky request, that tells God what you actually want and lets him answer. These prayers are frightening because they are real, because they cost something, because they open you to change and to disappointment and to being known. But the safe prayers, the vague and guarded and self-protective prayers, the prayers that risk nothing, they also gain nothing, they keep God at the arm's length we designed them to keep him at, and they leave us exactly as shallow as we were. The prayers we are afraid to pray are afraid-making precisely because they are the ones that would change us, and being changed is the whole point, and so the door we are most afraid to open is the door we most need to walk through, into the presence of a God who has been waiting, on the other side of our fear, to be let all the way in.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Prayer and the Long Defeat

*We wanted our prayers to win, and
mostly, in this life, they do not win,
and we had to learn to pray anyway,
the way a man keeps faith with a cause
he will not live to see triumph.*

I WANT TO TALK now about prayer over the long haul, prayer sustained across years and decades, prayer that does not get the victory it was praying for and keeps going anyway, because this is the prayer of a whole life and the books rarely describe it. In the short term, prayer can feel like a series of requests and responses, a running account of asks and answers. But over a long life of praying, something else comes into view, a longer shape, and the shape is often not the shape

of victory. It is the shape of what one writer called the long defeat, the faithful persistence in a good cause that does not, in this life, prevail, the keeping of faith with something you will not live to see vindicated, the praying of prayers whose answers, if they come at all, will come after you are gone.

Consider the person who prays for decades for a wayward child who never returns, or for a marriage that never heals, or for a country that only grows darker, or for a church that only grows colder, or for their own deliverance from a besetting struggle that stays with them to the grave. These prayers do not win, not in this life, not in the terms they were prayed. And the temptation, over the long defeat, is to conclude that the praying was pointless, that all those years of asking accomplished nothing, that you would have been as well off never praying at all. I want to face this temptation honestly, because I have felt it, and I will not pretend the long defeat is secretly a victory, because that is the kind of lie this book has refused from the beginning. Some prayers are not answered in this life. Some good causes do not prevail before we die. The long defeat is real, and prayer does not exempt us from it.

And yet. I have watched people pray through the long defeat, pray for decades into what looked like total failure, and I have seen what it did to them, and it was not nothing, and it was not defeat, though it was also not the victory they prayed for. What I saw was this. The prayer that did not change the situation changed the person praying. The mother who prayed thirty years for a son who never came home did not get her son back, but she became, over those thirty years of praying, a woman of a depth and a mercy and a strange unbreakable peace that she would never have had otherwise, a woman whose prayers had carved out in her a capacity for

love and for suffering and for hope-against-hope that made her, at the end of her life, one of the most Christlike people I have ever known. The prayer failed to accomplish what she asked. It succeeded in forming her into someone who could bear its failure without being destroyed by it, and that formation was itself a kind of answer, though not the kind she had asked for, and not one she would have chosen over her son, and I will not pretend she would have.

This is the deepest thing I know about prayer over the long haul, and I have been circling it for the whole book, so let me say it plainly here. The primary work of prayer is not to change your circumstances. It is to change you. And this is not a consolation prize we offer when the circumstances refuse to change, a way of spiritualizing our failures. It is the actual design. God is more committed to your formation than to your comfort, more committed to making you into a certain kind of person than to giving you a certain kind of life, and prayer is the central instrument of that formation, the place where, over years, the slow work of being made into the image of Christ actually happens. The person who prays for decades, even into apparent defeat, is being formed by the praying, shaped by the sustained turning toward God, made into someone who could not have been made any other way, and this formation is happening whether or not the prayer gets its result, is in fact often happening most deeply precisely when the prayer does not get its result, because the unanswered prayer, faithfully sustained, is the hardest and most refining school there is.

I think of Jesus in the garden again, because his prayer was the great long defeat and the great victory at once, and holding both together is the key to everything. He prayed to be spared and was not spared. His prayer, in the terms he

prayed it, failed, the cup did not pass, he went to the cross. By every measure of the vending machine, his was the great unanswered prayer, prayed with more faith and more anguish than any prayer before or since, and refused. And yet through that unanswered prayer, through that long defeat that ran all the way to a criminal's death on a Roman cross, came the salvation of the world, a victory so total that we still date our calendars by it, a victory that was hidden completely inside what looked, on Friday afternoon, like the most absolute defeat imaginable. I am not promising you that your long defeat will turn into a resurrection you can see. Most of ours will not, not in this life. But I am telling you that the pattern of the faith, its deepest pattern, is that God works his victories through what looks like defeat, that the cross always precedes the empty tomb, that the seed must fall into the ground and die before it bears fruit, and that your faithful prayer through the long defeat is not outside this pattern but inside it, participating in it, joined to the prayer of Christ himself in his garden, which failed, and saved the world.

So how do we pray through the long defeat without being destroyed by it? We pray the way you keep faith with a cause you love but will not live to see win. We pray without demanding to see the result, having decided that the faithfulness itself is the thing, that we will keep turning toward God whether or not he turns our circumstances, that we will be found, at the end, having stayed in the conversation, having kept the line open, having prayed our decades of prayers into whatever silence or delay or defeat they were prayed into, and having been formed by the praying into people who could do that, who could love God and keep asking and keep hoping without the reward of seeing, which is the very definition of faith, the assurance of

things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen. The long defeat is not the failure of prayer. It is the arena in which the deepest kind of prayer is learned, the prayer that has given up needing to win and prays anyway, the prayer of a person who has come to love God more than the answer, which is the only prayer, in the end, that death cannot defeat, because it has already surrendered everything death could take, and kept the one thing death cannot touch, which is the love of God, and the being loved by him, all the way through the dark, all the way to the end, and then past it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Prayer Closet and the Empty Room

*Jesus told us to go into our room and
shut the door, and we obeyed, and the
room was empty, and it took us years
to learn that the emptiness was the
point, that he had sent us somewhere
no audience could follow.*

JESUS SAID THAT WHEN we pray, we should go into our room and shut the door and pray to our Father who is in secret, and I want to sit with this instruction because it cuts against something deep in us, deeper than we admit. He gave it as a correction to the people who prayed on the street corners to be seen, who made a performance of their piety, and we hear the correction and we nod, because we know we

are not those people, we do not pray on street corners. But the correction goes deeper than the street corner, and it reaches into a subtler performance that even our private prayers are shot through with, the performance we put on for ourselves, for our own sense of ourselves as praying people, for the imaginary audience we carry with us even into the empty room.

Because here is what I discovered when I began to take seriously the shut door and the secret. Even alone in a locked room, I was performing. I was praying with an eye on myself, monitoring the quality of my prayer, judging whether it was going well, aware of myself as a person praying, narrating my own spiritual life to an internal audience. And Jesus's instruction, go into the room and shut the door, is not finally about excluding other people, who are not there anyway. It is about excluding the audience in your own head, the self-observation, the performance you put on for yourself, so that in the shut room, with the door closed, you can finally stop performing even for yourself and simply be with the Father in secret, unwatched, unjudged, un-narrated, alone with the only one whose attention matters, and free at last of your own exhausting attention to yourself.

This is why the empty room is a gift and not a deprivation. We come to the shut room hoping to feel God's presence, and often we feel nothing, and we take the emptiness as a failure, a sign that God did not show up. But the emptiness of the room is doing something the felt presence could not do. It is stripping away the audience. It is removing every reward that would let us pray for the wrong reasons. In a room where we felt God powerfully every time, we would come to pray for the feeling, to seek the experience, and our prayer would become,

again, a performance, this time for the reward of the felt presence. The empty room refuses us that reward. It gives us nothing to perform for, no feeling to chase, no experience to collect, only the bare fact of the Father in secret, unseen, unfelt, present in a way that gives our self-regard nothing to feed on. The empty room is where prayer is purified, because it is the only place where we finally cannot get anything out of praying except God himself, unfelt, in secret, which is the only thing worth getting.

I want to describe the discipline of the shut room concretely, because it is one of the few practices in this book I will actually urge on you as a regular thing to do. Find a place where you can be alone and unobserved, and go there at a set time, and shut the door, literally if you can. And then, in the shut room, do not try to have an experience. Do not try to feel God. Do not monitor how the prayer is going. Simply turn toward the Father who is there in secret and be with him, bringing whatever you have brought, the honesty and the anger and the numbness and the requests, and let the shut door and the empty room strip away the audience until it is just you and God, unwatched. And when you notice yourself performing, narrating, judging your own prayer, gently let that go too, let the internal audience out of the room along with everyone else, until there is no one left in the room but you and the Father in secret. This is harder than it sounds, because the internal audience does not want to leave, but the practice of dismissing it, over and over, is itself a deep prayer, the prayer of a soul learning to stop performing and simply be with God.

The reward Jesus promises for the shut room is strange and worth attending to. He says the Father who sees in secret will reward you, and we are tempted to hear this as a promise

that private prayer produces public results, that God will pay you back openly for the prayers you prayed in secret, and some translations and preachers have pushed it in that direction, back toward the vending machine. But I think the reward is quieter and greater than that. The reward of praying to the Father in secret is the Father in secret, is the secret intimacy itself, the being with God in a place no one else can see, the relationship that exists purely between you and him with no audience and no performance and no external validation, which is the most precious thing a human being can have and the one thing that cannot be taken away, because it does not depend on anything external, it happens in the secret room, behind the shut door, where only God can follow, and where, precisely because no one else can follow, the relationship is finally and purely your own.

There is a loneliness in the shut room that I do not want to minimize, because it is real and it is part of the gift. To pray to the Father in secret is to go somewhere no one can come with you, not your spouse, not your closest friend, not your pastor, no one. The deepest chamber of your life with God is a room built for two, you and him, and everyone else must wait outside. And this is lonely, and it is meant to be, because there is a solitude at the center of every soul that only God can enter, a place too deep for any other human being to reach, and the shut room is where you meet God in that place, alone, unaccompanied, in a solitude that would be unbearable if you were truly alone, but that is not truly alone, because the Father is there in secret, in the very solitude that excludes everyone else. The shut room teaches you that your deepest loneliness is not empty, that at the bottom of the solitude no one else can share, there is God, and that the aloneness you most feared is in fact the place of the most

intimate company there is.

So do not despise the empty room, and do not mistake its emptiness for the absence of God. The empty room is where the audience is stripped away, where the performance ends, where you finally pray for no reward but God himself, where the secret intimacy that no one else can see or share is built, slowly, between you and the Father, in the solitude at the center of your soul that he alone can enter. Go into your room. Shut the door. Let everyone out, including the audience in your own head. And be with the Father in secret, unwatched, unfelt, unrewarded by anything but him, and discover, over years of the shut door, that the empty room was never empty, that it was the fullest place in your whole life, that the secret was worth more than all the public prayers you ever prayed, and that the Father who sees in secret had been there, in the emptiness, the whole time, waiting for you to stop performing long enough to notice that you were not alone.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Praying the Scriptures

*We had been reading the Bible as a
book about God, and one day we
started praying it back to God, and the
book we thought we were studying
turned out to be studying us.*

THERE IS AN OLD practice, older than the divisions of the church, of praying the Scriptures, of taking the words of the Bible and turning them, slowly, into prayer, and I want to commend it to you because it solves several problems this book has raised at once. It solves the problem of not knowing what to say, because the Scriptures give you the words. It solves the problem of praying only about your own small concerns, because the Scriptures enlarge the range of what you pray about. And it solves the deepest problem, the problem of prayer as a monologue we deliver into silence,

because praying the Scriptures makes prayer a genuine conversation, a listening as much as a speaking, in which God speaks first, through his word, and we respond, and the responding is prayer.

The practice has been called by various names in various centuries, and the most famous is the ancient monastic practice of a slow prayerful reading, in which you do not read the Bible the way you read a newspaper, for information, to get through it, to extract the point. You read it slowly, a small passage, a few verses, and you read it again, and again, and you let it sink in, and you attend to the word or phrase that seems to catch, that seems addressed to you, and you stay with it, and you turn it over, and then you begin to speak back to God about it, to pray it, to respond to what God has said in it, and then, having spoken, you fall silent and simply rest in the presence of the God whose word you have been praying. Reading, meditating, praying, resting. Not a technique that produces results, but a way of being with God through his word, a conversation in which God's word is the opening and your prayer is the reply.

Let me make this concrete with the Psalms, since I have pressed the Psalms on you throughout this book. Take a single Psalm, and do not read it for information about ancient Israelite worship. Pray it. Make its words your words. When the Psalmist says the Lord is my shepherd, do not merely note that this is a metaphor for God's care. Pray it. Say to God, you are my shepherd, and mean it, and let the saying of it search you, do you believe it, do you feel shepherded, where in your life does the shepherding seem absent, and pray that too. When the Psalmist cries out of the depths, and you are in the depths, pray it as your own cry, let the ancient words

carry your present anguish up to God. When the Psalmist praises, and you do not feel like praising, pray the praise anyway, let the words lead your feelings rather than waiting for your feelings to produce the words, and discover that praise prayed without feeling sometimes calls the feeling up out of hiding. The Psalms were given to be prayed, not merely studied, and praying them turns the whole Psalter into your own prayer book, a well of words for every condition of the soul.

But the practice reaches beyond the Psalms, into the whole of Scripture, and this is where it becomes a genuine conversation. When you pray a passage of the Gospels, you place yourself in the scene, you let Jesus's words to the people in the story become his words to you, you respond to him as the people in the story responded, or as you wish you could respond, and the reading becomes an encounter. When Jesus asks the blind man, what do you want me to do for you, you let him ask it of you, and you answer, and the answering is prayer, and it is a prayer prompted by God's own word, so that you are not making up your prayer out of nothing but responding to an initiative that came from God's side first. This is the deep answer to the loneliness of the monologue. In praying the Scriptures, God speaks first. The word comes from him. You are not initiating a conversation into silence, hoping someone is there. You are responding to a word already spoken, and the response is prayer, and the whole thing is a genuine back-and-forth in which God's speaking and your praying alternate, and the silence you feared is filled, from God's side, by the word he has already given.

I have to be honest that praying the Scriptures is not a magic solution to the silence of God, because the God who speaks through his word is still, often, silent in the felt sense,

and you can pray the Scriptures for years and still not hear a voice from the ceiling. But something is different, and the difference matters. When you pray the Scriptures, you are anchored to something outside your own head, outside your own moods and doubts and feelings, anchored to the objective word of God that stands there whether you feel anything or not. On the days you feel nothing, the word is still there, still true, still God's speech to you, and you can pray it, and the praying of it does not depend on your feeling. This is why praying the Scriptures is such a lifeline in the dark seasons. It gives you a place to stand that your own shifting inner weather cannot wash away, a word from God that is true on the numb days and the angry days and the doubting days alike, a conversation that God has already begun and that you can rejoin at any time simply by opening the book and praying what you read.

There is a discipline required here, and it runs against our habits, and I want to name it. We are trained to read fast, to skim, to extract, to move on, to consume text the way we consume everything else, quickly and in quantity. Praying the Scriptures requires the opposite. It requires slowness. It requires reading a very little, and staying with it a long time, and resisting the urge to move on, to get through more, to accomplish a reading goal. A single verse, prayed slowly, turned over, responded to, rested in, will feed you more than three chapters read fast for information. This slowness is hard for us, harder than for any generation before us, because we have trained ourselves out of the capacity for it. But the slowness is where the prayer happens, in the lingering, in the staying, in the refusal to hurry past the word that has caught you, and learning this slowness is itself part of the healing, a recovery of an attention we have nearly lost, an attention that

is close to the heart of love.

So take up the practice, gently, without ambition. Do not set out to pray through the whole Bible in a year, which turns it back into a reading project. Take a small passage, a Psalm, a paragraph of a Gospel, a few verses of a letter. Read it slowly. Read it again. Attend to what catches. Speak back to God about it, honestly, as a response to what he has said. And then fall silent and rest in his presence, letting the word settle. This is prayer that God begins and you complete, conversation rather than monologue, a listening that becomes a speaking, and it will feed you on the days you have nothing of your own to bring, because on those days the word of God is still there, still speaking, still waiting to be prayed back to the God who gave it, and in praying it back you will find, some days, that the book you thought you were studying has been studying you all along, reading your heart even as you read its pages, addressing you by name from the silence, so that the conversation you feared was one-sided turns out to have had a voice on the other end the whole time, and the voice was in the word, and the word was in your hands, and you had only to slow down enough to pray it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

When Prayer Feels Like Talking to Yourself

*The suspicion never fully left me, that I
was a man talking to his own
reflection, and I stopped fighting it,
and learned instead to pray inside it,
and found that the suspicion was not
the enemy of prayer. The pretending
was.*

I WANT TO RETURN, near the end of this book, to the suspicion I opened with, because I do not want you to think I have talked my way out of it, or that the chapters between here and the introduction have dissolved it. They have not. The suspicion that prayer is a man talking to himself, that

there is no one on the other end, that the whole exercise is an elaborate conversation with my own reflection, has been with me for my entire life of faith, and it is with me still, and I have decided to tell you the truth about that rather than pretend to a certainty I do not have. This chapter is for the person for whom the suspicion is not occasional but constant, for whom prayer always feels, at some level, like talking to yourself, and who wonders whether such a person can pray at all.

Let me first grant the full force of the suspicion, because I will not answer it by making it smaller than it is. When you pray and hear nothing, when no voice answers, when no felt presence confirms that you are heard, the plainest explanation available to your mind is that there is no one there, that the silence is silence because it is empty, that you are, in fact, talking to yourself, running a conversation in your own head and imagining a listener. This explanation is not stupid. It is not a sign of weak faith or bad reasoning. It is the most economical account of the raw data, which is that you speak and nothing answers, and I held this explanation myself for years, and I will not insult it or you by pretending it is easily dismissed. If prayer feels like talking to yourself, that is not a malfunction of your faith. It is an honest perception of the actual experience, and the honest perception deserves an honest response.

Here is the honest response, and it is not a proof, because there is no proof, and anyone who offers you a proof that prayer is not talking to yourself is selling something. The honest response is that the feeling of talking to yourself and the reality of talking to God are not distinguishable from the inside, in the moment, by feeling alone. This cuts both ways, and I want you to see both. It means that when prayer feels

like talking to yourself, you cannot conclude from the feeling that you are, in fact, talking to yourself, because the feeling would be the same either way, because God does not, as a rule, provide a felt confirmation every time you pray, and so the absence of the felt confirmation proves nothing. But it also means, and this is the harder half, that I cannot prove to you from your feeling that you are talking to God, because I do not have access to a felt confirmation either, and I will not manufacture one. We are both in the position of not being able to tell, by feeling alone, in the moment, whether the prayer is heard. And the question is what to do inside that not-knowing.

What I have learned to do inside the not-knowing is this, and it is the whole of what I have to offer, so hear it carefully. I pray as though God is there, having decided, on grounds other than the feeling of the moment, that he probably is, and I refuse to let the feeling of talking to myself stop me, because I have recognized that the feeling proves nothing. I made the decision that God is there not on the basis of any single prayer experience but on the basis of a whole life, the change in me I could not account for otherwise, the testimony of people I trust who are not fools, the strange durability of the church across millennia, the person of Jesus who does not read like a fiction, the resurrection that I have come to think more likely true than not, and a hundred other things that add up, for me, to a probability strong enough to act on, though not to a certainty. And having made that decision on those grounds, I do not re-litigate it every time I pray, I do not let each session of felt self-talk reopen the whole question, I simply pray, inside the decision, and let the feeling of talking to myself be what it is, a feeling, not a verdict.

But I want to go further, because there is something I have

found inside the suspicion that is better than merely enduring it, and it surprised me. The very fact that I keep praying into the feeling of talking to myself has become, over the years, a strange kind of evidence, not a proof but a weight on the scale. Because if I were merely talking to myself, why would I keep doing it, decade after decade, when it brings me no reward my own mind could manufacture, when it costs me my pride and my time and my comfortable certainty? A man talking to himself, and knowing it, stops, because there is no point. But I have not stopped, and the not-stopping is not, I think, mere stubbornness, or not only that. It feels, from inside, like being held, like there is something on the other end that keeps drawing me back even when the feeling gives me nothing, and while I cannot prove that this something is God and not just my own psychology, I have noticed that my own psychology, left to itself, would have quit this exhausting and unrewarding practice long ago, and it did not quit, and the not-quitting has the texture, to me, of being kept.

I think of the disciples on the road, after the resurrection, walking with a stranger who turned out to be Jesus, and how they did not recognize him the whole way, thought they were talking to an ordinary traveler, and only afterward, when he was gone, said to each other, did not our hearts burn within us while he talked with us on the road. They were with Jesus and did not know it. They thought they were talking to a stranger. The presence was real and the recognition was absent, and the recognition came only later, looking back. And I have come to think that this is often the shape of prayer in the dark, that we are with God and do not know it, that we think we are talking to a stranger or to ourselves, and that the recognition, if it comes at all, comes later, looking back, when we see that our hearts were burning the whole time and we

did not notice, that we were accompanied on a road we thought we walked alone. The feeling of talking to yourself may be the feeling of not-yet-recognizing a presence that is nonetheless there, and the recognition may be a gift held in reserve, given later, or given only at the end, when we see at last the one we were talking to the whole time.

So if prayer feels like talking to yourself, pray inside that feeling, and do not let it stop you, and do not pretend it away, because the pretending is worse than the suspicion. The suspicion, honestly held, is compatible with real prayer, is in fact the condition of most honest prayer in a disenchanted age, and God is not offended by it, God who preserved the doubts of the Psalmists and the questions of Job and the my-God-my-God-why of his own Son. What God cannot use is the pretending, the performance of a certainty you do not have, the polite prayer that hides the suspicion instead of praying inside it. Bring the suspicion. Say to God, I am not sure you are there, I feel like I am talking to myself, and I am talking to you anyway. That prayer, the prayer of the honest doubter who prays despite the doubt, is not a defective prayer. It may be the truest prayer there is, because it has given up every consolation except the bare decision to keep the conversation open, and a conversation kept open across a lifetime of not-being-sure is a faith more refined than certainty, because it has loved God without the reward of feeling him, which is the love the whole book has been about, the love that can be given in the dark.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Company of the Praying

*We thought our prayer was a private
thing between us and God, and then we
learned that we had never prayed
alone, that behind us stood a great
crowd of the praying, living and dead,
and that our thin voice had been
joined to a chorus we could not hear.*

I HAVE WRITTEN MOST of this book as though prayer were a solitary struggle, a man alone in a room talking into the silence, and there is truth in that, and the shut room is real and necessary. But I have to correct the impression now, before the end, because it is only half the truth, and the other

half is a comfort I do not want you to miss. You have never prayed alone. Not once. From the first faltering prayer you ever prayed, you have been joined to a company of the praying so vast that no one has ever counted it, the whole church across all the centuries and all the continents, the living who are praying now in every language on earth, and the dead who prayed before us and whose prayers, the Scripture suggests, are somehow still present before God, rising like incense, gathered up, not lost. Your thin solitary voice, praying into what felt like an empty room, was never solitary at all. It was one voice in a chorus too large to hear.

Consider first the living. At this moment, as you read this, millions of people are praying. Somewhere it is dawn and monks are singing the morning office. Somewhere it is midnight and a mother is praying over a sick child. Somewhere a persecuted church is praying in secret under threat of death, and their prayers are more fervent than any I have prayed in my comfortable freedom. Somewhere a dying man is praying his last prayer, and somewhere a new believer is praying his first, and all of it is going up, at once, all the time, a ceaseless chorus of prayer ascending from the whole earth to God, and your prayer, whenever you pray it, joins that chorus, is added to it, is not a lone voice in an empty room but a voice added to a sound that never stops, the sound of the whole church praying, day and night, around the world, without ceasing, so that even when you feel most alone in your prayer, you are in fact praying in the largest company that exists.

And then consider the dead, and here I have to speak carefully, because the traditions differ on the details and I do not want to teach as certain what is disputed, but the core is

held by the whole church and I can stand on it. The Scripture speaks of a great cloud of witnesses surrounding us, the faithful who have gone before, and it speaks of the prayers of the saints rising before God, and it teaches that in Christ the dead are not lost to us but alive to God, so that the communion of saints is not merely the fellowship of living Christians but a fellowship that reaches across death, binding us to all who have prayed before us. When you pray the Psalms, you pray the very words that David prayed, that Jesus prayed, that the whole church has prayed for three thousand years, and in praying them you are joined to every soul who ever prayed them, a fellowship across time, a communion that death has not broken. Your prayer is added not only to the living chorus but to the long chorus of the faithful dead, so that the sound you make, however thin, is part of a music that began before you were born and will continue after you die, the church at prayer across all the ages, one great unbroken song.

This matters immensely for the person praying in the dark, and I want to make the comfort concrete. When your own faith fails, when you cannot pray, when your prayer hits the ceiling and you are sure no one is listening, the chorus does not stop. The church is still praying. The living are still praying, and their faith holds up yours when yours cannot hold itself. The creed you can barely believe is being believed, at this moment, by millions, and their believing carries you when your own gives out. This is what it means to be part of a body. When your hand is injured, the rest of the body does not stop functioning, it compensates, it carries the injured part. When your faith is injured, the body of Christ carries you, prays for you, believes for you, holds you up in the chorus even when your own voice has gone silent, and this is

not a metaphor, it is the actual structure of the church, a body in which the strong bear the weak and no member is left to hold themselves up alone.

I have leaned on this more times than I can count. In my darkest seasons, when I could not pray, when I stood in the pulpit leading prayers I could not myself pray, I have leaned on the fact that the church was praying, that my congregation, ordinary people in the pews, were praying with a faith stronger than mine that morning, and that their prayers held up the service that my own faith could not have held up. I have leaned on the great tradition, on the fact that Augustine prayed, and Teresa prayed, and the martyrs prayed, and that their prayers are not lost, that I stand in a river of prayer that has been flowing for two thousand years and will flow long after I am gone, and that my little contribution to it, however faltering, is caught up and carried by the whole. When you cannot pray, let the church pray for you. Go to the gathered people even when you feel nothing, and let their singing and their praying wash over you, and let yourself be carried, because that is what the body is for, and there is no shame in being carried, and the day will come when you are strong and someone else is weak and you will carry them, and the chorus will go on.

There is a practical shape to this that I want to urge on you, which is simply that you must not try to pray only alone. The solitary prayer of the shut room is essential, and I have defended it, but it is not the whole of prayer, and a prayer life that is only solitary is a prayer life dangerously exposed, because when your solitary faith fails, you have nothing to fall back on. Go to the gathered church. Pray with others. Say the prayers together, out loud, in one voice, so that on the days your own faith is weak, the voices around you carry the words

your heart cannot mean, and the shared prayer holds you up. Join a smaller company too, a few people who will pray with you and for you and let you pray for them, so that when the dark comes, and it will come, you are not alone in it, but held by a company who will keep praying when you cannot, who will name your name before God when you have no words, who will be, for you, the friends who carry the paralyzed man to Jesus when he cannot get there himself.

So do not believe the loneliness, even when you feel it. The loneliness of prayer in the dark is real as a feeling and false as a fact. You are not alone in the room. Around you, unseen, stands the whole company of the praying, the living in every land and the dead in every age, a chorus so vast it fills heaven, and your thin voice, praying into what seems an empty room, is added to that chorus and carried by it and never, not for one moment, actually alone. And ahead of all of them, leading the chorus, is the one whose prayer holds the whole thing together, the Son at the right hand of the Father, who ever lives, the Scripture says, to make intercession for us, praying for you now, by name, so that behind your prayer and around your prayer and ahead of your prayer stands a company of the praying that begins with the whole church and ends with Christ himself, and in that company, though you cannot hear it, you have never once prayed alone.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Thanksgiving When You Are Not Grateful

*We were told to give thanks in all
circumstances, and we choked on it,
because we were not grateful, until we
learned that thanksgiving is not the
report of a feeling but the practice of a
memory, and that a man can give
thanks with a broken heart if he is
willing to remember.*

PAUL TOLD THE THESSALONIANS to give thanks in all circumstances, and it is one of the hardest commands in the New Testament, harder even than pray without ceasing, because it seems to demand a feeling we cannot summon on

command. Give thanks in all circumstances? In grief, in loss, in the pit, in the dark? When my prayers are hitting the ceiling and I am not sure anyone is there, I am to give thanks? The command seems either cruel or naive, a demand for a gratitude that the circumstances make impossible, and I have resented it, and I have skipped over it, and I have suspected the people who quote it cheerfully of not having suffered much. But I have come, slowly, to understand it differently, and the different understanding has made it not only bearable but a lifeline, and I want to give you that understanding, because thanksgiving in the dark is one of the deepest prayers there is.

The mistake is to think that thanksgiving is a report of a feeling, that to give thanks means to feel grateful, and therefore that you cannot give thanks unless you feel grateful, and therefore that the command to give thanks in all circumstances is a command to feel grateful in all circumstances, which is impossible and would be dishonest even if it were possible. But thanksgiving is not, primarily, the report of a feeling. It is an act, a practice, a discipline of memory and speech, and it can be done without the feeling, the same way I have argued throughout this book that prayer can be done without the feeling. To give thanks is not to feel a warm glow of gratitude. It is to remember, and to name before God, the things that are genuinely good and genuinely from him, whether or not you feel warm about them in the moment, and this remembering and naming can be done with a broken heart, through tears, in the pit, because it does not depend on the feeling. It depends only on the willingness to remember and to speak.

Let me show you how this works in the actual dark,

because abstractions are useless here. Suppose you are in grief, real grief, and the command to give thanks lands on you like an insult. You cannot feel grateful. Your child is dead, or your marriage is over, or your body is failing, and gratitude is the last thing you feel. But you can still remember. You can remember that the child you lost was given to you at all, that the years you had were real, that love was real even though it ended in loss, and you can name these before God, not as a denial of the grief but alongside it, through the grief, and in the naming, thanksgiving happens, not the feeling but the act, the deliberate remembering of what was good and the speaking of it back to God. The Psalms do this constantly. In the middle of lament, the Psalmist remembers, I remember the days of old, I remember your wonders of old, and the remembering does not cancel the lament but coexists with it, thanksgiving and grief held together, the memory of good and the pain of loss prayed in the same breath.

This is why thanksgiving is a discipline and not merely a feeling, and why it must be practiced deliberately, especially in the dark. When we are in the pit, our memory contracts. The present pain fills the whole field of vision, and we forget, genuinely forget, everything else, forget every good thing that ever happened, forget every mercy we ever received, forget every prayer that was ever answered, because the present darkness is so loud it drowns out the memory of light. And thanksgiving is the deliberate act of expanding the contracted memory, of forcing the field of vision to widen, of remembering, against the pull of the present pain, that the pain is not the whole story, that there was good, that there were mercies, that God has acted before even if he seems absent now. This remembering is an act of will, a discipline, a refusal to let the present darkness edit out the whole past of

light, and it is one of the most important things a person in the dark can do, because a memory that has been edited down to only the present pain is a memory that has lost the very evidence it most needs.

I keep, and I commend this practice to you plainly, a deliberate account of God's mercies, a remembering of the specific things I have to be thankful for, and I return to it especially when I feel least grateful, because that is when I most need it. In the dark seasons, I make myself remember, out loud, to God, the specific goods, the answered prayers of years past, the people who have loved me, the beauty I have seen, the mercies large and small, and I name them, one by one, not because I feel grateful but because they are true, because they happened, because they were from God, and the naming of them, even through numbness, even through grief, even through the suspicion that God is not there now, reconnects me to the whole story of my life with God, which is longer and larger than the present dark. And I have found, again and again, that the deliberate thanksgiving, done without the feeling, slowly calls the feeling up, that gratitude practiced as a discipline sometimes becomes gratitude felt as an emotion, not always, and I will not promise it, but often enough to make the practice worth its difficulty.

There is a deep theological reason why thanksgiving belongs in the dark, and it is this. Thanksgiving is the antidote to the lie that the dark is telling you. The dark tells you that God has never been good to you, that he is absent, that he does not care, that the silence is empty, that you have received nothing and can expect nothing. Thanksgiving contradicts this lie with evidence, with the specific remembered evidence of God's actual goodness in your actual past, and the remembering does not depend on the

present feeling, it depends only on the facts of what has been. When you give thanks in the dark, you are not lying about the dark, you are not pretending the pain is not real, you are simply refusing to let the dark rewrite the whole of your history with God, refusing to let the present silence erase the memory of every time God was not silent, holding the good you have received up against the good you are not receiving now, and in that holding, keeping alive the truth that the God who was good before is the same God now, even in the dark, even in the silence, even when you cannot feel it.

So give thanks in all circumstances, and do not wait for the feeling, and do not think the command requires you to be dishonest about your pain. Give thanks the way you pray, as an act and not a feeling, a discipline of memory, a deliberate naming of the good God has done, held alongside the honest lament for the good he is not doing now. Thanksgiving and lament are not enemies. They are the two hands of an honest prayer, one holding the grief and the other holding the memory of mercy, and a prayer that has both hands is a whole prayer, a prayer that neither denies the dark nor forgets the light, a prayer that can be prayed in the pit by a broken-hearted person who is willing to remember. Remember the good. Name it before God. Give thanks with your broken heart, through your tears, in the dark. It is not a lie. It is the truest thing you can do in the dark, because it is the deliberate refusal to let the dark have the last word about a God who has been good to you before and will be good to you again, even if you must wait for the light to see it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

The Prayers of Children and the Prayers of the Dying

*At the beginning and at the end, when
we had the least to bring, we prayed the
best, and it shamed all the
accomplished prayers of the strong
years in between.*

I WANT TO LOOK, in this chapter, at prayer at the two edges of life, the prayer of small children and the prayer of the dying, because I have learned more about prayer from watching people at these two edges than from all the books and all the theology, and because what I learned there overturns almost everything our culture believes about what

makes a prayer good. At the beginning and at the end, when a person has the least to bring, the least eloquence, the least accomplishment, the least of everything we associate with spiritual maturity, prayer is often at its purest and truest, and this should tell us something profound about what prayer actually is.

Watch a small child pray, really watch, and set aside your adult condescension, because there is something there worth seeing. A small child prays with total directness and no self-consciousness whatever. He does not monitor the quality of his prayer. He does not wonder whether he is doing it right. He does not perform for an internal audience or worry that God might not be listening. He simply talks to God the way he talks to his father in the next room, plainly, trustingly, with total confidence that he is heard, and he asks for what he wants without embarrassment, and he tells God what happened at school, and he prays for the dog and the goldfish and the neighbor, and then he is done, and he does not agonize over whether it worked. Now, some of this is mere ignorance, the child has not yet learned the doubts, and I am not romanticizing childhood or pretending that a child's untested faith is the same as a faith that has been through the fire. But there is something in the child's prayer that the accomplished adult has lost and needs to recover, and Jesus said so directly, that unless we become like children we cannot enter the kingdom, and I think he meant, among other things, this, the directness, the trust, the freedom from performance, the plain talking to a Father a child is sure is there.

I learned this watching my sons pray when they were small. There was a plainness to their prayers that convicted

me, because my own prayers had become so complicated, so full of theology and qualification and self-consciousness, so performed, and here were these boys just talking to God, plainly, and it was obviously realer than anything I was managing. One of them, small, prayed one night for God to make him less afraid of the dark, just that, plainly, and then rolled over and went to sleep, entirely trusting that he had been heard and that the matter was in good hands, and I sat there in the dark of his room and realized that his prayer was better than mine, that his childish trust was nearer to what Jesus commended than all my adult sophistication, and that somewhere in the years of becoming a competent praying adult I had lost the one thing that made prayer prayer, which was the plain trust of a child talking to a Father he was sure of. I have been trying to get it back ever since.

And then there is the prayer of the dying, at the other edge, and I have sat with many people as they died, it is part of a pastor's work, and I have watched what happens to prayer at the end, and it is one of the most instructive things I know. At the end, everything falls away. All the complexity, all the theology, all the performance, all the accumulated sophistication of a lifetime of religious practice, it falls away, and what is left is very simple and very small and very true. The dying do not pray elaborate prayers. They pray, if they pray, the simplest things, the things they learned as children, the Lord's Prayer, a Psalm, the name of Jesus, help, mercy, into your hands. At the end, prayer returns to the plainness it had at the beginning, comes full circle, and the accomplished prayers of the strong middle years turn out to have been, in some sense, a long detour, and the true prayer was the simple one all along, the one the child prayed and the dying pray, the plain turning of a small soul toward a great God with nothing

left but trust.

I sat with a man once as he was dying, a man who had been, in his strong years, a formidable and articulate believer, a leader, a teacher, and at the end all of that was gone, the articulateness gone, the leadership gone, the strength gone, and he lay there able to say almost nothing, and what he said, over and over, in a whisper, was simply the name of Jesus. Just the name. That was his whole prayer at the end, the name, whispered, again and again, and I want to tell you that it was the most powerful prayer I have ever heard, more powerful than any eloquent public prayer, more powerful than my own best sermons, because it was prayer stripped down to its absolute essence, a dying man with nothing left, no strength, no eloquence, no accomplishment, holding onto the one name that could carry him across, and it carried him, and he died with the name on his lips, and I stood there undone, having witnessed the truest prayer of my life prayed by a man who could no longer say anything else.

What both edges teach, the child and the dying, is that prayer is not finally about our capacity, and that our capacity, the very thing we spend the strong middle years developing, is in some ways an obstacle we have to get past to reach the simple truth that was there at the beginning and returns at the end. The child prays well because he has not yet developed the capacity that would let him perform and doubt and complicate. The dying pray well because they have lost the capacity, it has fallen away, and they are left with only the essence. And the rest of us, in the middle, with our capacity at its peak, pray worst of all, because our very strength gets in the way, our eloquence becomes performance, our theology becomes doubt, our accomplishment becomes self-consciousness, and we lose the plain direct trusting turning-

toward-God that requires no capacity at all, that a child can do and a dying man can do and that we, in our strength, have made too complicated to manage.

So I want to send you toward the prayer of the child and the prayer of the dying, both, as your models, over the prayer of the accomplished adult, which is to say over your own prayer as you have probably been praying it. Pray plainly, like a child, talking to a Father you have decided to trust, without monitoring the quality, without performing, without the sophistication that has become an obstacle. And pray as the dying pray, stripped down, with the simplest words, the name of Jesus, help, mercy, into your hands, holding onto the one thing that can carry you when everything else has fallen away. You do not need the capacity you have spent your life building. You need to get past it, back to the plainness at the beginning, forward to the plainness at the end, to the simple trusting turning-toward-God that requires nothing but the willingness to turn, that a child can do and a dying man can do and that you can do, right now, in the dark, if you are willing to lay down your sophistication and become, again, small.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The Discipline of the Ordinary Hour

*We waited for prayer to be inspired,
and it almost never was, and we
nearly gave it up, until we understood
that the great pray-ers were not the
inspired ones but the faithful ones,
who showed up at the ordinary hour
whether or not anything happened, for
years.*

I HAVE SAID A great deal in this book about prayer in the extremities, prayer in the dark, prayer in grief and anger and numbness and doubt, and I have said it because the extremities are where the books fail us and where honesty is

most needed. But I would be giving you a distorted picture if I left you thinking that prayer is mostly a matter of these dramatic conditions, because it is not. Prayer, for most people most of the time, is a much more ordinary thing, a daily discipline, an unglamorous habit, a showing up at a regular hour to do a regular thing that is usually neither ecstatic nor agonizing but simply plain, and I want to spend a chapter on the ordinary, because the ordinary is where prayer actually lives, and a person who can only pray in the extremities cannot really pray at all.

Here is the truth that the inspirational books hide. The great pray-ers of history, the ones whose prayer lives we admire, were not, mostly, people who were constantly inspired, constantly feeling God, constantly having dramatic experiences. They were people who showed up. They had a discipline, a rule, a regular time and a regular practice, and they kept it, faithfully, for years and decades, most of the time feeling nothing in particular, most of the time doing it as a plain habit rather than a thrilling encounter, and it was the faithfulness, the showing up, the discipline maintained across the long dry stretches, that made them who they were, not the occasional inspired moment. We have this exactly backwards. We think the inspired moments are the real prayer and the dry discipline is what we do while waiting for them, when in fact the dry discipline is the real prayer and the inspired moments, when they come, are a grace laid on top of a faithfulness that was already there.

This means that prayer is far more like a marriage than like falling in love. Falling in love is the inspired moment, the ecstasy, the feeling, and it is real and it is wonderful and it cannot be sustained and it is not the point. Marriage is the

discipline, the showing up, the daily unglamorous faithfulness, the choosing of the person again and again across years, most of them ordinary, some of them dry, some of them hard, and it is in the marriage, not the falling in love, that the deep union is actually built. Prayer is the same. The falling in love, the early inspired experiences of God that many believers have, is real and wonderful and cannot be sustained and is not the point. The marriage, the daily discipline of showing up to pray whether or not anything happens, the faithfulness across the dry years, is where the deep union with God is actually built, and the person who abandons prayer when the inspired feelings fade is like the person who abandons a marriage when the falling-in-love fades, having mistaken the beginning for the whole, having quit right at the point where the real thing was about to start.

So I want to urge on you, plainly, the discipline of the ordinary hour, the regular time set aside for prayer, kept faithfully whether or not you feel like it, whether or not anything happens, for years. Choose a time, and it does not much matter which, though many have found the beginning of the day best because it sets the day in God's presence before the world can crowd him out. Choose a place, and keep it, so that the place itself becomes associated with prayer and helps to gather you. And then show up, at the time, in the place, every day, and pray, using the Scriptures and the fixed prayers and your own words and silence, and do not judge whether it went well, and do not quit when it is dry, and do not wait for inspiration, and do not require an experience. Just show up, and pray, and keep showing up, and let the faithfulness itself, the plain unglamorous discipline of the ordinary hour maintained across years, be the thing, because it is the thing, and the great pray-ers knew it, and it is the

secret they all share underneath their various methods, that they showed up, faithfully, at the ordinary hour, for a lifetime.

I have to be honest about how dull this can be, because the inspirational books never are, and their dishonesty about the dullness sets people up to quit. Much of the discipline of the ordinary hour is dull. You show up, and you pray, and you feel nothing, and your mind wanders, and you bring it back, and it wanders again, and the time passes, and you get up, and nothing in particular has happened, and you do it again the next day, and the next, and most days are like this, plain and dull and undramatic, and if you are expecting fireworks you will conclude you are failing and quit. You are not failing. The dullness is normal. The dullness is, in fact, part of what the discipline is doing, because a faith that can only survive on fireworks is a shallow faith, and the discipline of the dull ordinary hour is building in you a faith that does not need fireworks, that can love God and keep company with him in the plain dullness of an ordinary Tuesday, which is where most of life is lived, and a faith that can do that is a faith that can survive anything, because it is not dependent on the conditions being dramatic.

There is a paradox here that took me years to understand. The discipline of the ordinary hour, kept faithfully across the dull years, is what makes possible the deep experiences of God when they do come, and it is also what makes those experiences unnecessary. That is the paradox. The person who has kept the discipline is more open to the occasional grace of a felt encounter with God, because they have kept the channel open, kept the practice alive, been present at the ordinary hour where the extraordinary grace, when it comes, arrives. And at the same time, the person who has kept the discipline no longer needs the felt encounter, because their

prayer has been weaned off dependence on feeling by the long faithfulness through the dry years, so that when the encounter comes it is received as a gift and not a requirement, and when it does not come the prayer continues unbothered, sustained by discipline rather than experience. The discipline both opens you to the gift and frees you from needing it, and this double freedom is one of the deepest fruits of a faithful ordinary prayer life.

So do not despise the ordinary hour, and do not wait for inspiration to pray, and do not quit when prayer is dull, and do not measure your prayer by its drama. Show up. Keep the discipline. Pray at the ordinary hour, faithfully, for years, through the dull stretches and the dry stretches and the dark stretches, not because it feels good, it often will not, but because faithfulness is the thing, because the great pray-ers were the faithful ones and not the inspired ones, because prayer is a marriage and not a falling in love, because the deep union with God is built in the dull ordinary faithfulness and not in the occasional fireworks. And one day, looking back over years of the ordinary hour, you will find that the plain dull faithful showing up has made you into someone you could not otherwise have become, has built in you a life with God that no drama could have built, has carried you through the dark seasons on the strength of a habit that held when everything else gave way, and you will understand that the ordinary hour, which felt like so little, was in fact the whole thing, quietly building, day by dull day, the deepest relationship of your life.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Waiting

*We hated the waiting more than the no,
and God gave us so much of it, and
slowly we understood that the waiting
was not the delay of the answer. It was
the answer, teaching us what we could
learn no other way.*

THERE IS AN EXPERIENCE in prayer that is neither the yes nor the no, and it is harder than either, and it is the most common experience of all, and the books say almost nothing about it. It is the waiting. You pray, and you do not receive the thing, and you do not receive a clear no either, you receive nothing, you receive silence and delay, you are left waiting, not knowing whether the answer will be yes or no, not knowing how long, not knowing anything except that you must keep waiting, and the waiting stretches on, and on, and

it becomes, for many people, the defining experience of their prayer life, this endless suspended waiting for an answer that does not come and does not clearly refuse to come, just delays, and delays, and delays.

I hate the waiting. I want to say that plainly, because the books tend to spiritualize it too quickly, to tell you that the waiting is good for you before they have acknowledged that it is agony. It is agony. The waiting is often harder than a clear no would be, because a clear no, however painful, at least lets you grieve and move on, at least resolves the question, at least tells you where you stand. The waiting resolves nothing. It keeps you suspended, hoping and fearing at once, unable to grieve because the answer might yet be yes, unable to hope freely because the answer might yet be no, held in an in-between that has its own particular torment, the torment of the not-knowing, the torment of the suspended hope, and I will not pretend it is easy or that it does not sometimes feel like a cruelty. The Psalms are full of the agony of waiting, how long, O Lord, how long, and the how-long is one of the most frequent cries in the whole Psalter, the cry of people suspended in the waiting, and God preserved that cry, which tells me he knows the waiting is hard and does not blame us for hating it.

And yet. I have to say the yet, because it is true, though I will not say it until I have granted the agony. The waiting, agonizing as it is, is not empty, and it is not merely the delay of the answer, a pointless gap between the asking and the receiving. The waiting is doing something, forming something, teaching something that could not be taught any other way, and I have come to believe that the waiting is often itself the answer, or at least a large part of it, that God gives us

the waiting not because he is slow or indifferent but because there are things we can only learn in the waiting, things about ourselves and about him and about the nature of hope and trust, that a quick answer would have prevented us from ever learning. The person whose prayers are answered quickly never learns to wait, and never learns what only the waiting can teach, and misses a depth that is only available on the far side of a long suspension.

What does the waiting teach? It teaches, first, that our hope is often attached to the wrong thing, and the waiting slowly detaches it. When we begin to wait, our hope is fixed entirely on the outcome, on getting the thing, and the waiting is unbearable precisely because everything is riding on the outcome. But as the waiting stretches on, something happens, if we let it, if we do not quit, and it is this. Our hope, unable to rest in an outcome that will not arrive, begins, slowly, to shift its ground, to attach itself less to the thing we are waiting for and more to the God we are waiting on, until at some point, and it is a mysterious point, we find that we are no longer waiting for the thing so much as waiting on God, that our hope has been transferred from the outcome to the person, and this transfer, this slow detaching of hope from outcome and reattaching of it to God, is one of the deepest works God does in a soul, and it can only be done in the waiting, because it is the waiting itself, the frustration of the outcome, that forces the hope to look elsewhere for its rest.

The waiting teaches, second, that we are not in control, and this is a lesson we resist with everything in us and cannot learn any other way. When we can make things happen, we believe, at some level, that we are the masters of our lives, that our effort and our planning and our will can secure what we want. The waiting destroys this illusion, gently or not so

gently, because in the waiting we discover the absolute limit of our control, discover that there are things we want with our whole hearts that we cannot make happen no matter what we do, that we are, finally, not in charge, that our lives are held in a hand that is not our own. And this discovery, devastating as it is to our pride, is the beginning of the only peace there is, because the illusion of control was never peace, it was a constant anxious labor to secure what we were terrified of losing, and the surrender of control, forced on us by the waiting, is the laying down of a burden we were never meant to carry, the burden of being the god of our own lives, and in laying it down we find, underneath it, the rest of being a creature in the hands of a Creator who is in control when we are not.

I want to point you to the pattern of Scripture, because the waiting is everywhere in it, and the heroes of the faith are, almost without exception, people who waited. Abraham waited twenty-five years for the son he was promised. Joseph waited years in a prison for a deliverance that seemed never to come. Moses waited forty years in the wilderness before his calling came, and then forty more years in the wilderness leading a people who did not want to be led. David waited years, anointed as king but hunted as a fugitive, before the throne he was promised became his. And the whole people of God waited centuries, praying, for the Messiah who was promised and delayed and delayed, until in the fullness of time, the Scripture says, in the fullness of time, not before, not on the people's schedule but on God's, he came. The pattern is unmistakable. God's people wait. The waiting is not a malfunction of the life of faith. It is central to it, woven through the whole story, and the God of the Bible is a God who makes his people wait, and who does his deepest work in the

waiting, and who is never, the Scripture insists, actually slow, but works in a fullness of time that our impatience cannot see.

So if you are waiting, and most of you are waiting for something, I will not tell you the waiting is easy or that you should not hate it, because it is not easy and you may hate it and God can bear your hating it. But I will tell you that the waiting is not empty, that it is not merely the delay of the answer but is itself doing a work in you that nothing else could do, detaching your hope from the outcome and reattaching it to God, dismantling your illusion of control and teaching you the rest of the creature in the Creator's hands, forming you in the pattern of every hero of the faith who ever waited on God. Wait, then, not passively, not in despair, but as the Psalmist waited, crying out your how-long honestly while continuing to wait, hoping in God more than in the outcome, trusting that the fullness of time is real even when you cannot see it, and knowing that the God who kept Abraham and Joseph and Moses and David and the whole waiting church across the centuries is keeping you too, in the waiting, working in the waiting, present in the waiting, and that the waiting, agonizing as it is, is not the absence of his answer but is, itself, part of the answer, the part that forms you, the part you could not have learned any other way.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

The God Who Speaks First

*We had spent our whole prayer lives
trying to get God's attention, and the
Scriptures kept telling us we had it
backwards, that he had our attention
first, that our prayer was always a
reply to a word we had not noticed him
speaking.*

THERE IS AN ASSUMPTION buried so deep in how most of us pray that we never examine it, and it distorts everything, and I want to bring it up into the light. The assumption is that prayer begins with us. That we are the initiators, the ones who start the conversation, the ones who reach up toward a

God who is passively waiting to be addressed. On this assumption, the whole burden of prayer falls on us, our effort, our reaching, our attempt to get God's attention and to sustain a connection that depends entirely on our activity, and no wonder we are exhausted, no wonder prayer feels like heavy lifting, no wonder the silence feels like failure, because if the whole thing depends on our initiative, then when our initiative flags, the whole thing collapses. But the assumption is wrong, and the Scriptures correct it on nearly every page, and the correction is one of the most freeing things I know.

The correction is that God speaks first. Always. In the beginning, before any creature could pray, God spoke, and the world came into being at his word, so that the very first thing in the story is not a creature reaching up to God but God reaching out to create. And ever after, the pattern holds. God calls Abraham before Abraham seeks God. God comes to Moses in the bush before Moses thinks to look for God. God speaks to the boy Samuel in the night before Samuel knows how to answer, and Samuel's famous prayer, speak Lord, for your servant is listening, is not the initiation of a conversation but the reply to a God who had already spoken his name in the dark. The whole Bible is the record of a God who takes the initiative, who speaks first, who seeks before he is sought, who is, as one theologian put it, always prior, always ahead of us, so that whenever we turn to God in prayer, we are never initiating a conversation but always joining one already in progress, always replying to a word already spoken, always responding to a God who addressed us before we thought to address him.

This changes the whole nature of prayer, and I want you to feel the weight of the change. If God speaks first, then prayer

is not primarily our reaching up but our answering back. Peterson titled his book on the Psalms *Answering God*, and the title is the whole argument, that prayer is answering speech, that we pray because God has spoken, that the initiative is always his and ours is always response. And this means that the burden is not, finally, on us. We are not responsible for starting the conversation or for getting God's attention or for sustaining a connection by our own effort. God has started it. God has our attention already, has had it since before we were born, has been speaking to us through his word and his world and his Son and his Spirit, and all we have to do, all prayer finally is, is to answer, to reply, to respond to the God who has already spoken. The exhausting labor of trying to reach a distant and passive God is simply unnecessary, because God is not distant and not passive, but has been speaking first the whole time, and our prayer is the answer.

Let me make this concrete for the person in the dark, because it is exactly the person in the dark who most needs it. When you pray into the silence and hear nothing and conclude that God is absent or not listening, you are assuming that the burden of the conversation is on you, that you are speaking into a void and it is up to you to somehow reach across it. But if God speaks first, then your very impulse to pray, the fact that you are turning toward God at all, is itself already a response to God, is itself evidence that God has been speaking to you, drawing you, calling you, because you would not be seeking him if he had not first sought you. The theologians have a phrase for this, that we love because he first loved us, and it applies to prayer, that we pray because he first spoke to us, that the desire to pray is itself the fruit of a prior word from God, so that even your

struggle to pray in the dark, even your reaching toward a God you cannot feel, is not you initiating a lonely effort but you responding to a God who has already, in ways you cannot see, addressed you, called you, drawn you toward himself.

Where does God speak first, concretely, so that we can learn to listen and answer rather than only to reach and strain? He speaks first in his word, in the Scriptures, which is why I urged you toward praying the Scriptures, because there God's speech is objective and available, there you can hear the word to which your prayer is the answer, there the conversation is clearly God-initiated and you are clearly responding. He speaks first in his creation, in the world he made, which the Psalmist says declares his glory day and night, pouring out speech, so that the sunrise and the mountains and the ordinary beauty of an ordinary day are God's speech, addressed to us, and our noticing and our gratitude are the answer. He speaks first, above all, in his Son, in Jesus, who is called the Word, God's ultimate speech, God's final and complete self-communication, so that the whole of the gospel is God speaking first, God taking the initiative to come to us in Christ before we ever sought him, and our faith and our prayer are the answer to that prior word. In all these places, God speaks first, and prayer is learning to hear the prior word and to answer it.

There is a discipline that follows from this, and it is the discipline of listening, which most of our prayer lacks entirely. If prayer is answering God, then prayer must include listening, must include silence, must include the receptive attending to God's prior word that alone makes a real answer possible. But our prayer is so often all talking, all our own speech, all our reaching and asking and telling, with no space for listening, no silence in which the prior word of God could

be heard, and so our prayer becomes the monologue we complain it is, not because God is silent but because we never stop talking long enough to hear the word he is speaking. To pray as answering God, we have to build listening into our prayer, have to be quiet, have to attend to the Scriptures and to the creation and to the Spirit, have to make space for the prior word, so that our prayer becomes a genuine conversation, God speaking first through his word and we answering, rather than a monologue we deliver into a silence we ourselves created by never listening.

So lay down the exhausting assumption that prayer begins with you, and take up the freeing truth that God speaks first. You are not initiating a lonely effort to reach a distant God. You are answering a God who has been speaking to you your whole life, in his word, in his world, in his Son, in the very impulse that turns you toward him even now in the dark. Your prayer is a reply, not an initiation, and the burden of the conversation is not on you, because God started it and God sustains it and God will finish it. Learn to listen for the prior word. Build silence into your prayer. Attend to the Scriptures where God's speech is clear. And answer, out of the listening, the God who has already spoken, and discover that the conversation you thought you were struggling to begin has been going on since before you were born, that God had your attention first, that you are not talking into a void but answering a voice, and that the voice, though you may not hear it in the way you wish, has been speaking to you the whole time, and your prayer, your poor dark struggling prayer, is the answer it has been waiting for.

CHAPTER THIRTY

Prayer and the Body of Christ Broken for You

We kept trying to reach God by the strength of our prayer, and at the table we were handed the truth, that we do not reach God by our prayer at all, that he reached us, at the cost of his own body, before we ever prayed a word.

I WANT TO BRING prayer to the table now, to the Lord's Supper, the communion, the eucharist, because I think the table is the deepest place to understand what prayer is and is not, and because the table corrects the last and most stubborn error in our praying, the error of thinking that we reach God by the quality of our prayer. There is a way in which all the anxieties this book has addressed, the fear that

our prayer is not good enough, that we are not praying right, that our prayer is hitting the ceiling because of some deficiency in us, all of these anxieties rest on a single underlying assumption, which is that access to God depends on us, on our prayer, on our getting the prayer right. And the table demolishes this assumption completely, because at the table we do not reach up to God at all. God reaches down to us, and puts himself into our hands, and into our mouths, and the whole direction of the movement is reversed.

Consider what happens at the table, and consider how utterly it contradicts the vending-machine and the performance models of prayer. At the table, we do nothing to reach God. We do not pray our way up to him. We do not achieve access by the fervor or the correctness of our prayer. We simply come, empty-handed, with nothing to offer, and we receive. We hold out our hands and are given bread, the body of Christ, broken for us. We are given the cup, the blood of Christ, poured out for us. The movement is entirely from God to us, entirely gift, entirely grace, and our part is only to come and to receive what is given, to hold out empty hands and be filled. And this is the truth about our whole relationship with God, of which the table is the sign and seal, that we do not reach God by our effort but are reached by his grace, that access to God was never something we achieved by good prayer but something God accomplished, at the cost of his own body, before we ever prayed a word.

This is why the table is such medicine for the anxious prayer, and I want to press the medicine on you. If you have been tormented by the fear that your prayer is not good enough, that you are not reaching God because you are praying wrong, that the ceiling your prayers hit is a verdict on your

inadequacy, then the table has a word for you, and the word is that your access to God never depended on your prayer in the first place. It depended on the broken body of Christ, on the poured-out blood, on a work God did entirely without your help, entirely before your prayer, entirely as gift. The curtain of the temple, the Scripture says, was torn in two at the moment of Christ's death, torn from top to bottom, torn by God from the top, not by us from the bottom, so that the access to God that we could never achieve by our own reaching was opened by God's own hand at the cost of his own Son, and it stands open now, permanently, not because of anything we do but because of what he has done. You do not have to pray your way through the curtain. The curtain is torn. You have only to come.

Let me say what this does not mean, because grace is always in danger of being misheard as license or laziness. It does not mean that prayer does not matter, or that we need not bother to pray because access is already given. It means the opposite. It means that prayer is freed from the terrible burden of having to earn or achieve access, and is therefore able to become what it was always meant to be, the free and grateful response of a child who already has access, who is already welcome, who does not have to knock and hope the door opens but walks through a door that stands permanently open because someone else opened it at great cost. The child of the house does not pray his way in. He is in. And his prayer is not the anxious effort of an outsider trying to gain entry but the free conversation of an insider who belongs, and this changes everything about the tone and the texture of prayer, removes the anxiety, removes the performance, removes the fear that the door might not open, and replaces it with the security of a child at home, talking to

a Father whose house is his own.

The table also teaches us something about prayer in the dark specifically, and it is this. At the table, we remember. We do the thing in remembrance of him, the Scripture says, and the remembering is central, because at the table we are pulled out of the tyranny of the present moment, out of the present darkness and the present silence and the present doubt, and anchored to an event in history that does not change, the death and resurrection of Christ, the objective fact of what God has done, which stands there true and solid whether we feel anything or not. In the dark, when God seems absent and our prayer seems empty, the table gives us something to hold onto that is not dependent on our feeling, the historical fact of the cross, the objective reality of the broken body and the poured-out blood, the accomplished work of God that our darkness cannot touch. We come to the table in the dark, feeling nothing, and we receive the bread and the cup, and we are anchored, again, to the fact of God's love, which is not a feeling but an event, not a mood but a body broken in history, and the anchoring holds when everything else is washing away.

There is a communal dimension here too, which I touched on in the chapter on the company of the praying but which the table makes physical and undeniable. We do not come to the table alone. We come together, the whole church, and we receive the one bread, and Paul says that because there is one bread, we who are many are one body, for we all partake of the one bread. The table makes visible the truth that we are one body, that our prayer is never solitary, that we are bound together in Christ, and so at the table, when your own faith is weak, you are surrounded by the body, receiving the same bread, held in the same communion, carried by the same

grace, and even if you come to the table in the dark, unable to feel or believe, you come as part of a body that is feeling and believing around you, and the body carries you, and the shared bread makes you one with a company of faith larger than your own faltering heart.

So bring your prayer to the table, especially your dark prayer, your doubting prayer, your prayer that hits the ceiling. Come to the table with empty hands and nothing to offer, and receive what is given, the body broken for you, the blood poured out for you, and let the table teach you the truth that undoes all your anxiety, that you do not reach God by your prayer but are reached by his grace, that the curtain is already torn, that the access you feared you could not achieve was achieved for you at the cost of his own body before you ever prayed a word. And in the dark, when God seems silent and your prayer seems empty, come to the table and remember, and be anchored to the fact of his love that is not a feeling but an event, and be carried by the body that surrounds you, and receive, again, the grace that was never dependent on your prayer being good enough, that was always, from the beginning, pure gift, held out to you in nail-pierced hands, waiting only for you to come, with empty hands, in the dark, and take it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

When Others Pray and It Works for Them

*We watched other people's prayers get
answered while ours went into the
dark, and the comparison nearly
destroyed us, until we learned to stop
measuring our prayer against theirs
and started measuring it against
nothing at all.*

THERE IS A PARTICULAR grief that afflicts the person praying in the dark, and it is a grief I have not yet named directly, and it needs naming because it is one of the sharpest, and it is the grief of comparison. You are praying into silence, your prayers hitting the ceiling, receiving

nothing, and meanwhile, all around you, other people's prayers seem to be answered. They pray for a job and get it. They pray for healing and are healed. They stand up in church and testify to answered prayer, glowing, and you sit there in the pew having prayed with equal or greater faith for years and received nothing, and the comparison is a knife. Why them and not me? Why their prayers and not mine? What do they have that I lack? And this comparison, this measuring of your dark prayer against their apparently answered prayer, is one of the most corrosive things in the whole life of faith, and I want to walk into it honestly, because pretending it away helps no one.

Let me first grant that the comparison is natural and nearly unavoidable, so that you do not add to your grief the guilt of feeling it. We are comparing creatures. We measure ourselves against others in everything, and prayer is no exception, and when we see others receiving what we are denied, the comparison arises whether we will it or not, and it brings with it a whole train of painful conclusions, that God favors them over us, that they have a righteousness or a faith we lack, that we are doing something wrong, that we are, somehow, second-class in the kingdom, the ones whose prayers do not count. These conclusions are agonizing, and they are also, I want to say clearly, false, every one of them, but they are natural, and feeling them is not a sin, it is a wound, and the wound deserves care rather than condemnation.

Now let me take apart the false conclusions, one at a time, because they are doing you real damage and they are not true. The first is that God favors the answered over the unanswered, that the person whose prayer is answered is

more loved than you. This is false, and the cross is the proof, because the most loved human being who ever lived, the beloved Son in whom the Father was well pleased, prayed the great unanswered prayer in the garden, and his prayer was refused, and he went to the cross, and if unanswered prayer were a sign of being less loved, then Jesus was the least loved, which is absurd. Unanswered prayer is not a sign of being less loved. It fell on the most loved one of all. Whatever the difference is between the answered and the unanswered, it is not a difference in how much God loves them, and you must drive that false conclusion out of your mind with the fact of the unanswered prayer of the beloved Son.

The second false conclusion is that the person whose prayer is answered has a righteousness or a faith you lack, that they have earned or achieved something you have not. This too is false, and it is false because it drags us straight back to the vending machine, to the idea that answered prayer is a reward for spiritual performance, that if you just had enough faith or enough righteousness the machine would dispense your request. But we have seen that this is not how prayer works, that the saints prayed and were refused, that Paul prayed three times and got a no, that the correlation between spiritual quality and answered prayer simply does not hold, that some of the most faithful people who ever lived received the least of what they asked for, and some of the least faithful received much. The distribution of answered and unanswered prayer does not track spiritual quality, and so the person whose prayer was answered while yours went dark did not earn it, did not achieve it, is not spiritually superior to you, but received, as you may yet receive, or may not, a gift that was never a reward in the first place, given according to a wisdom neither of you can see.

But here is the deepest thing I have to say about the comparison, and it is the thing that finally freed me from it, and it is this. The comparison assumes that prayer is a competition, a race, a distribution of limited goods in which what one person gets another person loses, and that the answered prayers of others are, somehow, at your expense. And this assumption is not only false, it is a kind of blindness to what prayer actually is. Prayer is not a competition and there is no limited pool of divine attention being divided up, with some getting more and some getting less. God's attention is not scarce. His love is not rationed. When your neighbor's prayer is answered, nothing has been taken from you, no attention has been diverted from your prayer to theirs, because God is not a finite resource that must be shared out. He is infinite, and his attention to you is total and undivided even as his attention to every other creature is total and undivided, and so the answered prayer of another is not evidence that you are getting less, because there is no less, there is only the infinite attention of God given wholly to each, and your dark prayer is receiving that total undivided attention exactly as much as your neighbor's answered prayer, even though the outcomes differ, because the outcomes were never a measure of the attention.

This means that the only cure for the comparison is to stop measuring your prayer against anyone else's at all, to refuse the whole framework of comparison as a category error, and to receive your own prayer life, with its own outcomes, as a thing between you and God alone, incomparable, unmeasurable against any other, because it exists in the infinite undivided attention of God that is not being shared out or rationed or distributed competitively. Your prayer is not in a race with your neighbor's prayer. It is a private matter

between you and a God who gives himself wholly to you, whatever the outcome, and the outcome of your neighbor's prayer tells you exactly nothing about the state of your own prayer or the measure of God's love for you or the quality of your faith. Stop comparing. It is not merely that comparison is unhelpful. It is that comparison is based on a false picture of a scarce and rationed God, and the true God is infinite and undivided, and in the true God there is nothing to compare, because each soul receives the whole of his attention, and no soul receives it at another's expense.

I had to learn this the hard way, over years, watching others receive what I was denied, and being eaten alive by the comparison, until slowly, painfully, I came to see that the comparison was a lie, that I was measuring my prayer against a false standard, that God's love for me was not diminished by his answering someone else, that my dark prayer was held in the same infinite attention as any answered prayer anywhere, and that the outcomes, the yeses and the nos, were distributed according to a wisdom I could not see and did not need to see, and were never the measure of the love. And when I finally stopped comparing, something eased in me, a grief and an envy and a resentment I had carried for years lifted, and I could, at last, rejoice when others' prayers were answered, actually rejoice, instead of being knifed by it, because their answered prayer was no longer a verdict on my unanswered prayer, was no longer at my expense, was simply a good thing happening to someone I could love, in the house of a Father whose love for me was not one drop diminished by his kindness to them. Rejoice with those who rejoice, the Scripture says, even when their rejoicing is the thing you asked for and did not get, and you can only do this when you have stopped comparing, when you have seen that there is

nothing to compare, that God's love is not scarce, and that your dark prayer is as fully held as any answered prayer in the world.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

The Slow Miracle of Being Changed

We kept asking God to change our circumstances, and he kept, instead, changing us, and we called it a failure for years, until one day we looked in the mirror and saw a person we could not have become any other way, and understood that the change was the answer we had been too blind to recognize.

I HAVE SAID, SEVERAL times in this book, that the primary work of prayer is not to change our circumstances but to

change us, and I have said it in passing, but it deserves a chapter of its own, because it is the deepest thing I know about prayer and the hardest for us to accept, and I do not want it to slip by as a consolation we half-hear on the way to the outcomes we actually want. The claim is radical and I want to state it plainly. When you pray, over a long time, faithfully, the main thing that happens is not that God rearranges your circumstances to suit your prayers. The main thing that happens is that you are changed, slowly, into a different kind of person, and this change, not the rearrangement of circumstances, is the primary answer to prayer, the deepest thing God is doing, the point of the whole enterprise.

We resist this with everything in us, and I understand the resistance, because it sounds, at first, like a dodge, like a way of explaining away unanswered prayer, like the disappointing thing a person says when they cannot deliver the miracle you asked for. You asked for your circumstances to change, and I am telling you that instead you will be changed, and this can sound like being told that you asked for bread and will be given a lecture. But hear me out, because it is not a dodge, it is the actual structure of the life with God, and once you see it, it reorganizes everything. The reason the change in you is the primary answer is that the change in you is what you most deeply needed all along, deeper than the circumstances you were praying about, because the circumstances, whatever they were, were temporary, and the person you are becoming is eternal, and God, who loves you enough to give you what you most deeply need rather than what you superficially want, is at work, through your prayer, on the eternal thing, on the person, on the you that will outlast every circumstance you ever prayed about.

Let me describe the change, because it is real and specific and I have watched it happen in others and, to my astonishment, in myself. The person who prays faithfully over years, even through unanswered prayer, even in the dark, becomes, slowly, more patient, because the waiting has taught them patience. They become more humble, because the unanswered prayers have taught them that they are not in control and do not always know what is best. They become more compassionate, because their own suffering, brought to God in prayer, has softened them toward the suffering of others. They become less anxious, because the long practice of handing their fears to God has, over time, loosened the grip of fear. They become more able to love, because prayer has slowly turned their attention away from themselves and toward God and, through God, toward others. They become, in a word, more like Christ, and this Christlikeness, this slow transformation of character, is the deepest work of prayer, and it happens not through the answering of prayers but through the praying itself, through the long faithful turning toward God that reshapes a soul the way water reshapes stone, invisibly, gradually, and completely.

And here is the thing that took me longest to see and that I most want you to grasp. This change often happens most deeply precisely through the unanswered prayers, through the dark seasons, through the very experiences we count as prayer's failures. The answered prayer, the quick yes, does not change us much, because it confirms us in what we already wanted, leaves us essentially as we were, only with the thing added. But the unanswered prayer, the long no, the dark silence, this breaks us open, forces us past our own agendas, drives us to the end of our control and our understanding, and it is in this breaking, this being driven

past ourselves, that the deep change happens. The people I know who have been most transformed by prayer are not the ones whose prayers were most answered. They are the ones who prayed through the most unanswered prayer, who stayed in the conversation through the longest silence, who kept turning toward God when God seemed to give them nothing, and who were, in that long faithful turning through the dark, changed more profoundly than any answered prayer could have changed them.

I have to be careful here not to make suffering sound good, because it is not good, and I have insisted throughout this book on the honesty that will not spiritualize away real pain. The unanswered prayer is a real loss. The dark season is real suffering. The child who does not come home, the healing that does not come, the deliverance that never arrives, these are genuine griefs and I will not pretend the change they work in us makes them good, makes them worth it, makes them anything other than the evils they are. But I will say that God, who does not author the evil, is able to work through it, is able to bring out of the unanswered prayer and the dark season a change in us that is a genuine good, not a good that justifies the evil, but a good that God wrests from the evil, a treasure he brings up out of the pit, so that even the suffering we would never have chosen becomes, in God's hands, the occasion of a transformation we could not have received any other way. This is not the same as saying the suffering was good. It is saying that God is good enough, and powerful enough, to bring good even out of what is not good, and that the change in us is that good, wrested from the dark.

There is a way to cooperate with this change, and a way to resist it, and I want to name both, because the choice is yours and it matters. You resist the change by insisting, through the

whole dark season, that the only acceptable outcome is the change of circumstances you prayed for, by refusing to receive anything except the specific answer you demanded, by treating the whole experience as pure loss and closing yourself against the transformation God is offering in the midst of it. And you cooperate with the change by staying open, in the dark, to what God might be doing in you even as he declines to do what you asked in your circumstances, by praying not only change my circumstances but also change me, by allowing the unanswered prayer to do its slow work of patience and humility and compassion rather than only its fast work of disappointment. The same dark season can leave one person bitter and closed and another person deepened and softened, and the difference is not the circumstances, which are identical, but the openness, the willingness to be changed, the cooperation with the slow miracle that God is working in the dark.

So when you pray, and especially when you pray in the dark, into the silence, over the unanswered years, hold this before you as the deepest hope, deeper than the hope for the outcome you are asking for. Hold before you the hope that God is at work, in the dark, on the eternal thing, on the person you are becoming, changing you, slowly, into someone more like Christ, someone more patient and humble and compassionate and free, someone you could not have become any other way, someone who could only be forged in the fire of the very unanswered prayer you are grieving. This change is the slow miracle, the deep answer, the thing God is doing underneath all the outcomes you can see, and it is happening even now, even in the dark, even in the silence, even in the prayer that seems to accomplish nothing, and one day, looking back, or perhaps only on the far

side of death, you will see the person you have become, and you will understand that the prayer was answered all along, in a currency deeper than circumstances, in the coin of your own transformed soul, and that God, who loved you too much to only rearrange your circumstances, was making you, the whole time, into someone who could bear his own eternal glory.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

Praying as a Father, Praying to a Father

*The word he told me to begin with was
the word I had never had, and it took
me half my life to say it without
flinching, and when I finally could, I
understood that I had been learning to
pray and learning to be a father in the
same school the whole time.*

I HAVE CIRCLED THE word Father throughout this book, mentioning that I was raised without one, hinting that this made the word both the hardest and the tenderest in the language for me, and I have saved a full reckoning with it for near the end, because it is the most personal thing I have to

say about prayer and the most costly, and I did not want to spend it early. Jesus told us to begin our praying with the word Father, and for a man raised without a father, that instruction is not a gentle invitation into a warm image. It is a summons to the very wound at the center of his life, a demand to address God by the name of the person whose absence shaped everything, and I want to tell you honestly what it has been like to learn to pray that word, because I suspect I am not the only one for whom it is hard.

When I first came to faith and encountered the instruction to call God Father, something in me recoiled. Father was not a warm word to me. Father was an absence, a hole, a wound, the name of the person who was supposed to be there and was not, the first and deepest lesson I ever learned in calling out and getting no answer. And here was Jesus, telling me that the way to God was through exactly that word, that I was to approach the Almighty by the very name that meant, in my experience, abandonment. I could say the word, in the Lord's Prayer, going through the motions, but I could not mean it, not for years, because the word Father did not connect me to warmth and safety and presence, it connected me to the deepest absence of my life, and to call God by that name felt less like coming home and more like being handed a photograph of the thing I had never had.

But something worked on me over the years, slowly, and I want to describe it because it is, I think, one of the deepest things prayer did in me, and it is bound up with prayer itself. As I prayed, over years, to a God I addressed, at first mechanically, as Father, the word began to change its meaning, or rather, God began to fill the empty word with a content it had never had. The Father I had never known

began, through prayer, to be revealed as a Father who was there, who did answer, though not always in the way I wished, who did not abandon, who was present in the very silence I had learned to expect abandonment in. And this was not a sudden healing, not a moment of revelation that fixed the wound, but a slow filling-in, over years of praying the word, of the empty place where a father should have been, so that the word Father, which had meant only absence, began, gradually, to mean presence, began to be inhabited by the God I was praying to, until one day, and I cannot tell you exactly when, I found that I could say the word without flinching, could say Father and mean it, could address God by the name of my deepest wound and find, in the name, not the wound but the healing of it.

And here is where my two vocations, the two things this book keeps returning to, came together in a way I did not expect. Because at the same time I was learning to pray to a Father, I was learning to be one. I have five sons. I became a father having never been fathered, which is a terrifying thing, to be handed a role you have no model for, to be asked to be for your children what no one was for you. And I discovered that learning to pray to God as Father and learning to be a father to my sons were, somehow, the same education, that they fed each other, that as I learned what a father was by trying to be one for my boys, I understood better what it meant to call God Father, and as I learned what a Father God was by praying to him, I understood better how to be a father to my sons. The two schools were one school. The God I was learning to pray to was teaching me to be the father I had never had, and the effort to be that father was teaching me who the God I prayed to was, and in the middle of it all was prayer, the place where the two educations met.

Let me tell you what my own fatherhood taught me about prayer, because I think it will help you whether or not your own experience of fathers was like mine. When my sons were small and one of them asked me for something, I did not give it to him because he asked correctly, or because he had earned it, or because his request was eloquent. I gave it, or withheld it, based on my love for him and my knowledge of what was good for him, which was often more than he could see. And when I withheld something he desperately wanted, it was never because I loved him less, but almost always because I loved him too much to give him something that would harm him, and he could not understand this, and to him my no was incomprehensible and cruel, and I had to bear being, to my own beloved son, a father who seemed not to love him, when in fact the no was the very form my love was taking. And I realized, watching myself father my sons, that this was how God fathered me, that my unanswered prayers were often his no, given not because he loved me less but because he loved me too much to give me what would harm me, and that my inability to understand his no was exactly my sons' inability to understand mine, and that the whole thing was, from God's side, love, even the refusals, especially the refusals.

And I learned something else, something that undid me, about the presence that does not answer. Because there were times when my sons were suffering and there was nothing I could do, nothing I could fix, no answer I could give, and all I could do was be there, present, in the suffering, silent because there was nothing to say. And I have described this earlier in the book, the father sitting silent on the edge of the frightened child's bed, but I want to return to it here because it is the deepest thing my fatherhood taught me about the

silence of God. When I sat with my suffering son and said nothing, my silence was not absence, it was the deepest presence I had, the presence that had run out of answers and stayed anyway, and I understood, sitting there, that God's silence with me might be the same, might be not abandonment but the presence of a Father who has run out of answers that I could understand and stays anyway, present in the silence, loving in the silence, there in the silence, in exactly the way I was there for my son when I had nothing left to give him but my presence in the dark.

So if the word Father is hard for you, as it was for me, whether because your own father was absent or cruel or simply human and disappointing, I want to say that the hardness of the word is not a barrier to prayer but can become, through prayer, the very place of the deepest healing. Do not avoid the word because it wounds. Pray the word, even mechanically at first, even without being able to mean it, and let God, over years, fill the empty and wounded word with his own presence, let him become, in the very place where your father failed or was absent, the Father you never had, present in the silence, loving in the refusals, there in the dark. Jesus did not tell us to begin with the word Father in order to wound us. He told us to begin there because that is where the healing is, because the deepest wound is the place God most wants to enter, because the name of your deepest absence is the name by which the ever-present God wants to be known to you, and because in learning to call him Father, in the very place where you learned that fathers are absent, you learn the truest thing there is, that this Father is not absent, has never been absent, is there, in the dark, in the silence, waiting to be called by the name you were most afraid to say.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

What Prayer Is For

After all the pages, the question remained, and I had to answer it, not with a definition but with a confession. Prayer is for the thing it was doing to me the whole time I thought it was failing.

WE ARE NEAR THE end now, and I owe you an answer to a question that has been running underneath this whole book, sometimes surfacing, mostly submerged, and it is the simplest and hardest question of all. What is prayer for? If it is not a vending machine, if it does not reliably change our circumstances, if it often meets only silence, if the answers are often no or not yet or not this, if the whole thing can feel like talking to ourselves, then what is it for? Why do it? Why have I written a whole book urging you to keep doing a thing

that I have admitted, again and again, does not do the thing most people want it to do? I have to answer this, and I have to answer it honestly, without retreating to the vending machine I have spent the book dismantling, and the answer is not a definition but a confession.

Prayer is for God. That is the whole answer, and everything else is commentary. Prayer is not for the outcomes, though it may sometimes produce them. It is not for the feelings, though it may sometimes give them. It is not for the answers, though they may sometimes come. Prayer is for God himself, for the relationship with God, for the being-with-God that is the point of the whole human project, the thing we were made for, the end for which we exist. We were made for communion with God, made to know and love and be known and loved by our Maker, and prayer is the practice of that communion, the way the relationship is conducted, the ongoing conversation, silent and spoken, dark and light, in which the communion we were made for is actually lived. And so prayer is for God the way a marriage is for the beloved, not for what the beloved provides but for the beloved, not for the benefits of the relationship but for the relationship itself, for the person, for the love.

This is why all the anxieties this book has addressed finally dissolve when we see what prayer is for. We were anxious that our prayers were not working, but prayer was never primarily for working. We were anxious about the silence, but prayer was never primarily for hearing a voice. We were anxious about unanswered prayer, but prayer was never primarily for getting answers. All these anxieties came from mistaking the point of prayer, from thinking it was for the outcomes when it was for God, and when we see that it

was for God all along, the anxieties lose their grip, because the presence of God, which is the actual point, is not defeated by the silence or the unanswered prayer or the darkness. God is present in the silence. God is present in the unanswered prayer. God is present in the dark. And if prayer is for God, and God is present in all these conditions, then prayer is succeeding, is doing exactly what it is for, even in the silence, even in the dark, even when every outcome we hoped for fails to materialize, because it is keeping us in the presence of the God it was for all along.

Let me confess how I came to see this, because it was not through argument but through a long slow discovery in the dark. For years I prayed for outcomes, and measured my prayer by the outcomes, and was tormented when the outcomes did not come, because I thought the outcomes were the point. And then, through a long season of unanswered prayer, through the dark this whole book has been describing, I discovered, almost by accident, that even when the outcomes did not come, something was happening in the praying itself that I had not been paying attention to, something I had dismissed because it was not the outcome I wanted. I was being with God. In all those prayers that seemed to fail, I had been with God, in his presence, in relationship with him, and the being-with-God had been quietly happening the whole time, underneath the failure of the outcomes, and it was the realest thing in my life, and I had nearly missed it because I was so focused on the outcomes that I did not notice the presence, so focused on the answers that I did not notice the God who was there whether or not he answered.

And when I finally noticed, when I finally understood that the being-with-God was the point and not the outcomes,

everything changed, and this is the change I most want to leave you with. I stopped measuring my prayer by whether it worked, and started measuring it, if measuring is even the right word, by whether I was there, present to God, staying in the relationship, keeping the conversation open. And by that measure, my dark prayers, my silent prayers, my unanswered prayers, my prayers that had felt like failures, were not failures at all, were in fact successes, were doing exactly what prayer is for, were keeping me in the presence of the God I was made for, were conducting the relationship that is the point of my existence. The prayer that got no answer had still been with God. The prayer that met only silence had still been in the presence of God. The dark prayer had still been the relationship, still been the communion, still been the thing prayer is for, and I had been calling it failure only because I had mistaken the point.

I want to be careful, one last time, not to let this become a dodge, a way of pretending that the outcomes do not matter and that we should not care about them. The outcomes matter. Your suffering matters. The healing you prayed for, the child you prayed for, the deliverance you prayed for, these matter enormously, and their absence is a real grief, and I have insisted on that grief throughout the book. To say that prayer is for God and not for the outcomes is not to say the outcomes do not matter. It is to say that even when the outcomes are denied, even when the grief of their absence is real and sharp and lasting, prayer is still doing its deepest work, still succeeding at its actual purpose, still keeping you in the presence of a God whose presence is worth more than any outcome, even the outcomes you most desperately wanted. You can grieve the denied outcome with your whole heart and still be sustained by the presence of God, and

prayer is what holds both, the grief and the presence, together, in one honest conversation with a God who receives the grief and gives the presence.

So this is what prayer is for. It is for God. It is for the presence of God, the relationship with God, the communion with God that is the point of your existence and that no silence and no unanswered prayer and no darkness can defeat, because God is present in all of them, and prayer is the practice of that presence, the keeping-company with God through every condition of the soul. And this means that your prayer, your dark, doubting, unanswered, silent prayer, the prayer you have been calling a failure, is not a failure. It is prayer doing exactly what prayer is for. It is you, being with God, in the dark, which is the thing you were made for, the thing that will outlast every outcome, the thing that death itself cannot end. Prayer is for God, and God is with you in the dark, and so your prayer in the dark is not the failure of prayer. It is prayer at its truest, prayer stripped of every reward except the one that matters, prayer that has learned, at last, to want God more than his gifts, which is the only prayer that was ever really prayer at all.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

The Prayer That Is Only a Sigh

*We thought we had to bring God a
speech, and on our worst days we could
not manage even a sentence, and it
turned out a sigh was enough, that God
had always been fluent in the language
we used when we had no language at
all.*

I WANT TO SPEAK, near the end of this book, to the days when you cannot pray at all, not even badly, not even a broken sentence, days when all you can manage is a sigh, a groan, a wordless exhalation of the whole weight of being alive, and I want to tell you that this too is prayer, that the sigh

is prayer, that on the days you have nothing else God receives the sigh as the truest prayer you have prayed all year. Because there are such days. There are days when the grief or the exhaustion or the despair is so total that words are impossible, when you sit down to pray and nothing comes, not a Psalm, not the Lord's Prayer, not a single word of your own, just a heaviness that has no language, and on those days the whole apparatus of prayer that this book has described, the honesty and the lament and the fixed forms and the discipline, all of it feels impossibly far away, because you cannot manage even the smallest piece of it, you can only sit, and be heavy, and sigh.

The Scripture has a word for these days, and it is the word from Romans that stands at the head of this book, the word about the Spirit interceding for us with groanings too deep for words. I said a great deal about that verse in an earlier chapter, about the Spirit praying in us, but I want to return to it here for the specific comfort it offers on the days of the wordless sigh, because it was written for exactly those days. Paul says we do not know what to pray for as we ought, and on the days of the sigh that is literally true, we do not know what to pray, we cannot form the words, we have nothing, and Paul says that this is precisely the condition in which the Spirit takes over, that our very inability to form words is the occasion for the Spirit's wordless intercession, that the groanings too deep for words are not the failure of prayer but the point at which the Spirit's own praying takes up our wordless sighs and makes them into intercession before God. On the days you can only sigh, the Spirit is praying your sigh, translating it, carrying it, making of your wordless heaviness a prayer more perfect than any words you could have found.

This means that the sigh is not the absence of prayer but a form of it, maybe the purest form, because it is the form with the least performance in it, the least of our own contribution, the most complete reliance on the Spirit to do what we cannot. When we pray with words, however honest, there is still some part of us managing the prayer, choosing the words, shaping the expression, and however small that management is, it is still us, still our doing. But the sigh has no management in it. The sigh is what escapes when management has failed entirely, when we have nothing left to shape or choose or perform, when the whole weight of us simply exhales, and in that unmanaged, unshaped, unperformed exhalation, there is a purity that our worded prayers rarely reach, a total helplessness that is, as Hallesby said, the very thing prayer is for, the empty-handed need that draws the God who is drawn not to our fervor but to our helplessness. The sigh is helplessness made audible, and helplessness is the country God most loves to enter, and so the sigh may be nearer to the heart of God than the most eloquent prayer you ever prayed.

I have prayed the prayer that is only a sigh, and I want to tell you about it, because I think the confession will help more than the theology. There was a day, in one of the darkest seasons of my life, when I sat down to pray and discovered that I could not. Not that I did not want to, but that I could not, that the words would not come, that I was too far into the heaviness to form even the simplest prayer, and I sat there in a kind of horror, because prayer had been my lifeline and now even prayer had failed me, even prayer had gone silent, and I thought, this is the end, I have lost even the ability to pray. And all I could do, sitting there, was sigh, a long, heavy, wordless exhalation of everything I was carrying, and I did it

not as a prayer but as a giving-up, a surrender to the impossibility of praying. And it was only later, reading Romans again, that I understood that the sigh had been the prayer, that in the moment I thought I had lost the ability to pray, I had in fact prayed the deepest prayer of my life, that the Spirit had taken my wordless surrender and made it intercession, that my giving-up had been received as a prayer more honest than any I had ever managed with words.

There is a great mercy in this, and I want you to feel its full weight, especially if you are in a season where prayer has become impossible. The mercy is that prayer does not finally depend on your ability to pray. On the days you can pray, pray, with all the honesty and the lament and the fixed forms and the discipline this book has commended. But on the days you cannot pray, when even the smallest word is beyond you, when all you have is a sigh, you have not fallen out of prayer, you have not lost your connection to God, you have not failed, because the Spirit is praying in you, taking your sigh, your groan, your wordless heaviness, and making it into intercession, so that your worst day, your most prayer-less day, the day you could manage nothing but a sigh, is still a day of prayer, still a day in the presence of God, still a day when the conversation continued, carried entirely by the Spirit when you could not carry it yourself. You cannot fall out of prayer, because when you let go, the Spirit holds on, and prays your sigh, and keeps the conversation going in a language you do not even know you are speaking.

So on your worst days, when you have nothing, do not add to your suffering the false guilt of thinking you have failed to pray. Sigh. Let the whole weight of you exhale toward God, wordlessly, helplessly, with nothing to offer and nothing to say, and know that the sigh is heard, that the Spirit is praying

it, that God is fluent in the language of sighs and groanings and wordless heaviness, that he has always been fluent in it, that it may be his favorite language because it is the language of total helplessness and total helplessness is where his grace most loves to work. The prayer that is only a sigh is not a lesser prayer. It is prayer stripped down to its absolute essence, prayer with nothing left but the turning of a helpless soul toward God, and God receives it, and the Spirit prays it, and it is enough, more than enough, because it was never your eloquence that made prayer prayer, but only the turning, and even in the sigh, even in the wordless exhalation of your worst day, you are turning toward God, and the turning is the prayer, and the turning is received, and you have not failed, you have prayed, in the only language your soul had left, and God has heard.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Learning to Pray Again

*We had prayed for years and stopped,
and thought the door was closed for
good, and it was not, and the coming
back was easier and harder than we
feared, easier because God had never
left, harder because we had to admit
we had.*

I WANT TO WRITE a chapter for the person who used to pray and stopped, because this book has been mostly for the person still struggling to pray, still in the conversation however dark, and I have not yet spoken directly to the one who left, who used to pray and does not anymore, who let the drift I described earlier carry them all the way out, and who is reading this book from outside the practice, wondering

whether they could ever come back. If that is you, this chapter is for you, and I want to say, before anything else, that you can come back, that the door is not closed, that no matter how long it has been or how completely you stopped, the coming back is possible, and I have watched people do it who thought they never could.

Let me first take seriously how hard it is to come back, because the encouragement is worthless if it does not reckon with the difficulty. When you have stopped praying for a long time, coming back is not simply a matter of starting again where you left off, because things have changed in the interval, and the changes are real obstacles. There is the awkwardness, the sense that you have been away so long that you no longer know how, that prayer has become a foreign country whose language you have forgotten. There is the guilt, the sense that you abandoned God and have no right to come back, that you forfeited the relationship by your neglect and cannot simply pick it up again. There is the fear that it will not work, that you will try to pray again and find only the same silence that drove you away, and that the second failure will be worse than the first, will confirm that the door really is closed. And there is the pride, the difficulty of admitting that you left, that you were wrong to leave, that you need to come back, which is a humbling thing and pride does not like to be humbled. These obstacles are real, and I will not pretend them away, and coming back means facing them.

But here is what makes the coming back possible despite all the obstacles, and it is the thing I most want you to hear. God never left. The whole time you were away, the whole time you had stopped praying, God did not stop being present, did not stop loving you, did not close the door, did not write you

off. The parable Jesus told about the son who left and returned is the deepest picture of this, and I want you to notice the detail that matters most. When the son who had left came back, the father was watching for him, saw him while he was still a long way off, and ran to him, ran, an old man running, and embraced him before the son could even finish his prepared speech of repentance. The father had been watching the whole time. The father had never given up on the son's return. The door had never been closed. And this is the truth about your coming back to prayer, that God has been watching for you the whole time you were away, that he sees you while you are still a long way off, that he is not waiting behind a closed door for you to earn your way back but is running toward you the moment you turn, so that the coming back is not a long hard climb up to a God who has to be persuaded to receive you, but a turning toward a God who is already running to meet you.

So how do you actually come back? Not with a grand return, not with a dramatic recommitment, not with a perfect prayer that makes up for all the ones you missed. You come back the way you would come back to any relationship you had let lapse, simply, humbly, with the truth. You say to God, plainly, I stopped. I left. I have not prayed in a long time, and I do not entirely know why, and I do not know if I know how to do this anymore, and I am here, turning back, not because I have become a better person but because I want to come back, and if you are there, here I am. That is the whole prayer of return, and it is enough, because it is honest, because it is a turning, and the turning is all that is required, because God is already running. You do not have to explain yourself fully, or repent perfectly, or promise never to leave again, or feel the right feelings. You have only to turn, with the truth, and let

God do the running, which he is already doing, which he has been ready to do since the moment you left.

I want to speak specifically to the guilt, because it is the obstacle that stops the most people, the sense that you have no right to come back after leaving, that your neglect disqualifies you. This guilt is understandable and it is also a lie, and I want to name it as a lie so you can stop letting it keep you away. The guilt tells you that God is angry at your leaving, that he holds your absence against you, that you must somehow make up for the lost time before you can be received. But the father in the parable was not angry. He did not hold the son's absence against him. He did not require the son to make up for the lost time. He ran, and embraced, and celebrated, and the son's carefully prepared speech of unworthiness was interrupted by an embrace, was rendered unnecessary by a love that had never stopped. Your guilt is real as a feeling and false as a fact, because the God you are afraid to return to is not angry but longing, not holding your absence against you but watching for your return, not requiring you to earn your way back but running to meet you, and the guilt that keeps you away is keeping you from the very embrace that would heal it.

And I want to say, finally, that the coming back is not a one-time event but the beginning of a practice, and that you should expect it to be imperfect, to falter, to require coming back again, and that this is normal and not a sign of failure. You will come back, and pray for a while, and perhaps drift again, and have to come back again, and this cycle of drifting and returning is not the failure of the spiritual life but, for many people, the actual shape of it, the ordinary rhythm of a real relationship with God across a real and messy life. Do not expect that coming back once will fix everything, that you will

pray perfectly from now on, that you will never drift again. Expect, instead, that you will come back, and falter, and come back again, and that each coming back is received with the same running embrace as the first, that God does not tire of your returning, that there is no limit to the number of times you can come home, because the father in the parable would have run just as fast on the son's second return, and his tenth, and his hundredth, because the love that runs to meet the returning son is not a love that keeps count, but a love that simply, always, runs. So come back. However long it has been, however many times you have left, however awkward and guilty and uncertain you feel. Turn, with the truth, toward the God who is already running, and come home, and know that you will be received, not because you deserve it, but because he never stopped watching the road.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

The Hope That Does Not Depend on the Answer

We had pinned our hope on the answer, and the answer did not come, and we thought hope was finished, and then we found a deeper hope underneath, one that did not need the answer, one that could survive even the grave, and we understood that this was the hope prayer had been quietly building the whole time.

I WANT TO END the body of this book, before the conclusion, with a chapter on hope, because everything I have written

could be misread as counsel for endurance without hope, a grim doctrine of staying in the conversation with no expectation of anything, and that is not what I mean, and I do not want to leave you there. There is hope in this book, real hope, but it is a particular kind of hope, a hope that has been through the fire, a hope that no longer depends on the answer, and I want to describe it carefully, because it is the hope that can sustain a life of prayer in the dark, and the ordinary kind of hope, the kind that depends on getting what we ask for, cannot.

The ordinary kind of hope, the kind most of us start with, is a hope pinned to outcomes. We hope that we will get the thing we are praying for, that the situation will improve, that the answer will come, and this hope is real and it is not wrong, and Scripture permits us to hope for the things we ask for. But this hope has a fatal vulnerability, which is that it depends entirely on the outcome, and when the outcome does not come, when the answer is no or never, this hope collapses, because it had nothing to rest on but the outcome, and the outcome failed it. The person whose whole hope is pinned to outcomes is a person whose hope can be destroyed by a single unanswered prayer, and since unanswered prayer is a certainty in every human life, a hope pinned to outcomes is a hope certain, sooner or later, to be destroyed. This is why so many people lose hope, and lose faith along with it, because they built their hope on the answer, and the answer did not come, and the hope had nowhere else to stand.

But there is a deeper hope, underneath the hope pinned to outcomes, and prayer in the dark is the very thing that uncovers it, because prayer in the dark strips away the hope pinned to outcomes and forces us to find, if we can, a hope

that does not depend on the answer. This deeper hope is not pinned to any particular outcome. It is pinned to God himself, to the character of God, to the promises of God, to the future God has secured, and because it rests on God and not on outcomes, it cannot be destroyed by any unanswered prayer, because God remains even when the answer does not come. This is the hope that Paul describes, the hope that does not put us to shame, the hope that is an anchor for the soul, and it is an anchor precisely because it is fixed not to our shifting circumstances but to the unshakable God, so that when the storms of unanswered prayer and dark silence sweep away every outcome we hoped for, the anchor holds, because it was never fixed to the outcomes but to God, who does not move.

Where does this deeper hope finally rest? It rests, in the end, on the resurrection, on the promise that God will make all things new, that the dead will be raised, that every tear will be wiped away, that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing to the glory that will be revealed. This is the ground of the hope that does not depend on the answer, because even if every prayer you pray in this life goes unanswered, even if you go to your grave with your deepest requests denied, the resurrection stands, the making-new stands, the final setting-right of all things stands, and this final hope cannot be denied you by any unanswered prayer, because it does not depend on the answers coming in this life, but on the promise of God for the life to come. The mother who prayed thirty years for a son who never returned, and died with the prayer unanswered, has a hope that her death did not end, because the God she prayed to is the God of resurrection, and the story is not over at the grave, and the setting-right of all things, including the unanswered prayers, is still to come.

I want to be careful, because this hope for the life to come can be misused as a way of dismissing the sufferings of this life, of telling the suffering to simply wait for heaven and stop troubling us with their present pain, and that is a cruelty I have refused throughout this book and will not embrace now. The hope of resurrection does not cancel the grief of this life, does not make the unanswered prayer stop hurting, does not tell you to ignore your present suffering in favor of a future consolation. It exists alongside the grief, underneath the grief, as a deeper current running beneath the surface pain, so that you can grieve your unanswered prayer with your whole heart and still be held, at the deepest level, by a hope that your grief cannot reach, a hope fixed to the resurrection, a hope that says this is not the end, that the God who seems to have denied you in this life has secured for you a future in which every denial will be answered, every wound healed, every tear wiped away, every unanswered prayer taken up into a setting-right so complete that we cannot now imagine it. The grief and the hope coexist, both real, both honest, and the hope does not diminish the grief but sustains you through it.

This is the hope that prayer in the dark builds, slowly, without our noticing, the whole time we think it is failing. Every prayer prayed into silence, every request denied, every dark season endured in prayer, is quietly doing this work, weaning our hope off its dependence on outcomes and fixing it, more and more, on God himself and on the future he has secured, until we arrive, if we stay in the conversation long enough, at a hope that no unanswered prayer can destroy, because it was never pinned to the answers, but to the God who remains, and to the resurrection he has promised. This is the deepest fruit of prayer in the dark, this unshakable

hope, and it can only be grown in the dark, because it is only in the dark, only through the failure of the outcomes we hoped for, that our hope is forced off the outcomes and onto God, and a hope that has been through that fire, that has survived the death of every outcome and found God still there and the resurrection still promised, is a hope that can survive anything, even death, especially death, because it is fixed to the one who conquered death and promised to raise us with him.

So I do not leave you without hope. I leave you with a better hope than the one you came with, a hope that does not depend on the answer, a hope that can survive the unanswered prayer and the dark silence and the denied request, because it is fixed not to the outcomes but to God and to the resurrection, an anchor for the soul, sure and steadfast, that holds when every outcome is swept away. Hope in God, the Psalmist told his own downcast soul, over and over, hope in God, for I shall again praise him, and notice that his hope was in God, not in the outcome, in God himself, whom he would again praise, and this was a hope he could hold even in the pit, even in the dark, even when everything else was gone, because it was fixed to the one thing that cannot be taken away. Hope in God. Not in the answer. In God. And that hope, fixed to God and to the resurrection, will hold you through every dark night of prayer, through every unanswered request, through the grave itself, into the morning that has been promised, when the God you prayed to in the dark will be seen at last face to face, and every prayer you ever prayed into the silence will be answered in a single look from the one who was there, listening, the whole time.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

The Small Prayers of an Ordinary Week

We waited for the grand prayer, the mountaintop prayer, the prayer that would change everything, and it did not come, and meanwhile the small prayers of an ordinary week, the ones we barely noticed, were quietly saving our lives.

I HAVE WRITTEN A great deal in this book about prayer in the extremities, the dark night, the great grief, the long unanswered petition, the crisis of doubt, and there is a danger in this, the danger of leaving you thinking that real prayer happens only in the dramatic moments, only at the

edges, only in the depths, and that the ordinary week, with its small concerns and its minor prayers, is somehow beneath the dignity of the subject. So I want to spend a chapter on the small prayers of an ordinary week, the unremarkable prayers that most of us actually pray most of the time, because I have come to believe that these small ordinary prayers, precisely because they are small and ordinary, are the ones that do the quiet saving work in a life, and that a person who can only pray in the extremities has missed the greater part of what prayer is.

Think about the actual prayers of an actual ordinary week, not the dramatic ones but the small ones, the ones you barely notice yourself praying. The quick prayer for help before a difficult conversation. The whispered thanks when something goes right. The prayer for a child before they leave for school. The prayer over a meal, however rote. The prayer in the car, in traffic, for patience, for the person who cut you off, for the day ahead. The prayer at the end of a long day, exhausted, a few words before sleep. The prayer for a friend who is struggling, offered in passing. The prayer of frustration, the prayer of gratitude, the prayer of a moment's fear, all the small prayers scattered through an ordinary week like seeds, most of them unremarkable, none of them dramatic, all of them quietly turning the moments of the week toward God. These are the prayers that most of us actually pray, and I want to tell you that they matter, that they are doing something, that the accumulation of these small ordinary prayers across the weeks and the years is building a life turned toward God far more surely than any single dramatic prayer ever could.

Because here is the truth about the spiritual life that the

emphasis on the dramatic obscures. A life is not made mostly of dramatic moments. A life is made mostly of ordinary weeks, ordinary days, ordinary hours, and the shape of a life is determined far more by what fills the ordinary time than by how we handle the rare crisis. And the same is true of a life of prayer. A life of prayer is not made mostly of dramatic prayers in the depths, because the depths are rare, thank God, and most of life is not spent in them. A life of prayer is made mostly of the small ordinary prayers of the ordinary week, and the shape of your life with God is determined far more by the accumulation of these small prayers than by how you pray in the occasional crisis. The person who prays the small prayers faithfully, all week, every week, is building a life turned toward God, a habit of turning, a reflex of the soul that reaches for God in the small moments, and this reflex, built by ten thousand small ordinary prayers, is what will be there for you in the crisis when it comes, because you cannot suddenly, in the depths, become a person who turns toward God if you have not been becoming that person all along, in the small ordinary prayers of the ordinary weeks.

I want to honor the small prayers specifically because we are tempted to despise them, to think them too trivial to matter, to feel that praying about small things, about traffic and meals and minor frustrations, is somehow beneath God, that we should save prayer for the big things and handle the small things ourselves. But this is exactly backwards, and it misunderstands the relationship. A child does not save conversation with a loving parent only for the big things. A child talks to a loving parent about everything, the small things and the big things alike, the scraped knee and the school day and the funny thing that happened and the minor fear, and it is precisely this constant small talk, this ongoing

conversation about the ordinary stuff of life, that makes the relationship warm and close and real. The relationship that only comes alive in crises is a distant relationship. The relationship that hums along in the small ordinary talk of ordinary days is a close one. And your relationship with God is the same. If you only pray in the crises, your relationship with God will be a crisis relationship, distant in the ordinary times, activated only in the depths. But if you pray the small prayers, all week, about the ordinary stuff, the traffic and the meals and the minor fears and the small gratitudes, your relationship with God becomes a close one, a warm one, a constant conversation that hums along through the ordinary days and is therefore already close and warm and real when the crisis comes.

There is a discipline of the small prayers that I want to commend, and it is simply the discipline of turning the moments of the ordinary week toward God as they come, without waiting for a special time or a special mood or a special subject. When something good happens, however small, turn it toward God with a word of thanks, in the moment, without stopping your life. When something is hard, however small, turn it toward God with a word for help, in the moment. When you think of someone, turn the thought toward God with a word for them. When you are afraid, or frustrated, or grateful, or tired, turn it toward God, in the moment, with the small prayer that fits it, and do not despise the smallness, do not feel you need a grander prayer, but let the small prayer be enough, because the small prayer, turning the small moment toward God, is doing the quiet work of building a life turned toward God, one small moment at a time. This is the discipline of the small prayers, and it is available in any life, however busy, however ordinary,

because it does not require special time or special conditions, only the willingness to turn the moments toward God as they come.

And I want to tell you, from my own life, that it is these small prayers, more than any dramatic one, that have quietly saved me over the years. When I look back over a life of prayer, I do not find that the dramatic prayers, the ones in the depths, are what sustained me, though they were real and they mattered. What sustained me, what carried me, what kept me turned toward God through the long ordinary stretches that make up most of a life, was the accumulation of the small prayers, the daily unremarkable turning of the ordinary moments toward God, the constant low hum of a conversation that never quite stopped, that continued through the traffic and the meals and the small fears and the minor gratitudes, and that was therefore already there, already close, already warm, when the crises came. The small prayers of the ordinary weeks were the foundation, laid quietly, invisibly, one small prayer at a time, on which everything else was built, and without them the dramatic prayers would have had nothing to stand on, would have been the desperate cries of a stranger rather than the anguished prayers of a child who knew, from ten thousand small conversations, that his Father was there.

So do not wait for the grand prayer, the mountaintop prayer, the prayer that will change everything. Pray the small prayers of the ordinary week, and pray them faithfully, and do not despise their smallness, because they are the ones that build the life, that hum the constant conversation, that keep you turned toward God through the long ordinary stretches, that quietly save you, one small moment at a time. The dramatic prayers will come when they come, in the depths, in

the crises, and you will pray them, and they will matter. But most of your life is not the depths, most of your life is the ordinary week, and most of your prayer will be, and should be, the small prayers of the ordinary week, and these are not the lesser prayers, the throat-clearing before the real thing. They are the real thing, the constant conversation, the ongoing relationship, the daily turning of an ordinary life toward the God who is present in the ordinary as much as in the extraordinary, in the traffic as much as in the crisis, in the small prayer as much as in the great one, waiting, in every moment of every ordinary week, to be turned toward, and to turn, in return, toward you.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

The Prayer We Pray with Our Lives

*We thought prayer was the words we
said and the silence in between, and
slowly we understood that the deepest
prayer was the life itself, that a life
turned toward God was a prayer no
words could equal.*

I HAVE WRITTEN THIS whole book about prayer as a conversation, words and silence, honesty and lament, and this is true and I stand by it. But there is a dimension of prayer I have not yet named directly, and it is the largest one, and I want to name it before the conclusion, because without it the picture is incomplete. The deepest prayer is not finally the words we say or even the silence we keep. The deepest

prayer is the life we live. A life turned toward God, offered to God, lived in the presence of God, is itself a prayer, a prayer larger and truer than any words, and the words we pray are meant to be, in the end, the concentrated expression of a life that is itself a continual prayer.

Paul said something that points at this, when he urged the Romans to present their bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which he called their spiritual worship, their true and proper act of worship. He was saying that worship, and prayer is at the heart of worship, is not finally a matter of words and rituals but of the offering of the whole self, the whole life, the body itself, presented to God, so that the real worship, the real prayer, is the life laid down, the self offered, the whole of one's living turned into an offering to God. This means that your prayer is not confined to the times you stop and say words to God, but extends to the whole of your life, so that the way you treat your family, the way you do your work, the way you spend your money, the way you love your neighbor, the way you bear your suffering, all of it is prayer, all of it is worship, all of it is either offered to God or withheld from him, and the words you pray are meant to gather up and express the life that is itself the deeper prayer.

I have known people whose lives were prayers, and they have taught me more about prayer than any book, including this one. I have known a woman who prayed with words, yes, but whose whole life was a prayer, whose every act of quiet service, whose every patient bearing of hardship, whose every small kindness to the difficult and the overlooked, was an offering to God, a prayer prayed with her hands and her days rather than her mouth, and her life was more eloquent before God than any words could have been. I have known a

man dying, who could barely speak, whose whole prayer at the end was simply the way he died, patiently, trustingly, with love for the people around him and peace toward the God he was going to meet, and his dying was a prayer, a prayer prayed with his last breaths not in words but in the shape of a life offered to God all the way to the end. These lives were prayers, and they showed me that the deepest prayer is not what we say but what we are, not our words but our lives, offered to God.

This does not diminish the words, and I do not want you to hear it as a way of dismissing the practice of verbal prayer that I have spent this whole book commending. The words matter, the honest words and the lament and the fixed prayers and the small prayers of the ordinary week, they matter, and I have urged them all on you. But the words are meant to serve the life, to express it and to shape it, to gather up the whole offering of a life into concentrated moments of turning toward God, and a life of verbal prayer that does not issue in a life offered to God is a hollow thing, words without the life they were meant to express. The Pharisees prayed many words, and Jesus condemned them, not because they prayed words but because their words were not the expression of lives offered to God, were in fact a cover for lives turned away from God, lives of pride and greed and hardness, so that their many words of prayer were a lie, contradicted by the prayer of their lives, which was prayed toward themselves and not toward God.

So the question prayer finally asks of us is not only what do you say to God but what do you offer God, what is the prayer of your whole life, in what direction is your living turned. And this question searches us more deeply than any question about our verbal prayers, because it is possible to

pray many words while living a life turned away from God, and it is possible, though harder, to live a life turned toward God even when the words are scarce, even in the dark, even when the verbal prayer has gone silent. The person in the dark, whose verbal prayers have failed, who can barely say a word to God, may yet be praying the deepest prayer of all with their life, with the way they keep loving in the dark, keep serving in the dark, keep bearing their suffering with faith in the dark, keep turning their whole life toward a God they cannot feel, and this life-prayer, prayed in the dark without words, may be more pleasing to God than all the eloquent verbal prayers of people whose lives are turned elsewhere.

This is a great comfort for the person in the dark, and I want to leave it with you as we approach the end. If your verbal prayers have failed, if you can barely say a word to God, if the conversation in words has gone silent, you may yet be praying, with your life, the deepest prayer there is. The way you keep going in the dark, the way you keep loving your family when you feel nothing, the way you keep doing your work faithfully when God seems absent, the way you keep showing up, keep serving, keep bearing your suffering without giving up on God, all of this is prayer, the prayer of a life turned toward God even in the dark, and it is heard, and it is pleasing to God, and it may be the truest prayer you have ever prayed, precisely because it is prayed without the reward of feeling, without the words, in the dark, with your life alone. Your life in the dark, turned toward God, is a prayer, and it is enough, and God receives it, and it is more eloquent before him than all the words you cannot find.

So let your life be your prayer, especially when the words fail. Offer your whole self to God, your body, your days, your work, your love, your suffering, and let this offering be the

prayer that the words were always meant to serve. And in the dark, when the words fail, when you can barely say anything to God, keep offering your life, keep turning your living toward God, keep loving and serving and bearing and showing up, and know that this life-prayer, prayed in the dark without words, is heard, and received, and pleasing to God, and that you are praying, with your life, even when you cannot pray with your mouth, the deepest prayer there is, the prayer of a life laid down before God, which no words could ever equal, and which God receives, in the dark, as the truest worship a person can offer, the offering of a whole life turned toward him, in the light and in the dark, all the way to the end.

CHAPTER FORTY

A Rule of Prayer for the Rest of Us

*We wanted freedom and got chaos,
prayed only when we felt like it and
therefore almost never, until we
discovered that a rule was not the
enemy of freedom in prayer but the
only thing that ever made it possible.*

I WANT TO END the chapters, before the conclusion, with something practical, because I have spent this book arguing against formulas and I do not want to leave you with nothing to actually do, as though the only counsel were to feel your way through the dark without any structure at all. There is a difference between a formula and a rule, and I want to draw it clearly, because the difference is the difference between the

vending machine I have spent the book dismantling and the sustainable prayer life I actually want to leave you with. A formula is a technique that promises a result, insert the correct prayer and receive the desired outcome, and I have rejected it. A rule is something else entirely. A rule is simply a structure, a shape, a rhythm you commit to, not because it guarantees a result but because it makes the practice possible, the way the banks of a river do not guarantee where the water goes but make it possible for the water to go anywhere at all instead of spreading into a shapeless swamp.

The great tradition of Christian prayer has always known that prayer needs a rule, and the word rule here does not mean a law that constrains you but a pattern that supports you, the way a trellis supports a vine, giving it something to climb that it could not climb on its own. The monastic communities built their whole lives around a rule of prayer, fixed times, fixed forms, a rhythm that held them whether or not they felt like praying, and this was not the enemy of their freedom but the foundation of it, because it freed them from the exhausting and impossible task of deciding, moment by moment, whether to pray, and instead gave them a settled structure within which prayer simply happened, reliably, day after day, regardless of mood. We have lost this, most of us, in our suspicion of anything that smacks of ritual or obligation, and in losing it we have made our prayer entirely dependent on our feelings, so that we pray only when we feel like it, which is to say almost never, because the feeling is unreliable and the seasons of not feeling like it are long.

So I want to commend to you, plainly, a rule of prayer, a simple one, one for the rest of us, the ones whose prayers hit the ceiling and who are not sure anyone is listening. Choose a

time, once a day at least, and keep it, whether or not you feel like it. Choose a place, and return to it. Begin with the Lord's Prayer, slowly, letting the words do their work. Pray a Psalm, working through them in order over time, praying the hard ones and the dark ones along with the bright ones, letting them enlarge you. Bring your own honest words, whatever they are, the anger and the numbness and the requests and the doubt, holding nothing back. Pray for others by name, lifting them up when you cannot lift yourself. And end in silence, simply being with God for a few minutes without words, without agenda, without requiring anything of the encounter. That is a rule, a simple one, and it will hold you through the dark seasons when your own feelings would have carried you away from prayer entirely, because it does not depend on your feelings, it depends only on your keeping the appointment, and the keeping of the appointment is a thing you can do even when you feel nothing.

The point of the rule is not that it works in the vending-machine sense, and I want to be clear about that even now, at the end. The rule will not guarantee that you feel God, or hear an answer, or get the outcome you are praying for. It guarantees nothing except that you will show up, reliably, in the presence of God, day after day, and showing up, reliably, in the presence of God, is the whole of what we can do, and it is enough, because the rest is God's to do, in his time, in his way, often in the dark, often below the level of anything we can feel. The rule is simply the banks of the river, the trellis for the vine, the structure that makes the practice possible, and within that structure, held by it, freed by it, you can pray in the dark for a lifetime, through the silences and the unanswered prayers and the numbness and the doubt, because the rule holds when the feelings fail, and the holding

is what a prayer life in the dark most needs.

And here is the freedom the rule gives, which is the opposite of what we fear. We fear that a rule will make prayer mechanical, dead, obligatory, a duty rather than a relationship. But the truth is the reverse. The rule frees prayer from the tyranny of the feelings, frees it from the exhausting requirement that we generate the right mood before we can pray, frees it to become the reliable ongoing conversation that a real relationship needs, humming along through the ordinary days and holding fast through the dark ones. The married couple who only spent time together when they felt like it would have a thin and fragile marriage. The couple whose life together has a rhythm, a structure, reliable times of being together that do not depend on the mood of the moment, have a marriage that can weather the seasons when the feelings fade, and it is the structure, the rule, that carries them through to the far side where the feelings return. The rule of prayer is the same, the structure that carries the relationship through the seasons when the feelings fade, and it is not the enemy of intimacy with God but the very thing that makes a durable intimacy possible.

So take a rule, a simple one, and keep it, and let it hold you. Do not wait to feel like praying, because the feeling is unreliable and the waiting is a slow closing of the door. Keep the appointment, in the light and in the dark, whether or not anything happens, whether or not you feel God, whether or not your prayers seem to work, and let the rule be the banks that hold the river of your prayer through a whole life, through the droughts and the floods, through the silences and the answers, through everything. The rule will not make prayer work. Nothing makes prayer work, because prayer is not a machine. But the rule will keep you in the conversation,

day after day, through the dark, which is the whole of what I have asked of you in this book, and it is the one thing you can actually do, and it is enough, because keeping the conversation open, in the dark, held by a simple faithful rule, is not the failure of prayer. It is the life of prayer, the only one available to the rest of us, and it is a good life, and it can be had, starting today, by anyone willing to choose a time, and keep it, and turn toward God, whether or not anyone seems to be listening.

CONCLUSION

Keep the Conversation Open

I HAVE WRITTEN A long book to say a short thing, and now, at the end, I want to say the short thing plainly, so that if you forget everything else, you remember this. Prayer is not a technique that works. It is a conversation you stay in. And you can stay in it even in the dark, even in the silence, even when you are not sure anyone is listening, and staying in it, in the dark, is not the failure of prayer but its truest form.

I came to God from atheism, a grown man who had believed there was no one there, and I have told you that coming to faith did not end my suspicion that prayer might be a man talking to the ceiling, but only raised the stakes of it. I have told you the truth about my own prayers, that many of them hit the ceiling, that I have prayed for years into silence, that I have stood over hospital beds and in pulpits not sure anyone was on the other end. I have refused, in this book, to sell you a prayer that works, a formula, a method, a guarantee, because those things are lies, and the people who believe them are set up for a crueler disappointment than the

honest darkness I have tried to describe. What I have offered you instead is smaller and truer. Not a prayer that works. A God who can be spoken to in the dark, and a conversation you are allowed to stay in even when you cannot hear the other side.

I have tried to give you back what I think was stolen from you. The honesty of the Psalms, including the ugly ones, the laments and the accusations and the raging, so that you would know that God can take the truth of your heart and does not need you to protect his feelings with polite dead prayers. The permission to be angry at God, to bring your fury into the conversation rather than letting it fester outside it. The permission to be numb, and to pray numb, and to know that the numb prayer prayed without feeling is not a lesser prayer but a purer one. The fixed prayers and the Psalms and the small prayers of the ordinary week, so that when your own words fail you would have a well to draw from in the desert. The truth that the Spirit prays in you when you cannot pray, that on the days you can manage only a sigh, the sigh is heard and the Spirit prays it. And the deepest truth of all, that prayer is for God, that it was always for God, that even the dark prayer, the silent prayer, the unanswered prayer, is prayer succeeding at its actual purpose, which is not the outcome but the presence, not the answer but the God who is there whether or not he answers.

I have not explained away the hard things, and I will not begin now, at the end. The silence of God is real, and I have not told you it is secretly not silence. Unanswered prayer is real, and I have not told you that all prayers are secretly answered if you look at them right. Some prayers get the final no, the one with no explanation, and you may go to your grave not understanding it, and I have refused, throughout this

book, to lie to you about that, because the lie would be a cruelty and you have been lied to enough. What I have told you instead is that the God who is silent may be nearer than the God who speaks, that the dark night may be intimacy and not abandonment, that the unanswered prayer may be the very place the deepest change happens, that the God who withholds the answer does not withhold himself, and that the conversation, kept open in the dark, is itself the life with God, not the means to it but the thing itself.

So here is what I ask of you, at the end, and it is the only thing I have asked all along. Keep the conversation open. Do not close your mouth for good. Do not let the drift carry you all the way out. When you cannot pray with words, pray with a sigh, or with your body, or with your life. When your own words fail, pray the words of the Psalms and the church. When you are angry, pray angry. When you are numb, pray numb. When you are not sure anyone is there, pray anyway, on the outside chance that there is, the chance I staked my whole life on, the chance that turned a furniture-talking former atheist into a man who cannot honestly account for himself without reference to someone on the other end. Keep the conversation open, in the light and in the dark, in the answered seasons and the unanswered ones, and let the staying itself be your prayer, because the staying is the faith, and the faith is not finally your grip on God but his grip on you, and his grip does not loosen when you rage, or doubt, or go silent, or nearly quit.

I began with the prayers that hit the ceiling, and I want to end there, because I do not want you to think I have talked my way to a place where the ceiling is gone. The ceiling is still there. My prayers still hit it, some days. I still, some nights, at two in the morning, wonder if anyone is listening. But I have

learned to keep talking anyway, and I have learned, over a long time, that the wondering is not the enemy of prayer, that the pretending was the enemy all along, and that a prayer prayed honestly into the silence, by a person not sure anyone is there, is a prayer that reaches, somehow, further than all the confident prayers of people for whom it was always easy. The dark is not the absence of prayer. The dark is where prayer is finally purified of everything except the bare turning of a soul toward God, and that turning, in the dark, with no reward, is the deepest prayer there is, and it is the one I am still learning to pray, and it is the one I leave you with.

Talk to God when you are not sure anyone is listening. Stay in the conversation in the dark. And trust, not that it will work, but that the one you are talking to is there, on the other side of the silence, listening, praying in you what you cannot pray yourself, holding the line open from his end when you have nearly let go of yours, present in the dark in a way you cannot feel and can only, someday, look back and recognize, the way the disciples on the road looked back and said, did not our hearts burn within us while he talked with us on the road. He is talking with you on the road, in the dark, whether or not you recognize him, and one day you will, and until then, keep walking, and keep talking, and do not close your mouth for good, because the conversation, kept open in the dark, is the whole of the life with God, and it can be had, right now, tonight, in the silence, by you, with nothing but the willingness to turn toward him and say the true thing into the dark. Say it. He is listening. Even now. Especially now. In the dark.